

APHRODITE  OMNIMEDIA

BESTSELLING AUTHOR
KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

**UNDERCOVER
WIFE
RUSSIAN
ROULETTE**

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WIFE**



undercover wife: russian roulette

kirsten mcurran



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UNDERCOVER WIFE: RUSSIAN ROULETTE

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previously

Madison Sinclair was one of the CIA's best. Then she chose love over the field, traded covert ops for carpool lanes, and spent sixteen years behind a desk in Langley. She told herself she didn't miss it.

She was wrong.

When Deputy Director Bristow summons her, Madison is pulled back into a world she thought she'd left behind. A Russian hacker collective called Glacier Flame has built **Null:Echo**, a quantum cipher key capable of cracking any system on earth, instantly and without a trace. The buyer? Kharabat, one of the world's most dangerous state sponsors of terror. The CIA has one shot to stop the deal, and it needs Madison to take it. The target, Prince Zaydan, has a very specific weakness: older, married women. Madison fits the profile perfectly. So she's handed a new identity, a new "husband," and a mission that will push every limit she has.

Her husband? Damien Kane — her former partner, former lover, and the man she walked away from sixteen years ago when she chose Charles. Their last mission together nearly killed them both. This one might finish the job.

As David and Michelle Richardson, Madison and Kane infiltrate **Nox Venari**, an elite, international sex club where the Null:Echo deal is set to go

down. Madison must seduce the prince, neutralize the threat, and keep her marriage—and her sanity—intact.

The operation runs flawlessly. Zaydan is hooked. All they need to do is wait for the final piece to fall into place. Unfortunately, that final piece could prove deadly.

The Russian selling Null:Echo is one Sergei Reznikov, the son of a man Madison and Kane left for dead in Moscow sixteen years earlier. Anatoly Reznikov is very much alive, and if his son recognizes Madison, it's game over. She'll be lucky to escape with her life. Operation **Scarlet Phantom** just became much more dangerous than anyone could have anticipated.

With the stakes too high to abort, Madison goes back in. But the deeper she falls into Zaydan's world, the more the lines begin to blur. The thrill is real. The desire is real. And the woman she's becoming—the one Zaydan is carefully, deliberately shaping—feels disturbingly like someone she recognizes.

Then a single text from her husband shatters everything.

All the books in the *Undercover Wife* series can be found by clicking [this link](#).

one

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“Are you getting out, ma’am?” the driver asked. He was only in his twenties, but Madison still chafed at being called *ma’am*. That was the least of her worries.

She stared at the home she’d shared with Charles for the last twelve years and wondered if she had a place in it anymore. Everyone who took a job with the Agency knew that it would ask for sacrifices. The job could take everything from you. But the only way to do the work was to believe that it wouldn’t happen to you.

Madison feared the job had finally destroyed her life. The Agency had asked too much, and she hadn’t said no when she should have.

“Ma’am?”

“Oh, yeah, sorry.”

Grabbing her bag, she slid out of the backseat and walked up the long driveway to her house, doing everything she could to keep her gait normal. Her night at Nox Venari had left her incredibly sore. Charles’s car was in the driveway. He should have been in church with the kids on Sunday morning. She’d hoped to have time to pull herself together before she had to face him.

Madison’s world came crashing down very late on Friday night—or early Saturday morning, depending on the point of view. Her personal

phone was left behind at the condo in Philadelphia, and when she switched it on, there was a single text.

A photograph of the packet of Plan B pills the Agency gave her at the start of the mission. She stared at the image and her heart seized in her chest. Breathing was impossible.

She started typing out a frantic reply, but didn't press send. It was only an hour or so before sunup. Charles slept with his phone on the nightstand, always worried about an emergency. She didn't want to wake him with a lame, clichéd message.

It's not what you think.

Of course, it was what he thought. There was only one reason for a married woman to have abortion pills behind her husband's back. And Madison *was* fucking someone else. Did the nuance that she was doing it for her country—to keep their family safe—matter? That was if she could explain it at all. Everything about Operation Scarlet Phantom was classified at the highest level.

Ultimately, Madison didn't text Charles at all. She didn't want to call him and try to have that discussion in the condo with the rest of the team around. And she couldn't do it by text. She had to see her husband. Because the team was so close to a breakthrough, that had to wait until Sunday. Even with her marriage crumbling, the mission had to come first.

She found Charles in his study. The windows faced west, leaving the room dim on a gloomy Sunday morning. It had been raining all night, and the sun hadn't found a way through the clouds yet. She reached for the light switch when she walked in, but hesitated. If Charles wanted the light on, it would have been on. His face was in shadow. She couldn't tell if he was looking at her.

"I was starting to think you'd run off to start a new life." His voice was low and flat.

“I couldn’t get away. Work was crazy this weekend. I wanted to call you, but I didn’t have a minute to think.”

“Yeah, at the UN. Handling those VIP requests for the State Department is such a demanding job.”

Madison had to stop and breathe. She’d never heard that tone of sarcastic contempt from her husband before. He was done pretending that she had some boring job at State.

“Charles...”

“Don’t bother if you’re going to keep lying to me, Maddy.”

“There are things I can’t tell you. You’ve always known that. Accepted it.”

He opened his desk drawer, took out the box of Plan B pills, and tossed them onto his desk. “Do those things involve you fucking someone else? Does whatever super-secret thing you do for the government require you to have an affair? By the way, I noticed it’s not a full box.”

It was not. Madison had taken one on Saturday morning, right after she looked at his text. She only carried a couple of doses at a time on her trips north. The box had been hidden at the back of a drawer. The crazy thing was that the photo he sent had her so spooked that she almost didn’t take the pill. That was a chance she could not take, even at forty-eight.

Zaydan had literally been fucking her for hours. She swallowed him once, but he came inside her at least three times. Even with diminishing returns, that was *a lot* of cum. She’d gently touched herself when he was done with her, and her pussy had felt ruined. But god, he made her come *so many* times.

On the way out the door, he’d told Kane, “You can have her back now. Isn’t reclaiming what you guys do?”

Madison expected that Kane would fuck her, and as sore and ruined as she’d felt, she knew she would have let him. But with Zaydan out of the room, there wasn’t a mission reason for them to have sex, and he didn’t

press himself on her. Deep down, Kane was a good man—better than she'd ever given him credit for.

Kane had been comforting her in bed when Bristow came over their comms. *"Looks like the night is done. Get your clothes on and get out of there so we can debrief."* Madison was so stunned that Kane helped her dress and get out of the club, playing the perfect husband role to a T.

But now her real husband sat in front of her, and he wanted answers. Giving them could send her to Federal prison.

Madison held Charles's gaze for a long minute. "You know I don't work for State."

"I'm not stupid."

"I never thought you were. What I can tell you and not tell you has nothing to do with that."

"Are you having an affair?"

The question landed like a slap, and she resisted the urge to lash out. He had every right to ask it. She turned and closed his office door. "Where are the kids?"

"They went to church, and then brunch, with my sister and their cousins."

Madison sat on the leather loveseat against the wall. Charles stayed behind his desk. She steadily held his gaze so he'd know she wasn't lying—but she'd been trained to lie easily.

"I am not having an affair. I'm sorry you feel like you even have to ask me that."

"I'm an attorney, Maddy. I go where the facts lead me."

"And they led you to think I'm having an affair." She quietly nodded. "I'm not. And yes, those pills are related to my work."

Charles looked baffled. He was a very smart man, but there was not an obvious answer to that, and she watched him work through it in real time. "Are you one of those soccer mom escorts?"

“What the fuck, Charles?”

“Well...”

“You think I’m some walking Lifetime movie? I’m not a hooker.” She smoothly glided over exactly what she had become for her country. “I work for the CIA.”

“I know that. I *thought* I knew that. You could be doing something else on the side. How does working for the Agency make you need those?”

“I don’t think I’d keep my security clearance—or my job—if I was doing something like that. Even if I were having an affair, and they found out. And they would probably find out.”

Madison trod very carefully before continuing. She shouldn’t tell him anything at all. She trusted Charles implicitly, but the United States Government did not.

“Sometimes...my job requires me to get close to a target in an intelligence investigation. And that can mean...various things...”

“Are you running honey traps for the CIA?” He said it like he couldn’t believe in the possibility.

“It’s not that,” she insisted, thinking, *Isn’t it?*

“But you need...abortion pills?”

“They’re just in case.”

“But some are missing from this pack.”

Madison looked away. She didn’t want to say the words. She literally couldn’t.

“Have you been doing this the whole time we’ve been together? Are you jetting off to London to fuck some foreign diplomat and coming home to make dinner?”

“Do you really think I’m capable of that?” She couldn’t control her flash of anger. “Don’t you know me at all?”

“I thought I did. Jesus Christ, Maddy. What is going on?”

“I’ve been working at Langley for the last sixteen years. I left the field when I got pregnant with Penny. I’m an analyst.”

Charles stared at the pills on his desk.

“They—the Agency—came to me recently. They said they needed me to go back into the field for one more mission. I tried to tell them no.”

“You could have just quit.”

“This is my career, Charles. And I’m good at it. You lobby for some pretty terrible people. I’ve never asked you to turn down a client.”

“I’m not fucking them.”

“Yeah, they’re just fucking everyone else.”

They glared at each other across the room. Madison had never felt more distant from her husband.

“I thought about resigning. But I couldn’t. If you knew what I do, you’d understand why.”

Charles warily watched her. Madison had always been complicated. It was why he was drawn to her in the first place. The charge of danger she carried was electric, and when he learned about the way she grew up on the south side of Boston, he understood why she’d become the woman she was. He accepted her because he loved her, including the messy parts. But he didn’t want to think she was capable of what she was implying.

Over time, with love and support, he thought she’d left all of that behind. But now, he knew it had always been there, lurking just beneath the surface. He wasn’t a naive man. Many times, he’d asked himself, *Does anyone ever really change?*

Madison was being torn apart by whatever this was. He could see it. He wanted to be supportive, but those pills. His mind wanted to go to so many dark places. Images popped into his head. Charles tried to focus on the bigger picture instead of their marriage.

“What is it?”

She shook her head. “I can’t tell you. It’s Top Secret. This is the type of thing I wouldn’t even know if I wasn’t involved in it.”

“Maddy, you can trust me.”

Madison stared at him, but Charles understood how silly it sounded the moment it left his lips. She softly said, “You know better. This is a big ask... It’s a leap of faith most men couldn’t make, but I need you to trust me right now. If you have any faith in me, understand that I would never intentionally do anything to hurt you. None of this is fun for me. Whatever I’m doing, I’m doing it because I have to. There isn’t a choice. The stakes are too high.”

Charles knew his choice was to trust her or not. He wanted to. This was the mother of his children. They’d built a life together. Madison was his person. He believed she was only doing her job. But did it have to be *that*? Did it have to be *her*?

He wanted to ask why they needed a middle-aged mom from the suburbs for a honey trap, but he knew the question would only get him in trouble. Madison was hot—objectively hot. His bias as her husband didn’t factor into it. Even sitting there, scrubbed of makeup and her hair pulled back into a tight ponytail, she was beautiful. Charles knew the way men looked at his wife. He liked it. But he never thought about them doing any more than looking.

A question burned in his mind. Maybe he could accept this, but could he live with this? The knowledge of what Madison was doing would be with him forever. He’d never know exactly what she did—or who she did it with—but he’d know she was fucking other men.

Do these pills mean they’re coming inside her? Can I ask that? Should I ask that?

Charles thought that being kept in the dark could be a blessing for a different kind of man. That man could just turn a blind eye. Charles always had to know. Power came with knowledge.

“I know you can’t talk about this mission—whatever it is. I believe you when you say you have to do this. I can’t have any specifics. But I have to know. The sex... What are they making you do? What kind of men?”

“Charles, don’t ask that. There’s only a little bit I can tell you, and why would you want to know that? I don’t want to hurt you.”

Her reticence to share details only made him want to know even more. He thought of the worst things she could be doing. Maybe Madison was selling herself. She could have posed as a high-end call girl to ensnare someone. Did she have to fuck other men to get to the target? For all he knew, Madison had to fuck multiple men to get whatever the government needed.

Charles imagined anonymous men with their hands on his wife. Their hands slipping under her clothes. Worse, he envisioned Madison stripping for them, eagerly encouraging them, spreading her legs. She could be undercover as a stripper for all he knew. Many a powerful man had been undone by their dedication to a skilled sex worker. He didn’t even have to close his eyes to picture Madison working a stripper pole. She had the body for it, and she knew how to move it.

Jesus, how many men have seen her naked? How many have put their hands on my wife?

The thought turned his stomach, but his cock was inexplicably thickening. The combination made him lightheaded.

“Maddy, you know me. I can’t know nothing. Tell me what you can.”

“I don’t understand why you’d want to know any of that. It’s not even important. The men... They don’t matter. The things I have to do are just tasks. It’s a job. I’m not doing anything because I want to. I don’t want other men, Charles.”

Madison stared into her lap, where she was wringing her hands. He knew her too well after so many years together. She was holding back, and it wasn’t about national security.

“You like parts of this, don’t you?”

“Charles... I... That’s...ridiculous.”

“It’s okay,” he said, knowing it didn’t sound convincing at all. “It’s sex, and it should feel good.” He refrained from adding, *And I know how you are.*

He knew it would sound petty and accusatory—and maybe it would be—but Madison was also the most sexual woman he’d ever known. At the start of their relationship, he constantly worried that he wouldn’t be able to keep up with her. He couldn’t imagine her being involved in that way—even for work—and not enjoy it.

“Are you saying you want me to enjoy...” She paused like she had to force the words out. “Having sex...with other men?”

“I don’t want you to hate it. I certainly don’t want it forced on you. I’d never want that.”

“I’m not doing any of this because I want to. I want to be home with you guys.”

“I know,” he patiently replied.

“Do you really want to know?”

Charles stayed silent. Asking again felt like they were getting into weird territory. He didn’t want to seem eager.

“They wanted me specifically because the target has a thing for...older women.”

“A younger guy. Oh.”

“We needed to get close. *Very* close.”

Somehow, he felt numb and tingling everywhere at the same time. “And you did?”

Madison nodded. She didn’t understand why he wanted to know anything about this part of the operation. He’d never been one for morbid curiosity. He was too practical for that. The knowledge could only hurt him.

But he had the oddest look. The pain etched in his face was obvious, but it wasn't that.

He's picturing it, she realized. Why does he want to do that? He's not...

She wouldn't go there. Charles was rock solid. He was the most normal thing she'd ever had in her life. Madison could not allow that even a tiny part of him might be turned on by this.

"Maddy, did you..."

"We had sex, Charles," she said flatly. "It's why he let me get close enough to get the intel we need. I couldn't just tease him and play hard to get."

"I don't think you'd be very good at that."

Did he just call me a slut? I know he's having trouble with this, but...

"So, it worked. You got what you needed."

Her mind filled in the unspoken shot. *Because he did.* That wasn't like Charles, but she was seeing things in him she'd never thought possible. Madison understood that it was projection.

"It's a work in progress. But we're close. I promise, this will all be over soon."

"You're still...doing it...with him."

We did it all night, she thought. Zaydan is a machine. I don't even know what it's going to be like when we go out to Long Island. Is he going to expect me to spread my legs at the snap of his fingers?

Madison kept her face neutral. She couldn't betray that to her husband. He didn't want those kinds of details. She would protect him from himself. But she also had to make sure he understood the reality. If he was getting some weird idea that this was a game, she had to shut it down.

"We're still fucking, Charles. I'm sorry. I need to be available. That's why I've been away from home so much."

"Do you...do it a lot?"

“Let’s not do this, okay? Do you want to know positions? Do you want to know if there’s dirty talk? Do you want to know if I...”

Madison swallowed the rest of that thought. *Do you want to know if I come with him? There is no way you want to know how hard he makes me come.*

“I’m not some kind of pervert, Maddy.”

“I know. And this isn’t fair, but I don’t want to talk about this. I just want it to be over, so I can come home. Can I still come home to you, Charles? Does this change us?”

He wanted to say no. Charles still loved her, and if she was saying she had to do this, he had to believe her. But could she come home, and they’d just act like it never happened?

He was already struggling to reconcile the mom who volunteered with the local athletic league and carted the team to away games with the sultry spy who seduced a younger man for her country. Charles kept trying to conjure images of the Madison he knew because he couldn’t stop picturing some fit, younger man on top of her, thrusting into her. Madison’s legs wrapped around him...her nails digging into his back...her moaning for more... The problem was that it wasn’t *only* disgusting him.

No, I will not think about that. But is it okay if I’m proud that some younger guy thinks my wife is hot? That’s normal, isn’t it? Any man would be proud of that.

“We’ll be fine, Maddy. We love each other, and I trust that we’ll figure it out.”

They sat there in his study on that Sunday morning, each wondering what the other was actually thinking and feeling. When a couple has been together as long as the Sinclairs had been, they know when their spouse isn’t telling the whole truth.

Madison knew her revelation had set something off in her husband, and she didn’t trust that they could ever be the same.

Charles knew she was trying to spare his feelings, but Madison obviously liked fucking this other man—whoever he was.

They both thought the white lies could save them. They'd better be right.

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“What’s on your mind?” Kane asked.

“The work. The mission. Staying focused. This isn’t going to be the same as going to the club. We’re not going to have a break. We have to be on 24/7 until the end.”

They stood by a low, columned wall on a wide patio overlooking the bay. It was one of the many spectacular views of the bay on Hampton’s property. Each of the bedrooms facing the bay—six of them—also had balconies with even better views. An open-air outdoor dining room had its own partially obstructed views. And the infinity pool—one of three pools on the property—had a spectacular sunrise view of Mecox Bay. The Kharabati Royal Family’s Hamptons property—actually two properties combined—was a prime example of the lifestyle billions in petrodollars could buy.

“If this is the end,” Kane ominously replied.

“You heard what they said. They plan to do the deal here.”

“You’ve been out of the field too long. Never take anything for granted, Maddy.”

His correction annoyed her. She knew what she was doing, but she needed this to be done.

“Should you two be talking about this?” Bristow asked over comms.
“Stay on point.”

“We’re alone,” Madison answered. “No one is near us.”

“Kharabati intelligence probably has every inch of that place bugged,” Cassandra added.

“I looked around, we’re fine,” Kane said. “And we’re outside.”

He stood behind Madison, one arm casually around her waist, but he pulled her closer and kissed her cheek, which slid into kissing along her jawline, then her neck. She softly sighed, giving him chills that went straight to his balls and plumped his cock. Kane had forgotten how much he loved this—just being with her.

“Just stay focused,” Bristow directed.

Madison pressed back against Kane, telling herself they were playing the happy couple. They were, but being in his arms still felt right after all those years. She put her hand over his on her waist and squeezed. Guilt burned her chest, stronger than before, but no antacid could relieve her ache.

Her time with Charles and the kids was not long enough. They had Sunday and Monday together before she had to return to Philadelphia to plan the move of the operation to the Hamptons. The tension between her and Charles eased, but never disappeared. She knew what he saw every time he looked at her. It was evident in the intensity of their lovemaking. He showed an aggression in bed that she’d never seen before.

At least, they were able to hide it from the kids. Chaz was still bothered by her absence. She saw it in Penny, too. Madison had a lot of damage control to do when she returned to her life.

“So, darling, what do you think of this place? I guess we’re finally seeing how the other half lives,” Kane said, switching fully into David Richardson mode.

“I think a lot of people would consider us the other half, Dave.”

“Sure, we’ve done well, but we’re not in this class.”

Madison smiled. “It really is like something out of a movie, isn’t it? I can’t believe someone actually owns this.”

“His family does. I’ll admit, I can’t believe you’re fooling around with an actual prince.”

“It explains why he was so secretive when we first met.”

The Kharabati Royal Compound in the Hamptons was truly impressive. They were staying in the house on the front parcel, which was the more *intimate* property, with only thirteen bedrooms and one pool. This was the house where the family stayed when they came to town. The Russians were in the larger house in the rear. That one had the movie theater, indoor basketball court, and two-lane bowling alley.

Kane gestured and removed his comms earwig. He clenched it in his fist. Madison didn’t understand at first, and mouthed *what*, but then she removed hers. It was strictly against protocol, but he wanted to talk without anyone listening.

“I think once this starts moving, it’s going to move quickly. I just wanted to make sure you’re okay, and you’re ready. You’ve been different since you came back from visiting home. On edge. Is everything okay?”

Madison wanted to unburden and tell Kane about the Plan B pills and how Charles took it. She wanted someone to tell her everything would work out. But sharing details of her marriage would be a betrayal of her husband, and she’d done enough of that.

She looked at Kane, remembered how he made her come in the condo in Philly. That had nothing to do with the mission. That wasn’t the white lie that the things she’d done in Nox Venari were only for the mission. Madison cheated and lied to Charles about it. It was bitter in her mouth.

“I’m fine,” she insisted. “It’s just hard going back and forth, and seeing how much I’m missing while I’m gone. I feel like I have a split personality.

I go home, and I'm one person, but then I come back here, and I have to be someone else. I need to hold onto which one is the real me."

Kane touched her cheek, and she leaned into it. "I think they're both you. Yeah, you've built a life, and that's amazing, but it's meant denying this other side of you. Maybe you're supposed to be both."

"I just don't think that's possible, Damien."

"Then try to get everything you can out of this visit to your old self before you have to put her back in the box."

"If only it were that easy."

"Can't it be as easy as you want it to be, Maddy?"

"I wish."

Madison was sure he was going to kiss her, and she was just as sure she wouldn't stop him. But she heard the sound of a helicopter in the distance. Shading her eyes against the brilliant early-afternoon summer sun, she saw the black speck coming in fast.

"Do you think our host is here?" Kane asked.

"Maybe. He does like a grand entrance."

Madison had expected Zaydan to be waiting for them once they'd passed through the wrought iron gates and driven up the long, gravel driveway that morning. She thought he'd be standing by that fountain in front of the house, arms wide to greet his favorite MILF. She'd mostly expected him to whisk her—Melissa—away from her husband the moment they arrived to re-establish his ownership. A shameful part of her was disappointed when it hadn't happened.

"Shall we go greet our host?"

"Probably." Before Kane could move away from her, Madison gave him a quick peck on the lips. "Thank you for being worried about me. I know none of this has been easy on you either."

"I can handle it. We'll get through this together and take that bastard down."

“Sounds like a plan, Mr. Richardson.”

They popped their comms back into their ears. Kane held out his arm.

“Shall we, Mrs. Richardson?”

ZAYDAN WAS PLEASED to see Madison walking out of the house as his golf cart pulled up. He was less pleased to see her cuckold husband, but understood they were a package deal—for now. He’d impulsively invited her out to the Hamptons, and then thought better of it when he’d seen Sergei’s sour face, but he wouldn’t be bullied by the Russian. He was the one with the money. Besides, the MILF was no threat to their deal. She wouldn’t even know what Null:Echo was if she were staring at it. But seeing all that money changing hands would drop her panties—like he needed the help.

Several representatives of the Kingdom accompanied him, and he had to behave properly in their presence. Otherwise, Zaydan would have thrown Madison over his shoulder and carried her up to his bedroom.

His brother wanted other eyes on the deal before it was closed. Zaydan hated being second-guessed like that, but he wasn’t the crown prince. Omar was, and he’d never trusted his younger brother. Zaydan knew he’d proved himself, but Omar would never take him seriously. Acquiring a tool like Null:Echo would force his brother to admit he’d been wrong.

“Melissa, I’m so glad you could join us. I hope we didn’t tear you away from anything important.” He paused to nod at her husband. “David.”

“It’s summer,” she enthused. “Doesn’t the world slow down for vacations?”

She gave him the kind of smile that could only come from a woman who’d been transformed by a big cock. Zaydan loved that her husband had to hate every second of it.

“And you had no business to attend to, David? Melissa could have still come up if you’d been busy.”

Kane smiled tightly. “And miss this? Some beach house you have here. We have to sit down over drinks and discuss business. Surely, there is somewhere our businesses overlap.”

The men shook hands, each trying to outdo the other, just like the first time they met. Now, as then, Zaydan was surprised by his strength. Those callouses did not belong on the hand that worked a computer mouse all day. No man was a match for him, but he made a note not to underestimate David Richardson.

“We’ll find time to talk business,” Zaydan said, thinking, *Perhaps when I am done ruining your wife. I’ll invest a few million in your pet project as a consolation prize. You can live with pimping Melissa to me.*

When she tried to throw herself into his arms, Zaydan took Madison’s hands instead. He didn’t need the men sent with him reporting improper behavior to his brother. She didn’t make it easy. Zaydan was sure the redhead had bought the dress to tempt him. He could not get those men lodged in their quarters fast enough. Setting them up with Sergei would give him time to enjoy her properly.

Surely, a suburban mother had never owned such a revealing sundress before. The floral print fabric flowed over her curves, barely reaching mid-thigh, and exposing a dangerous portion of her tits. She may have been a soccer mom in her previous life, but this needy MILF knew exactly what she was doing. Zaydan would reward her for it.

“I promise we’ll catch up once I have my associates settled. Let me take them back to get acquainted with Sergei, and I’ll return shortly.”

“Promise?” she pouted.

“Of course. Do not worry, Melissa. Kharabati men always keep their promises.”

Zaydan re-boarded the golf cart, and it zipped off, headed for the rear section of the property, where the Russians were lodged.

Madison and Kane watched the golf cart go. He said, "I think he's hooked."

"Yep," she agreed. "I just hope they're not going back there to close the deal now."

"It can't take place that quickly. One of those men must be his computer guy. He's got to verify Null:Echo before they do anything. And then..."

"And then I fuck him to distraction, and we snatch it right out from under his nose."

THE RUSSIANS SEEMED ILL at ease at dinner. Madison noted a newcomer with them, a tattooed, bespectacled man with bedhead who wore a hoodie and black jeans in defiance of the summer heat.

Madison sensed that Sergei was eager to get the deal done and move on. Zaydan's constant need to show off and control the situation was wearing thin on his guests. The two men had been raised with wealth by powerful fathers, but they came from very different worlds.

Zaydan sat at the head of the long, marble table in the open-air dining room, with Madison to his left. He kept her close, but behaved because the other Kharabatis were present. Sergei sat to his right, with the other Russians down that side of the table. The Kharabati advisors were banished to the far end of the table, and most kept to themselves, speaking in their own tongue throughout dinner.

A cool breeze off the bay alleviated what had been a brutally hot summer day, and Madison reveled in the break. Even sitting on the beach had offered little relief. But the humidity still felt like a blanket over them,

and for once, she appreciated that she could get away with wearing as little modesty would allow for Melissa Richardson.

The dinner was specially prepared by Zaydan's personal chef. It may have been the best steak Madison had ever had—which was saying a lot—but she still hardly made a dent in hers. She didn't want to offend their host, but he couldn't possibly expect her to eat a steak the size of her entire dinner plate. The prince assured his countrymen, in Arabic, that the meat was halal. But she did consume the fresh greens salad and the snow peas, which had a perfect snap.

The wine flowed freely all night, as well. Madison paced herself without making it obvious. Alcohol seemed to be an area where he didn't worry about what the other Kharabatis thought because Zaydan's glass was always full.

The more wine he had, the less he appeared to worry about his countrymen at all. More and more of his charm offensive was directed at Madison, and his hand possessively rested on hers. Kane took her other hand, like she was in the middle of some macho tug of war.

The Russians became more insular as the night went on, and Zaydan turned his attention to Madison and Kane. They spoke among themselves in their own tongue, oblivious to the fact that she understood every word.

One of Sergei's associates thought they were wasting time and asked when they were going to close the deal. He laughed and said that Zaydan was a clown, but they had to humor him because of all the money on the table. Another Russian complained that he could only play so much basketball and wondered where the women were—unless they were going to take turns with Madison.

He seemed good with that. His comrade laughed and said he wanted her round ass. The third Russian snorted and said she was too old and probably dried up. The newest member of their group just looked at Madison like he was confused. In Russian, Sergei told his men, "She is the prince's toy.

Leave her be. You'll be able to buy every whore in Europe when we're done here."

The Russians looked at her while they spoke, and she just smiled like she had no idea what they were talking about. Madison chose not to be offended. She wouldn't let any of them touch her on a dare anyway.

"I was thinking we could go out on the boat tomorrow morning and try our luck at fishing," Zaydan suggested.

"Sorry, I am out on that. I can't imagine anything more boring," Madison replied, adding a little laugh to seem tipsy.

"Sorry, darling, but I was thinking just the men."

She turned to Kane. "What do you think, honey? You love fishing." She smiled as she watched him squirm.

"I don't know. I was looking forward to sleeping in." He finally read her tight smile and replied, "Sure, why not? I haven't gotten out there in a while."

"I used to go ice fishing with my father," Sergei said, expression turning dour. "It was as much about endurance as catching fish. Going out on a fancy boat is just playing.

Zaydan smiled, trying to charm him. He didn't make much headway. "Come on, we could all use some bonding. Besides, most of my time is spent with those stiff." He nodded toward the Kharabatis at the other end of the long table. "I could use some time with real men."

"Fine, but when we come back, we get down to business," Sergei insisted.

"Yes, then business."

Zaydan raised his wine glass. "To business!"

Madison joined the toast. She was just as eager to get this transaction done as Sergei. *And then I can put all of this behind me.*

three

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The Kharabati advisors left as soon as it was not too rude. Sergei took a golf cart back to the other house, too, claiming he had calls to make. Two of the Russians hung around when they moved to the deck with the infinity pool overlooking the bay. The wind was coming in hard off the water, and Madison's hair whipped around her head in a copper cloud. She pulled it back into a ponytail with a scrunchie from her wrist, while Zaydan poured more wine.

"I can do some poking around tonight if you keep him distracted," Kane whispered, while nibbling on her ear.

He hated the thought of sending her back to Zaydan, but they needed intel on how the deal was going to go down. He would have much rather taken her to their bed. Even though he shouldn't, Kane thought maybe they'd have to make love to maintain their cover.

"I was thinking your man time tomorrow morning might be the perfect time for me to do some digging. No *distracting* needed," she replied, softly kissing him the way a slightly tipsy, horny wife would. "Me poking around is less likely to draw notice than you."

Kane smiled, continuing their playful kissing. "That's pretty sexist, Mad...*Melissa*."

“But true.” Madison gave in and kissed him full-on, tongue teasing his. She hated how much she loved kissing him. She’d never be able to answer the question at the core of her being—*Am I a spy or a slut? Is it okay if I want to be both?*

“Sorry to interrupt the happy couple,” Zaydan said, holding out a wine for Madison and a whiskey for Kane. “Actually, that’s a lie. I hope you don’t mind me saying that I’ve been hoping to get between you and your lovely wife all night, David.”

Kane smiled like a shark. “Don’t tell me that the only reason you invited us out to the Hamptons is to fuck my wife.”

“Perhaps not the *only* reason, but I’ve been looking forward to it. Is that a problem? It didn’t seem like a problem the other night when she...”

“Boys...” Madison said, sipping her wine. “Play nice.”

“*Don’t antagonize him, Kane,*” Bristow warned in his ear. “*If you get yourselves kicked out...*”

“I’ll confess, I like seeing Mel expand her horizons. It’s nice to see her seeking her pleasure after putting our family first for the last twenty years.”

Kane’s improvisational skills were challenged by having to role-play such a passive man. Watching Zaydan fuck Madison for hours at Nox Venari had been torture. Whatever thrill he’d experienced from watching her be so free with her body had been numbed by the two-hour mark. He’d even left the room to get a drink at one point. He’d needed it. But now he had to consider how a man like David Richardson—proud but perverted—would contend with Zaydan.

“But I need you to remember she’s still my wife. And respect that,” he finished.

Zaydan flashed his charming smile, but it didn’t work on Kane the way it worked on Madison. “Of course, my friend. I am only borrowing Melissa for as long as she allows. She will always return to you.”

“I will, Dave,” she echoed.

Foolish American, Zaydan thought. No real man lends out his wife. Not one who loves her. I will return your Melissa, but only when she is fucked out. It will be my great pleasure to send her back, knowing you'll never satisfy her again.

“See, David. You have nothing to be concerned about. If you’re truly concerned about Melissa’s pleasure, you’ll let her enjoy herself.”

Kane only just held back from laughing in the prince’s face. *He can think I’m a fool, right up until I put a bullet in his head.* He didn’t care what the mission parameters were. Kane would enjoy sending Zaydan to the same place he’d dispatched his uncle. The world would be a better place without him.

“Please, Dave,” she said, batting her eyes at him. Madison thought she and Kane deserved Oscars for this performance.

Kane deliberately gave his *wife* a slow, possessive kiss before surrendering her to their host. His cock twitched when he felt her breath hitch. He threw back the whiskey Zaydan had just given him. “I need more of your private stash anyway.”

“My bar is all yours, my friend.”

Madison playfully punched Zaydan in the chest once Kane was gone. “You need to be nicer to him, Zay. He’s my husband. This isn’t as easy for him as he lets on.”

“I can’t even imagine, Melissa.” He laid a hand on her hip, and she pressed against him. “I can’t imagine that a husband would let another man lay hands on his wife. It’s...unnatural. He should be guarding you.”

“Like a possession?” she asked, playing with the tuft of dark hair that peeked out from the neck of his tight, black tank top. “I know things are different in your country, but I am no man’s possession.”

“A treasure, perhaps?” His grip tightened on her hip.

Zaydan felt how badly she wanted him with each shallow breath that escaped her lips. He loved that she was still nervous around him. She

should be. He planned to teach her what it truly meant to be possessed. *I bet she's already soaked for me*, he thought.

"A treasure is still something you want to possess, Zay. Why can't we be equals, enjoying each other? Does it have to be about surrender, or taking me from Dave?"

"Very good, Melissa," he replied, chuckling. He didn't try to hide because she'd already surrendered to him, and she would again. He would only humor her as much as needed. He slid his hand up her bare back, under the straps that crossed it to keep the light pink dress from falling off.

"You're terrible, Zay. Maybe that's what I like about you. I don't know any men like you." She touched his beard, absent-mindedly wondering how he kept it so soft.

"American men don't know how to...*treasure*...you. Perhaps you don't think so, but you need a firm hand, Melissa."

"Oh, do I?" she asked, amused.

Zaydan pulled her hard against him and demanded a kiss. She teased, flicking her tongue, tasting the wine on his lips, before she acquiesced. His hand on her back pressed her so tightly to his chest that she had to force her breath.

It seemed like he was always touching her bare skin, but then, she was always so exposed around him. Madison realized she'd been braless more in the last month than in the last year. She never left the house dressed the way she did as Melissa. Part of her thought she should take those dresses home when the operation was done. The looks on her neighbors' faces in McLean might be worth it.

Madison twisted her fist in his tank top while they kissed, locking them together just as much as he did. The fabric felt expensive. It probably cost the same as a car payment. She was the one chasing his lips when they parted.

"That proves nothing," she insisted, trying to catch her breath.

“Why don’t we discuss this in the pool?”

“It might be a little chilly with this wind.” She drained half her wine glass in one swallow. She wanted both hands free.

“The water is heated. You’ll love being right on the edge, looking at the ocean.”

Madison cocked an eyebrow and smiled. “Will I? Okay, let me go change.”

Zaydan shook his head. That’s not necessary, Melissa. We’re all adults here.”

“You mean... Zay, you can’t be serious.”

He slipped out of her arms and pulled the tank top over his head, dropping it to the laid-in stone patio. He unbuttoned his thousand-dollar chinos as he walked away from her backward. Madison smiled at his little show. The confidence to strip right there with an audience was sexy. But she knew what he had. Zaydan had a reason to be confident—a big one. Just before he reached the steps into the pool, he dropped his snug, black boxer briefs.

Madison stared at his thick, brown cock, pulsing as it rose before him. The way she loved that thing was a sin. She had to remind herself, *You’re fucking him for your country—not because you want it.*

“Well?” he asked, stepping into the water and then floating across the pool.

New Madison and old Madison warred inside her. Old Madison would have thrown off her dress, dove into the pool, and tried to wrestle Zaydan under the water. New Madison worked very hard to always be appropriate, and shedding her clothes in front of other people still felt wrong. Nox Venari hadn’t changed her that much.

Kane wasn’t the problem. He’d seen her naked more than anyone except Charles. God, Charles. What would he say if he saw her there? If he had a

front row seat, the way Kane did? She couldn't think about his strange reactions to her confessions.

No, she wasn't worried about Kane. But those sleazy Russians were still hanging around, watching. Madison suspected they'd hung around *because* they wanted to watch. And Rami stood just inside the glass doors that looked out on the patio. He wasn't right there like he was when Zaydan was in public, but he was still a constant presence when others were around.

Fuck it, she thought, pulling the straps from her shoulders. *This is Melissa's big slutty weekend. Guess I should lean into it. He thinks I had too much wine anyway.*

Madison made a show of pulling the shoulder straps away from her body before letting them go. The dress hung on her breasts for a breathtaking moment before pooling at her feet. Her nipples pebbled the moment they were exposed to the strong breeze. It didn't cover much anyway, dipping almost to her navel in the front. She was left in a white thong, which she left in place. No need to show *everything*.

She risked a look at Kane as she walked to the pool. He watched her hungrily in a way that made her core tighten. The Russians looked like they wanted to do unspeakable things to her. Zaydan watched as she descended into the water, looking like he knew exactly what he was going to do to her.

He took her hands and pulled her farther into the water. Her toes barely touched the bottom.

"Your body... So damn sexy, Melissa. You should be like this all the time, being worshipped. Don't try to tell me again that those men in your community don't want you."

Madison laughed, genuinely amused. She thought about putting her friend's husband, Bill, in his place. He learned the hard way to keep his hands to himself. "Men are not chasing me through the streets. There are more beautiful women, *younger* women, than me all around. Women who spend four days a week doing Pilates and parade around in Alo yoga pants."

Zaydan pulled her closer so that she floated between his legs. His cock bobbed against her—a thick promise. He released her hands to grab her hips. “A woman should feel like a woman, Melissa. She should have softness, not be hard like a man.”

“Soft? Are you calling me chubby? I’m not sure you understand women, Zay. We don’t want to be soft—especially when we reach a certain age.”

“Feminine,” he corrected.

She was ticklish and squirmed when his fingers danced up her side, but was not laughing when he cupped the swell of her breast. Zaydan was not a good man, but he still knew how to make her feel desired in a way few other men ever had. He massaged her supple flesh, rolling her nipple—thickened from the ocean breeze—with his thumb. She gasped his name.

“The problem is that American women don’t understand what appreciation means. Your society sexualizes you from an early age. It becomes cheap.” He studied her while he teased her nipple. His cock was pinned between them. It rubbed against her stomach, making her core ache.

“Zay...”

“How old were you the first time a man noticed these tits?”

Madison remembered it vividly. Her mother sent her to the bodega up the street for cigarettes. She tried to run in and out, but the older man behind the counter, the one who’d always been so nice, looked at her in the tank top in a way that made her feel dirty. She just innately sensed what he was thinking.

She just wanted to escape, but he kept her talking so he could stare. It was her first brush with the male gaze, and it changed the way she moved through the world. It would be a few more years before she learned how to weaponize her sexuality against men like him. Men like Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati.

“Too young,” she answered.

“We would never tolerate that in my country. That is why we protect our women from men’s baser impulses. We do not expose them to those lusts, unless the circumstance is appropriate.”

“Is this...” She couldn’t keep the hitch out of her voice. The light teasing was having the intended effect. “...*appropriate?*”

Zaydan slipped two fingers inside her. She was ready and tightened around them with a gasp. He smiled, pleased.

“We are in America. We are not following the rules of my culture.”

He slowly moved his fingers. Her sheath fluttered around him. Their cultural exchange should have ruined the mood, but in a twisted way, it made her want him more. Madison felt like she had something to prove, although she was fuzzy on what that was.

“That way you see women...Zay, that’s...mmm...”

“I see you for who you are.”

Zaydan steered them to the edge of the infinity pool. The dark water of the bay shimmered with silver highlights from the bright moon just past the dunes. She heard the gentle sound of the waves in the distance. He hadn’t been lying. The view was breathtaking—almost as breathtaking as what he was doing to her. She wrapped her hand around his cock.

He bent to where the water just lapped at her nipples, and took one in his mouth. She closed her eyes and trembled, raking fingers through his hair to keep his mouth against her chest. His tongue was busy while he suckled.

“You were right, it’s incredible, Zay...ohhh...”

“The view?” he asked, lips brushing her tip.

“That...ohhh...too...”

Madison dug her nails into the back of his neck when he went back to sucking. His teeth nipped at her, drawing her tip away from her pale skin, and she cried out, body flush with pleasure.

“Zay...fuck...mmm...that feels...sooo...fucking good...”

“I love how filthy your mouth gets when you’re turned on. That proper veneer is stripped away.”

He rose out of the water. She tried to kiss him. His hand lightly rested on her throat, stopping her. He wasn’t choking her, but the intent was clear. Fear shivered through her. It was a lightning bolt to her pussy. She tried to kiss him again, his grip tightened, so subtle she couldn’t be sure she was imagining it.

“Do you want me to fuck you, Melissa?”

“Yess...”

“That’s why you’re here, isn’t it? You’ll be mine all weekend, Melissa. Whenever I want you.”

Zaydan turned her as he spoke, lifting so her tits hung out of the water, pressing her to the edge of the infinity pool. It felt like she was hanging out into the dark night. It was exhilarating.

“Yesss... *I want you, Zay... I’m yours...this weekend...*”

He buried himself with one thrust. She was soaked, but it was still startling. The ache was intense, but it was a good ache—one she craved. Madison wanted Zaydan to get what was coming to him, but in the meantime, she would take what she needed. God, she felt so *full*.

“*Fuck! Zay... God...give a girl...ohhh...some...warning...ohhh god...*”

Zaydan ignored her, began sliding in and out of her, making Madison see stars. He had just the right amount of English in the roll of his hips to make it feel like she was feeling him for the first time with every thrust.

“Yesss...*god yesss...Zay...*”

“Your husband...isn’t going...to be a problem...” He grunted it with each deep thrust.

He cupped her hanging breast and roughly pinched her nipples. She loudly cursed into the dark, sea air.

“*No...fuck...he knows...why we’re here...*”

His hand on her hip curled around so he could rub her clit. Madison hated how easily she came apart for him—but she loved that he had the power to make it happen.

“Tell me...why...Melissa...”

“To fuck...ohmygod...for you to...ohhh...fuck me...Zay... Don’t stop... please... Do it... I’m here... Do it...”

Kane almost shattered the glass in his hand. He poured another measure of the prince’s five-figure single malt into the glass and downed it. He’d brought the bottle with him. The asshole could buy another one.

Madison’s cries carried back to him on the wind off the bay. She didn’t even play hard to get. It was ridiculous, but he wanted her to. He wanted... Kane didn’t know what he wanted. Things he couldn’t have. What he was watching was Zaydan taking like he was entitled to it. Kane wanted to be the one to pull those sounds out of her. He heard her cries so clearly.

Fuck me...Zay... Don’t stop...please...

Maybe most of all, Kane was angry that he couldn’t see it. All he could see from his perch on the patio was Zaydan thrusting from behind Madison. But he heard her losing her mind the way she always did when someone fucked her right. Kane loathed the weakness, but he wanted to see it. He wanted to see Madison come undone.

The Russians nudged each other and eagerly watched Zaydan take Madison. Their tone made it obvious what they were saying, even though it was in Russian. The nerdy one was particularly excited. Kane’s handle on the language was shaky at best, but he knew the dirty words. And he heard them all. *Whore. Slut. Needy bitch.* Kane would shoot them in the head just like their master, Sergei.

He went to adjust himself in the salmon, khaki shorts he’d worn as David Richardson’s uniform, and groaned when his hand brushed his cock. He rubbed it for a moment, but had to stop. He was going to make a mess and embarrass himself.

Madison screamed into the night. Screamed. “*Yes! Fuck yes! Ohmygod! Don’t stop! Never...stop! Anything... Anything you want!*”

Kane wanted to believe she was playing her role, but he wasn’t that foolish. Every time she came for Zaydan, it reopened an old wound. He watched the prince sag behind her, surely filling Madison with his load. Kane wanted to throw him over the edge of that infinity pool and then fill her with his own seed. Reclaim her? How could he reclaim her when she wasn’t his to begin with?

Zaydan helped a shaky Madison out of the pool. She leaned heavily against him and didn’t even bother to dress before he led her toward the sliding glass doors. Rami opened the door for them. Zaydan was taking her, and Kane had to sit there and watch it happen.

I told her to keep him occupied, he remembered. It was cold comfort.

Madison looked over her shoulder and mouthed, *sorry*.

Kane didn’t know if it was from Melissa for David or for him. It didn’t matter.

Rami slid the door closed, and Madison was gone.

four

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“I think I’ve got it,” Manny said, fingers flying over his keyboard. He sat at the battleship-sized dining room table in a multi-million-dollar mansion.

The package he’d prepared to take over the video feeds at the Kharabati compound was ready to go. But getting into—and staying there—their system was trickier than he’d expected. Once he was in, the package would record video from every camera feed and send a loop to the monitors in their security center. And the Kharabatis had cameras everywhere. But Manny had to get in undetected first.

“You need to be sure, Manny. It’s my ass,” Kane told him over comms. *“You guys are too far away if things really go to shit.”*

“We can be right there. Chill out, man,” Dentiger told him. He stood behind Manny, staring at the array of video monitors the tech guy had mounted on arms attached to the table. He was always amazed by how many screens these guys needed. It looked like Manny was trying to land a spaceship. “I’ve timed it out. If we don’t have to blow the gates, we can be on-site in about six minutes.”

“Six minutes is a long time when someone is shooting at you,” Kane argued.

“Just don’t get caught,” Bristow told him, yawning. It had been a long day. She’d spent too much time behind a desk and shaking hands on Capitol Hill in the last few years. She wasn’t used to long days in the field anymore.

“Really? Thanks. That’s why you’re in the big chair, ma’am.”

Dentiger had to smile at that. He didn’t like Kane at all, but he shared every field officer’s skepticism of upper management.

“That’s why I need Manny to get this right,” Kane continued.

“Don’t worry,” Cassandra said. “Manny’s got this.” She cut the audio on her headset. “You’ve got this, right?”

“Yeah, I can get it done. Kharabati security is as high-end as it gets. They’re using rolling encryption, so it’s hard to stay in their system—especially without tripping something. But I think I’ve written a workaround.”

“I’m glad you think it’ll work. Your confidence makes me feel all warm and fuzzy.”

Manny smirked. “You know what could get us right in there? Null:Echo would cut through this like a lightsaber through Obi-Wan.”

“So we need the thing we’re stealing to get at the thing we’re stealing? Thanks, nerd.”

“Madison is doing her part. Just make sure you do yours, Kane. This will be all over soon,” Bristow said.

“Hopefully not with a bullet in my head. Is Maddy still good?”

“She’s fine,” Bristow curtly answered.

She looked to Madison’s camera feed, which was on a separate monitor she’d turned away from the team. Bristow thought they’d seen enough. They didn’t need to monitor what the redhead was doing unless things went sideways. She could monitor Madison herself and alert them to a change.

The video from Madison’s locket cam was mostly jumbled images—darkness, then light, blurry fleshtones—and way-too-close-up views of Zaydan. When the couple had arrived in the master suite, Bristow got a very

intimate view of the target's cock. It was impressive, even taking the exaggerated camera perspective out of the equation. She wasn't a size queen herself, but she got why Madison was making those noises. Thinking that her officer might at least be enjoying herself alleviated some of the Deputy Director's guilt about sending her in.

Bristow glanced over at the Madison monitor. The camera was swinging wildly, with blurred images of the wall and headboard, then a quick flash of Zaydan on his back. Madison was obviously riding him. Bristow clicked on Madison's audio feed.

"Ohhh...fuck...Zay...fuck... It's too much... Fuck... I can't..."

"You can... You'll come again... You'll come until I let you stop..."

"Zay...you're terrible...ruining me... Ohmygod! Ohmygod! Fuck! Yes!"

Bristow switched off the audio. She didn't need to eavesdrop on another one of Madison's orgasms. She felt a twinge of jealousy. She'd never had a lover who made her come so many times she had to tell him that she couldn't keep going.

"I've got it. You're good to go, Kane." Manny triumphantly tapped a key and leaned back in his chair, grinning. "Just be as quick as you can. This is like riding a bronco. I don't know how long I can stay in there."

"Just give me a warning, if you can."

The team watched Kane move through the dark mansion from the safety of their makeshift ops center about a mile and a half away. It was like watching someone play *Call of Duty: Hamptons Edition*. There was no setting up a black CIA surveillance van on any of the narrow Hamptons roads near the Kharabati compound. Going unnoticed would be impossible. Fortunately, the government was sitting on a nearby mansion they'd seized from the architect of the third-largest pyramid scheme in US history.

They were close, but not close enough that they could storm the compound in seconds if things went horribly wrong. Dentiger had driven by a couple of times and calculated that six minutes was the fastest they could

respond if he and Cassandra—maybe even Bristow—just jumped into the SUV and went. He noted that the Deputy Director was wearing a sidearm, just like the rest of the team.

The reinforced front of the armored vehicle should be able to crash through the huge wrought-iron gates at the base of the long, winding crushed stone driveway. It would be longer if Dentiger had to set a charge and blow the gates.

Bristow had ordered a tactical team—who'd set up shop in the six-car garage—but they would need more time to mount up and go. It would be on the main team to lead the charge, and Dentiger didn't let personal feelings enter into it. He would not let a member of his team be harmed.

Ideally, Madison and Kane could snatch Null:Echo and make a clean getaway.

Kane's video feed showed him in the game room. He bent low and placed a listening device under the pool table. Kharabati security swept for bugs, but the devices provided by the DS&T Wizards used the same high frequencies as the team's comms and were passive devices anyway. They didn't transmit until they received a microburst to activate them.

"Pick up the pace, Kane," Manny warned. "The encryption key will roll over again in three minutes, and I don't know if I can stay in their system. If I get kicked and can't cover the video package, they're gonna flag it, and shit's gonna get real fast."

"It's a big fucking house, Manny. And it's not just the cameras I need to worry about," Kane answered.

He kept having to duck into shadows when he encountered a security patrol. Sometimes, he thought Madison had the easier job. This was no different than their earlier partnership. She was enjoying herself while he was sneaking around and trying not to get killed.

"You're doing great. Just keep going. Maybe just hold tight wherever you are if Manny has to reset," Cassandra suggested.

“Copy that, chief.”

Being called chief had annoyed Cassandra. She couldn't help but read sarcasm into it. Kane wouldn't be the first man with an issue answering to a younger woman. But ever since the Deputy Director came in and took the reins, Cassandra was looking for any acknowledgment that Scarlet Phantom was still her operation. Bristow had come in and completely undermined her authority.

Kane was in Zaydan's office. The curved wall of windows bathed the room in silvery moonlight, and he easily moved through the room. The feed showed him looking through the room for a place to plant the bug. He positioned it in the back of a bookshelf and turned his attention to the prince's desk.

“Look for anything useful,” Bristow told him.

“Thanks for that. I was just hoping he had his Netflix password written down.”

“Open the laptop,” Manny said. Kane pried it open, and the light was blinding. He snapped it shut. “Wait. Do you have the crack drive with you?”

“Yeah, but this screen is going to bring someone running.”

“Turn the brightness down. It'll be the little sun logo. You might have to hit a function key.”

“Fuck you, Manny. I know how to work a laptop.”

Kane opened the laptop again and quickly dialed down the brightness. When he plugged the USB drive into the side, an hourglass appeared on the lock screen. It kept turning and turning. *“How much time did you say I have?”*

“Don't worry about that. There could be vital intel on that laptop,” Bristow ordered.

A green bar appeared on the screen and began to crawl to the right.

“This is going to take forever.”

“Abort if you have to,” Cassandra said, her stomach knotted. She was not going to get Kane killed.

“Hang tight,” Bristow said. Cassandra glared at her.

“Shit. I need to pull out,” Manny muttered. The key’s about to roll over, and I haven’t locked in the next one. He started frantically typing.

“What does that mean, Manny?” Silence. *“What’s happening?”*

“It’s going to take a minute to get back in.”

“You’re fine, Kane,” Cassandra said. “You’ll just have to stay there until Manny gets control of the cameras again. There isn’t one in Zaydan’s office. No one will see you in there.”

“I’ll just put my feet up and look for a file stamped Null:Echo.”

The screen, divided into tiny boxes representing all the cameras on the estate, went black. The room was filled with the click-clack of Manny’s frantic work.

Cassandra crossed her arms and hugged herself tightly. She felt every bit of Kane’s tension. They both knew what the Kharabatis would do to him if he was caught in Zaydan’s office. The Royal Guard liked their machetes. As a woman, Madison would face far worse consequences. The prince would be forced to be especially cruel to save face. Cassandra considered putting the tactical team on alert.

Her eyes shifted to the feed from the drone Bristow had tasked for overwatch on the operation. Tiny, ghostly white blobs from the drone’s FLIR camera represented the people in the house. Two were clustered together in Zaydan’s bedroom, moving vigorously. Half a dozen guards patrolled the house. Even more walked the grounds.

“A guard is coming your way, Kane,” Cassandra warned. “Get out of there.”

“Manny said I can’t. Fuck.”

“Take cover,” Bristow offered.

His camera showed Kane looking around the room. There was no cover.
“*I don’t think I’ll fit under the desk.*”

“I need like a minute,” Manny murmured, locked in on his task.

“It’ll be fine,” Bristow said.

Like fuck it will, Dentiger thought, hand instinctively going to his sidearm, like he could do anything for Kane from there. He was ready to bolt for the SUV.

The camera feed showed Kane rush to compress himself into the space behind the door. Moments later, the door swung open, and a guard stepped through the door. The team saw him on the FLIR from the drone, but Kane’s feed only showed darkness.

“Dammit. The laptop,” Cassandra breathed. It had been left open on the desk.

The guard stepped farther into the room and toward the desk. Kane shifted left, ready to spring out from behind the door. Moonlight flashed on the blade in his hand. The entire team held their breath, except for Manny, who was typing away.

Seemingly satisfied, the guard turned back to the door. Kane pulled in just in time. The guard left and closed the door. Kane audibly exhaled in the comms feed.

“*Fuck me...*”

“We’re good. I’m back in,” Manny announced.

“What the fuck, man?” Dentiger said.

“What? I’m working as fast as I can.”

Kane went back around the desk, and his feed showed the laptop screen was dark. He tapped the space bar, and it lit up, showing that the copy was completed.

“Get back to your room. You’ve done enough for tonight,” Cassandra ordered. She didn’t wait for Bristow’s input. She was still in charge, and it wouldn’t go on the Deputy Director’s record if their officer got killed.

“Yes. Good job, Damien,” Bristow said.

“*Thanks*, Jen. ”

five

. . .

Madison let herself into the room she was sharing with Kane for the weekend. She carried her sandals, hoping to pad across the hardwood floor and slip into bed without waking him, but it was hard to move precisely when she was so sore. Another night with Zaydan had left her feeling thoroughly used. And blissfully satisfied.

She went right into the attached bathroom and shed Zaydan's dress shirt. She'd demanded he give her something. Her dress was lost on the patio, and she was not going to parade through the hallways naked—again. Security was constantly roaming the house. She looked at herself in the mirror, hated what she saw, and slipped off the locket. The team shouldn't see her like that. She popped out her earwig and stepped into the shower.

The hot, stinging water felt like the punishment she deserved. Water hit her from every angle. The five showerheads were positioned to drench her. Madison understood that she had been doing her job in Zaydan's bed, but she couldn't claim it was that simple in the immediate aftermath.

She still felt his touch, like ghost images in a photograph. Still felt the way he stretched her. Her knees were still weak from the countless times he made her come. Madison prayed he wasn't as effective as a terrorist as he was a lover.

Smoothing her hair back on her head, she murmured, “*Fuck. Dammit. Why...*”

Every time Zaydan made her come, it felt like a betrayal of Charles. Her husband implied he wanted Madison to enjoy herself—even though he couldn’t possibly have meant it. He’d said, *I don’t want you to hate it. I certainly don’t want it forced on you.* There was no need to worry about that. Zaydan didn’t have to force her to do anything. She’d been his willing, eager slut all night, playing the role of the uptight, long-suffering wife dying to break free to a T. But was she playing a role at all? Madison had been fully herself in that bed.

Madison was exhausted and fried. She only looked for her pajamas for a moment before giving up and slipping into bed beside Kane naked. She couldn’t worry about what message she was sending. He wouldn’t attack her. She trusted him to stop when she said no—if she said no.

His arm slid right around her waist. Madison snuggled back against him. It was instinct. Maybe it was another betrayal of Charles, but she needed to be held by someone who cared about her. He pressed his lips to her shoulder, and she clutched the arm that held her.

“Sorry I woke you.”

“You didn’t. I never fell asleep. Tonight was eventful. I couldn’t sleep knowing you were with him anyway.”

“Damien...”

“I know it’s not my place to worry that way, but I can’t help it.” He squeezed her tighter. “Are you okay, Maddy? You’re shaking.”

“I’m fine. My night was like yours. Very eventful.”

Kane brushed his lips over her shoulder. Her breath caught in her throat. They brushed her neck, and she began to melt. It didn’t matter how many times Zaydan fucked her. Madison’s body responded to Kane the same way it always had. She felt him thickening against her, and her core tightened.

“I don’t think your night was anything like mine, Maddy.”

She tensed. “What did you hear?”

“The team didn’t tell me anything. You know it’s not like that.”

Yeah, they’re just calling me a slut behind my back, she thought.

Kane pulled away from her, and she turned to see him pulling out his earwig and putting it in the nightstand drawer. “It’s just us now.” He pulled her back into his arms, but they were facing each other. His cock was hot along her stomach. She touched it without thinking.

“Damien, the way I am with him scares me.”

He brushed her wet hair back from her face. “You were doing your job. It’s no different than it was before. It’s just another form of undercover work. You have to become someone else and go to a place where you become someone else. It doesn’t define you.”

“But it’s not like before. I thought it would be, but it’s not. I thought it would be harder...because of Charles. It *should* be. Maybe for a second it was—that first time. But then I was into it...feeling it...and deep down, it wasn’t just about the job. I wanted it. I wanted...him.”

Kane twitched in her hand at the confession. *That much hasn’t changed,* she thought. *He always acted bothered by it, but I know what my...work...did to him.* Looking into his eyes, an hour before sunrise, Madison didn’t worry about what she should do. She needed more than Kane holding her. She stroked him.

“I’m not going to judge you for liking it, Maddy.” His voice had grown husky. “Fuck what anyone else thinks. Liking it is what makes you good at it. They’re lucky they found someone who does what no one else can do.” He caressed the swell of her hip, tightened his fingers on the softness of her ass.

“But *I* judge me. Back then, I didn’t have a husband.” She saw him wince. “Sorry, I know it was hard on you, but it was still different. I’m someone’s wife. I’m someone’s mother, Damien. What kind of example am I? What if Penny ever found out what her mother does?”

“Saving the world? She’ll never know the details. But she should be proud. Fuck, Maddy. I’m proud of you. I know this has been hell on you.”

Madison allowed a weak smile. She’d stopped stroking him, but now she squeezed him tighter, and was rewarded with a strangled grunt. He grabbed her ass harder.

“But not in the way it should be. It’s hell...*because* it’s not. Fuck, Damien, why do I like it more now? When he touches me...kisses me... god, when he’s inside me... I want it so bad, I can’t think straight. I should be lying there thinking of Charles and waiting for it to end. But...god...I’m *begging* him for it.”

“Life isn’t simple, Maddy. You can love Charles and still want this. I never questioned how you felt about me back when we...”

“When we did this?”

Madison kissed him. It started with a tentative brush of the lips. She was shy in a way she wasn’t with Zaydan. But Kane surged in her hand, and she pushed her tongue into his mouth. She needed him—to feel his acceptance for what she was. She needed to feel the connection they still had. Kane wouldn’t *just* fuck her. It would matter between them, even though it shouldn’t.

“Maddy...are you sure about this?” He searched her eyes.

“I need this, Damien. I need *you*.”

She didn’t hold anything back the second time she kissed him. She twisted his graying hair in her fingers and drove her tongue into his mouth, moaning when he chased it back. She worked his cock in her fist, smearing his excitement along her stomach. His fingers found her soaked when they pressed between her legs.

“*Ohhh...Damien...yesss... I...need...*”

“I know what you need,” he growled, between kisses. “I feel it. Christ, you’re drenched.” He slid his fingers up and down her slick slit, and she

rolled her hips at him for more. He pressed his fingers inside her. “So damn open, Maddy...”

“I’m...I’m sorry...ohhh....he...did this...ruined...”

“Hey.” He locked his eyes on hers. She couldn’t look away. “Don’t tell me you’re sorry. You’re perfect, exactly the way you are.” His fingers worked her pussy. Madison trembled. Her mind was clouded with need. All she wanted was Kane inside her. “He didn’t ruin you. You took everything he had, and never backed down.”

“Yesss...ohhh fuck yesss...Damien...”

“I feel what he did. Feel how he took you,” he grunted, pumping his fingers harder. “I only want you more...Maddy...take you back...”

“Ohhh fuck...reclaim me...please...feel what he did to me...prove you still want me...”

Kane rolled on top of her. He sank into her pussy with one slow, deep thrust. She felt...used. He’d have known he wasn’t the first man in her that night, even if he hadn’t *known*. He knew Zaydan came inside her—how many times?—but he was going to erase all that. He wasn’t her husband, but he would reclaim her all the same.

“Fuck...do you feel it...”

“Yeah...god, yes...Maddy...you feel...”

“Fucked...taken...used... God, he used me...all night...any way he wanted...”

Kane drove his hips into her. Their bodies found that old magic. They moved together with fluid grace. It did not feel like fucking. He wasn’t angry or disgusted. He wanted her more with every filthy admission. He wanted to exercise every dirty demon. He’d prove Zaydan was only borrowing her. Kane’s claim on her predated all of them—even her husband.

“Tell me, Maddy...what he did...how he used you...what you begged for...”

“All of it...wanted...all of it... When he fucked me in front of you...those men... Fuck, Damien... It was so wrong...to let him...”

“You...uhnnn...loved it...”

“Yesss...god, yesss... Fuck me, Damien...”

The bed strained under them. Madison locked her legs around his waist. Her nails dug half-moons into his shoulders. Damien welcomed the pain. His hips pumped harder. Her hips rolled back to match him. He was fucking Zaydan out of her because he made her feel things that bastard never could. *She’s mine*, he thought.

“Pinned me to his bed...hand on my neck...forced my face down...made me beg for him...”

“You did...you begged him...”

“Begged him to fuck me...ohhh god...begged him to own me...”

“Lies...not his...”

Madison remembered it so vividly. Zaydan forcing her face into the pillows. She struggled—pushed back—but then his finger found her, already dripping with his cum. He mercilessly worked her clit until she did it. She cried, *“Yesss...you fucking own me... Now prove it... Fucking own my pussy...”* He’d laughed. She didn’t care because he made her come so easily.

Damien was wrong. It wasn’t a lie. When Zaydan pinned her to the bed, hand on her neck, pounding her pussy, and she’d begged him to own her, she’d meant every word. Every fucking word.

“Fuck! Dam...mian... Fuck! I’m...”

“Yeah... damn it, Maddy... Come for me... Take it... Mine now...”

“Yes! Ohmygod, yes! Yours! Damien... Fuck... Need you...”

Madison arched off the bed. The climax Kane gave her was deeper than any of the orgasms Zaydan forced out of her. The prince only possessed her body. But Damien knew her—in ways even her husband didn’t. He knew

every broken, stained part of Madison, and he wanted her because of it, not in spite of it.

Kane grunted, and she felt him flood her. She worked him inside her, drawing out every drop. It was an affirmation that she needed him.

“Yes, baby, yes... I want it... I want you... give me all of it...”

It came out as a breathy whisper, not the uncontrolled cries of her orgasm. Drained, he sagged onto her, and Madison held on with wild desperation. She softly thanked Kane, eyes wet.

Madison lay there, holding Kane, and wondered if she could have that moment with Charles. Could he handle the messy parts of her? She’d always hidden them from him. She didn’t think a man like Charles could love all of her. But she’d never given him a chance.

Her fear had robbed him of that, and ultimately made her turn to another man for what she was afraid to ask her husband for. It was a different kind of betrayal, and it was all on her. Even as she held Kane, thankful for what he gave her, she vowed that it couldn’t happen again. When she went home, she would give Charles everything. She would finally trust him to see all of her.

six

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Kane was not in the mood. Zaydan was dialed up to eleven, and Kane wasn't having it. He tried to keep to himself, sitting in the shade, up toward the front of the boat, a long, wide cruiser with a flying bridge. But the prince would not stop picking at him. Kane had gotten no sleep and was having trouble restraining himself.

Zaydan wanted to needle him. That was obvious from the moment they set foot on the boat, which was moored at the private dock on the bay. It wasn't enough that Madison had spent the night in his bed, and everyone knew it. He had to ensure that they all knew what a slut she was for him. In any other circumstance, Kane would have taken one of those long, serrated knives and gutted the bastard.

Sergei didn't look any happier to be there than Kane was. The two men he'd brought with him laughed and muttered in Russian every time they looked over at the American, but Sergei was sour. When he looked Kane's way, he quickly looked away, like he'd been caught. It gave the spy an uneasy feeling.

Sergei had made it clear at dinner that he wanted to get on with business, not go fishing, but it felt like more than that to Kane. Years in the field had taught Kane to trust those feelings, and he kept on alert. He shaded his eyes and looked to the sky for the invisible drone he knew was

up there somewhere, keeping watch. It didn't matter. No one could reach him if something happened out on the water.

"Was Melissa still in bed when you got up to join us?" Zaydan asked. He'd dragged the group out of bed bright and early.

"She was," Kane grumbled. "Didn't move at all when I got out of bed. But she had quite a lot to drink last night. She's not ordinarily much of a drinker."

"Yes, she did drink quite a lot. Those lips are just asking for a taste.

Kane didn't rise to the bait. He imagined David Richardson would take the high road—until Zaydan pushed it too far.

"I would let her relax today. I'm sure she needs her rest." Zaydan's smile dared him to say something.

"Mel knows what she needs. I mostly just follow her lead."

"Yes, she does. And she's not afraid to ask for it. Loudly. Over and over again."

Kane stood, wobbling before he got his sea legs under him. They were so far out that he wasn't sure which of the properties along the shorefront belonged to the prince. It was choppy out on the water that morning. Their lines were in the water. Their poles were mounted, awaiting a nibble.

"Listen. I'm willing to let Mel go off with you because of what she gets out of it..."

"And because you are cuck, *da*?" Sergei didn't smile when he said it. He was picking at his fingernails with the tip of a very sharp knife. "You like to watch wife fuck."

"I like to watch her receive pleasure, yeah. It's called compersion," Kane replied. *Compersion* was one of the terms in his study material. "It means I love her, and I'm secure enough to indulge her pleasure."

"*Da*. Secure," Sergei snorted.

"You should have been there last night, my friend. You would have seen Melissa receive a lot...of pleasure. Why didn't you join us?"

“Was I invited?” Kane pointedly asked.

“If Melissa had insisted that you join us, I would have sent for you, of course. I think it may have slipped her mind. I apologize, but I kept her distracted.”

Kane squinted behind his sunglasses and clenched his jaw, recalling what Madison had moaned while he reclaimed her, “*Begged him to fuck me...ohhh god...begged him to own me...*”

Distracted indeed, he thought.

“Or she thought you jerking off in corner was buzzkill,” Sergei offered.

Kane stepped toward Sergei. He’d take it from the prince because he was the target, but he wouldn’t take it from both men. The other Russians stopped laughing and straightened up. Sergei turned the knife outward, pointing it at Kane’s chest.

“Do not try to reclaim your manhood by challenging me,” Sergei said. “Not unless you want to become chum out here. *Da?* You understand.”

“Okay, Sergei. Take the temperature down.” Zaydan said, putting a hand on the Russian’s shoulder. “Maybe I’ve been out of hand. Truly, David, I apologize. You honor me with your wife. She has me in such a good mood that perhaps I forget myself.” He put his other hand on Kane’s shoulder.

“This has nothing to do with you anyway,” Kane said, ignoring the prince. “I don’t care what kind of shady business you’re here for, but you can keep away from my wife and me.”

Sergei laughed. Kane’s blood boiled. “I will fuck her if I choose to. I don’t take orders from some American asshole or his bitch.”

Kane pushed past Zaydan’s hand. The tip of Sergei’s knife pricked his shirt, but he didn’t back down. He was prepared to shove that knife up the Russian’s ass. Sergei’s postured never changed, like he didn’t question who had the upper hand, but Kane didn’t care about his flunkies either. He would take them all. For once, he didn’t have to worry about Rami. Zaydan left his bodyguard on shore.

“Why so upset? She’s not even your wife. What do you care if she fucks Zaydan all weekend long? She can just stay in his bed.”

Kane’s blood ran cold. He’d gone after Sergei because emotion clouded his judgment, but he kicked into tactical mode like a switch had been thrown. He evaluated Sergei and his men, deciding who he had to take out first and how he could use the confines of the deck to his advantage.

“That’s too far, Sergei. She is still his wife. Even I know where that line is,” Zaydan protested.

“No, I mean she is not actually his wife because they are not David and Melissa Richardson.”

“This isn’t funny,” a confused Zaydan replied, looking between the men.

“You shouldn’t try to be funny,” Kane said, low and measured. “Russians aren’t very good at it. Stick with the doom and gloom. It suits you.”

“Tell me, Damien Kane. Is it difficult to pretend to be upset that she’s fucking Zaydan when she’s just another coworker to you?”

Kane slapped the knife aside, slitting the front of his shirt open. He ignored the thin red line it left across his skin and reached for Sergei’s throat, but stopped dead when he felt the muzzle of a pistol pressed to his temple. Sergei finally smiled.

“What is going on? Have you lost your mind, Sergei? Why does he have a gun out? None of you are supposed to be armed.”

“Perhaps you should be thanking me for being prepared. Mr. Kane here may have been planning to make his move without your man here to stop him.”

“What move? Who is Damien Kane?” Zaydan sputtered.

Sergei looked at the prince, eyes hardening. “Your games, your weakness for married women, have brought the wolf into the henhouse. The

Richardsons are a fiction created by the Americans. Meet Damien Kane, an operative of the CIA.”

“He’s full of shit,” Kane protested. Even he knew he sounded like he was lying.

Zaydan continued to look from Sergei to Kane. He didn’t want to believe it. Kane wondered if that was because of general pride, or if he was so into fucking Madison that he refused to believe she may have been acting the entire time.

“Then who is Melissa?” he asked.

Sergei flashed the deadliest smile Kane had ever seen.

“That, my friend, is the sweetest part of this. She is also CIA. She is a whore paid by the US government to fuck your secrets out of you. Her name is Madison Sinclair, and I have business with her.

Sergei knew everything. Had he somehow recognized Madison? Kane didn’t have time to calculate the how. He was busy trying to figure out if he could swim the distance to the shore.

Kane hoped that the overwatch drone would see him go overboard, and they’d send someone to fetch him. That was his best shot. He was pretty sure they were out of comms range on the bay. Once they picked him up, they could race back to the compound, unless Bristow had already sent the tactical team in.

Maddy will be safe, he told himself. She can handle herself.

Sergei acknowledged Zaydan’s open-mouthed stare. “Do not worry, my friend. We will get the truth out of that cunt when we get back to shore. It will be my greatest pleasure in life.”

“Don’t you fucking dare—”

Kane’s threat was abruptly cut off when the Russian slammed the gun against the side of his head. He went to one knee, blood dripping onto the white deck from his temple.

“Do not threaten me while I hold your fate in my hand, Mr. Kane,” Sergei said.

“We need to get back,” Zaydan said. “I can radio ahead.”

“Before we do that,” Sergei said. “We need to decide to deal with Mr. Kane out here or bring him back and take our time.”

“I’m not going to beg,” Kane sneered.

“Unlike your whore partner,” Sergei laughed.

Kane lunged up from his knee, but he had barely moved when he felt a sharp pain in his head and the world went black.

“WE HAVE TO GO IN,” Cassandra insisted, staring down the Deputy Director while she leaned into space.

They were watching Sergei’s goons dragging what looked like a unconscious Kane onto the dock on the feed from the overwatch drone. Cassandra hoped he was just unconscious. They hadn’t just tossed him overboard, so she had hope.

“We can’t. Sinclair doesn’t have Null:Echo. The last thing we saw before comms cut out, she was sunning herself by the pool. She didn’t turn up anything on her scouting mission while the boys were out fishing.” Bristow gave no ground.

“If we go in, we can scour the compound. It’s got to be there somewhere,” Dentiger added, backing Cassandra. It wasn’t just because they were sleeping together. He wasn’t about to hang Madison and Kane out to dry.

“It’s software, Dentiger. For all we know, the Russians are only going to download it when they have their money. We cannot intervene until we’re sure Null:Echo is in hand. If Kane is already dead, he’ll have died for nothing if we don’t get it.”

Bristow was tired of being challenged. She understood their concern for their teammates, and she wasn't unsympathetic, but they had larger concerns.

"Let's assume Madison is still in play. Maybe they knocked Kane out so they can pull a train on her, I don't know. How will we know if she gets it if our comms are down?" Dentiger asked.

"Tay," Cassandra said, making a face at his distasteful scenario.

"Speaking of which, how is that coming, Manny?" Bristow asked.

"I'm not getting them back. I think the Kharabatis or the Russians are jamming our signal somehow."

"I thought these next-gen comms were unjammable," Bristow scowled. "What did we pay those millions of dollars for?"

"Anything can be jammed if you know what to look for. I'll keep looking for a workaround, but you'd better have a backup plan."

"We go in," Dentiger insisted.

"When I was in the field, I would have been pissed if they pulled me out before the job was done. Wouldn't you feel the same way, Dentiger?" Bristow asked.

"Madison knows we have Overwatch. If she gets Null:Echo, she'll figure out a way to signal us," Cassandra suggested with an optimism she did not feel.

"She has kids," Dentiger pleaded.

Bristow wasn't surprised it was a man playing that card. Would he be so concerned if it was a father in there? "A lot of officers have kids, Dentiger. They still do their jobs. And Sinclair will, too. We sit tight."

She hoped she was right.

seven

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Madison was antsy. She tried to enjoy lying by a beautiful pool on the patio of a huge Hamptons mansion, but too much weighed on her mind. Keeping focused on the mission was a hard enough task. They were so close to the end, and there were so many variables. The more time she spent around Sergei, the more unpredictable he seemed. Madison didn't like wild cards.

More concerning, she'd been unable to contact the team. When she reached out on comms, there was only silence. Madison pulled out the spare that was hidden in her lipstick, and that was dead, too. Whatever the problem was, she hoped Manny solved it soon.

But clouding everything was the time she spent with Zaydan and what it did to her. Madison hadn't forgotten that he was the enemy. She was intimately familiar with his file. She knew the evil the Kharabati royal family had perpetuated in the world. But when she was with the prince, she felt things she couldn't control. It was a side of her that she'd always been able to rein in when she'd been in the field as a younger officer, but everything felt different now.

She wasn't falling for Zaydan—that would have been easier to understand. His effect on her was something else, something primal. When he touched her, when he purred in her ear, telling her how he was going to

take her, how she was his, it triggered something. Madison wasn't proud, but Zaydan somehow made her want it—all of it. The wild abandon. The control.

Madison didn't worry about betraying the team, but she did worry that she wouldn't be ready—sharp—when the time came. They needed to get Null:Echo. She needed this to be over.

The sun was rapidly burning off what had been a cool morning, and the humidity was thicker than ever, making her chest tight when she breathed. Madison was used to swampy DC summers, but that weekend in the Hamptons was brutal—even by the water. Still, she stayed out by the pool, letting the sun's heat bake life back into her after an exhausting night in Zaydan's bed. Even though she used SPF 1,000,000, she frequently reapplied it to her pale, freckled body. Irish genes and sun-worshipping did not mix.

Madison had expected Kane to be back already. The men had been out early, and the note he left said he'd be back by lunch. But it was past noon, and there was still no sign of him. Kane hadn't stayed because he was having a good time with Zaydan and the Russians. She felt bad thinking about her partner being held hostage on that boat while the men around him drank and got rowdy.

She sipped her sparkling water and scrolled social media on her phone—Melissa Richardson's phone. The device had been meticulously curated to match her cover. Zaydan's security had been crystal clear that she was expected to keep it tucked away whenever he was around, but Madison was alone and needed the distraction. The prince wasn't with her, but she'd noticed that a member of the security staff conspicuously followed her wherever she went.

"There you are," Zaydan called to her, coming through the sliding patio door. "The staff told me you were out here. I'm happy to see you're relaxing."

Madison smiled, hoping that he interpreted her heat flush as blushing. “I need to rest after last night.”

“Didn’t you sleep in? Why get up early if you don’t have to?” He walked down the shallow steps to join her poolside and sat on the lounge beside hers.

“I did, but I’m an early riser. I can’t sleep too late, no matter how exhausted I am.

Zaydan’s eyes were shaded by designer sunglasses, but they didn’t hide the way his eyes swept over her curves in the green, string bikini she’d chosen. Reclined, her breasts threatened to spill from the sides, and she knew he’d like the back if she were standing. The swimsuit wasn’t the dental floss and triangles younger women wore these days, but it was more daring than any two-piece Madison would have worn in her real life.

“Please, get your rest, sweet Melissa. I promise you’ll need it.”

The prince gestured to someone inside the house. Rami was stationed just inside the doors, but it wasn’t him. She was becoming accustomed to the silent man, always standing watch—even in her most intimate moments. Madison had trouble wrapping her head around how many people had watched her have sex over the last month.

“It sounds like you have plans,” she said, feeling a tingle of anticipation. She tried to remind herself, *This is a job*.

Zaydan leaned forward and put his hand on her thigh. She sighed and relaxed into his touch. Even though she was still sore from last night, her body knew what it wanted.

“That’s your fault for wearing that bikini. I can’t see you like that and not have plans for that body.”

“Stop it. You talk about me like I’m this sex goddess. I’m a regular woman, just like any other woman. I’m a mom. A wife. I wish I could see what you do when I look in the mirror. I don’t believe that you wouldn’t

rather be with some tight young thing than a mom who's closer to fifty than forty."

Madison didn't know how much of that speech was Melissa and how much was her own. The mention of being a wife made her wonder where Kane was. She didn't see him leaving her alone with Zaydan for long.

"Please, you're anything but a regular mom. I think you proved that last night."

He moved to sit on the edge of her lounge. His hand on her thigh slid higher. She subtly parted her legs. After last night, she wasn't worried about seeming too easy anymore. He knew exactly how easy she was now.

"Zay, the things we did... I need you to know, I've never done anything like that. I think I went a little crazy. The things I said... The way I..."

"Begged?" He looked like he'd won the lottery when he said it. "I remember very well. Once you got started... Well, I think the real you came out."

His confidence bordered on smarmy, and it made Madison want to stop him in his tracks. Men like Zaydan were too used to getting what they wanted. But then he was touching her through her bikini bottom, and she remembered why he got what he wanted. She gasped and nudged her hips at his hand.

"Do we have to...mmm...do this here? Let's go back to your room," she whimpered, biting her bottom lip.

The throbbing between her legs grew so quickly. Her body responded to him too easily. She knew she should wait until Kane turned up, but she didn't want to. She tried to rationalize that it was better for the mission to keep Zaydan distracted.

"Have you ever fucked under the sun, Melissa?"

He paused touching her long enough to roll her bottoms down to mid-thigh. *I can't believe I'm doing this...again*, she thought. She was a little

relieved that comms were down for the moment. When his fingers slid up her slit, he found her wet and ready.

“Still so eager, even after last night. I’m pleased that you’re not claiming you need downtime.”

“Oh, I do. But you have a way of making me forget about everything else. Everything but...mmm...this...”

“You won’t be able to go back to your boring, routine life after this.”

“Zay... Stop it, it’s just...*ohhh...sex...*”

He chuckled, enjoying how she eagerly rolled her hips up at his hand. “You’ll know the truth before the weekend is over.”

“Zay...*please...ohhh god...*”

He curled two fingers inside her, hitting that sweet spot. She was sore from the pounding he’d given her all night, but she still clenched around him, greedy for his touch.

The woman appeared out of nowhere. She was a member of the staff, and she carried in a frozen pina colada in a giant bowl of a glass. It even had an umbrella. She only paused for a moment to watch Zaydan finger Madison under the midday sun. Her look said she’d seen this before. He thanked her, and she smiled, excusing herself.

“*Ohhh fuck...Zay... That’s terrible... God, she must think I’m a...*”

“Slut? Or a woman who’s enjoying herself? Don’t worry, Melissa. My staff knows how to be discreet.” He lifted the bowl of frozen goodness and pressed the straw to her lips.

Madison sucked on the sweet, slushy drink. It felt so decadent to be sipping a tropical drink poolside while a handsome younger man played with her pussy. She did not feel like this could be her life, but it wasn’t. *This is Melissa Richardson’s life*, she reminded herself. *You belong back at home, on the sidelines of Penny’s game.* But it was very much Madison’s pussy he was fingering.

Zaydan set the drink aside and pulled her bikini top open, exposing her pale breasts to the sun. She whined that he had to stop, but she didn't make a move to stop him. When he grabbed a breast and rolled her stiffening nipple, his hand was cold from the drink, and she whined, trying to pull away from him.

"Fuck, Zay... That's cold!"

"Mmm, darling. You're warming my hand up," he grinned.

"Bastard...ohhh...you're enjoying this too much..."

Zaydan pulled the straw from her drink and dribbled frozen pina colada all over her breasts, instantly making her nipples throb to hardness. She tried to smack his hand away from her, and some of the slush splashed her face. He smiled, and she knew exactly what he was thinking that looked like. Madison had two hands to fight off his one and was winning until his thumb found her clit.

"Ohhh fuck...Zay.... That's not...fuck...fair...baby..."

He leaned forward and sucked the slushy sweetness from her chest. Her entire body pulsed. Madison was so close. She needed to get there.

"What will you do if I let you come?" he asked, kissing her. He tasted sweet.

"Like you could...mmm...stop me..."

He took his thumb off her clit.

"Ohhh god...fuck you..."

Melissa probably didn't say *fuck you*, but Madison was too close to care.

"Anything I want?" he teased.

She knew it was dangerous to promise that to a man like Prince Zaydan, but she was too close.

"Yesss...oh god...yesss...just..."

He shifted the angle of his fingers, driving in and out of her, and focused on her clit. Madison came so quickly, so easily, that it was like he

could have brought her to climax any time he wanted. Her wild cry felt so out of place beside the pool. She both hated him for it and loved that he used that power. God, a powerful man was hot. He kept rubbing her pussy until she pushed it away. It was too much.

Madison rolled onto her side and grabbed the frozen drink, drawing deeply on the straw in between her labored breaths.

Zaydan stood and pulled off his tight, patterned sports shirt. Madison stared, sucking on her straw, wondering where he found time for the gym in between bedding other men's wives and funding terror cells. *He didn't need to be so hot*, she thought.

His snug shorts followed, and his thick erection sprang out, pointing at her like an accusation. Seeing it out there in the afternoon sun was shocking. A big, thick cock like that didn't belong out in the open. She'd only seen it up close in dimly-lit rooms at night, but now she saw every detail—the flared head, the veins running along its dark length, the heavy balls beneath it that had filled her with cum three times last night. She knew it looked even more impressive because he was buzzed down there.

"I love the way you stare at my cock, Melissa. It shows me how badly you needed this." He smiled, proud, with a hand on his hip. His shaft pulsed with his heartbeat.

Madison hated that she was caught staring, but she couldn't help it. The thing was right there, hovering above her face like a threat—or a promise. She couldn't decide which. Her core tightened as she recalled how it stretched her. "I didn't *need* it," she argued.

"Need...want... There's no need to split hairs. The point is that you look at my cock like a woman who very much needs a good, hard fucking."

Zaydan knelt, placing a knee on the lounge, and laced his fingers in her copper mane. Madison knew what he wanted, and resisted when he tugged her head forward—but not much.

"Can't we take this inside, Zay?" she asked, voice low and breathy.

Her protest was undermined when she wrapped her hand around his thickness. She slowly pumped, and excitement dripped from his tip. She resisted the urge to catch it with her tongue.

“It’s such a beautiful day. The breeze off the bay is refreshing. Do you really want to be stuck inside?” His cocky grin was a challenge.

Madison rolled her eyes and pressed her lips to him, suckling his sticky precum from it. He gasped when her tongue peeked out to taste him, and then he groaned her name when her lips stretched to encircle his head. Zaydan tightened his fingers in her hair, and she sucked harder. Somehow, he just knew what she liked, and he had from the beginning. It was like he had a file on her, too.

“Don’t tell me that you don’t need it...*mmmm...yesss...*not when you’re sucking it like that.”

Instead of arguing with him, she pushed half into her mouth, relaxing her jaw. Sucking the prince took an effort that she hadn’t had to put into a blowjob in years. That wasn’t a knock on her husband. Charles was fine. She loved his cock. He just wasn’t as big as the built, younger man. Inhaling sharply through her nose, Madison pushed even deeper, taking him right to the back of her throat. She held him there, working her tongue against him.

Zaydan grunted and tried to push deeper, nudging the back of her throat. She resisted, but she loved seeing that moment when their control slipped, and she had the power. That was Madison’s favorite part of having a dick in her mouth.

“*Suck it... Suck me...faithless whore...*” he muttered in Arabic.

It was not the first time she’d caught him saying vile things to her in his native tongue. The prince had no idea that she spoke his language. Melissa certainly wouldn’t know Arabic. She looked forward to blowing his mind and saying something to him in Arabic when it was all over.

Madison bobbed, lips sealed tightly around his shaft, tongue swirling. Her cheeks hollowed, bulging where his cock pushed against them. She tried to control his depth with her hand wrapped around his base, but Zaydan kept trying to force it deeper—into her throat. Her blue eyes pleaded with him to let her guide him, but his dark brown eyes gave a different response. They told her, *you'll do what you're told*.

Zaydan flexed his hips, shifting the blowjob from Madison, showing off to the prince fucking her mouth. When she'd resisted his aggression with her mouth before, he'd backed off, but that wasn't happening. She sensed something different in him. Anger. It was the first time she felt like he wanted to punish her.

"Don't be shy..." he grunted, thrusting harder, bumping the back of her throat over and over. *"You know how to suck dick, Melissa... Stop pretending... Take it..."*

Madison tried to pull back and reply, but it was muffled because he kept his cock in her mouth. He tilted her head back and thrust harder. *Fine*, she thought. *I'll show you what I can do and ruin you for every other woman*.

Her nostrils flared, and she relaxed her throat. He slid right in. She had to fight panic because he was so thick that he fully blocked her throat. Madison had left her gag reflex behind in high school, but Zaydan was a new challenge. Her body jerked when she fought choking on him.

"Don't fight it...just do what comes naturally...mmm...yesss...submit... your throat was made to take my cock..."

Madison fell back on her training to regulate her response. The Agency didn't teach her how to deep-throat, but it did give her techniques to stay clear and calm in physically and emotionally stressful situations. He was physically punishing her throat, but that wasn't the most distressing part for Madison.

She hated how much she liked it. Having a man take control—even an evil one like Zaydan—made her pussy throb, especially when he was as hot

as the prince. Letting a man tell her what she was going to do, use her throat—push it in harder when she struggled—went against everything she believed in, yet Zaydan had her pussy dripping. She was eager to please him, and more than a little excited that he might make her.

Zaydan abruptly pulled out of her mouth, strings of saliva trailing back to her lips, his cock dripping onto her chest. Madison coughed and sputtered, wiping her hand across her lips, watering eyes staring up at him with a mix of anger and desire.

“I couldn’t breathe,” she rasped, throat raw from his rough treatment.

“Did you want me to stop, Melissa? You were sucking me harder than ever. I know you love it when I *make* you do it. That’s how you let go, isn’t it?” he smirked.

“That’s not...” She didn’t finish with *the point* because he would have seen through the lie.

Zaydan took her hands, pulling Madison with him as he sat on the other lounge. The strong, younger man easily guided her on top as he lay back.

“What are you doing, Zay?” she asked, straddling him with her slick furrow rubbing the base of his cock. “You don’t really want to... Out here...”

“Should have thought it through before you promised me anything.”

“Zay...I can’t...we can’t What if...”

“I don’t care who sees us. I want everyone to know I’m fucking you.”

Even as she protested, Madison was rising over him, grasping his shaft, fitting the flared head against her. “I’m not who you want me to be. I’ll...”

“I know you’re not,” he interrupted, watching her and impatiently waiting for her to settle onto his cock. He didn’t look like he had any doubt she would. “But you’re going to fuck me here by the pool.”

Zaydan didn’t wait. He pulled her down onto his cock. Madison’s eyes went wide, and her mouth hung open. The way he stretched her was amazing. She almost felt guilty for enjoying him when she knew what the

Agency had planned—almost. No matter how many times he made her come, Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati deserved everything he got. They couldn't kill him, but his own people would do worse to him after such an epic screw-up.

“Fuck! Zay...ohhh yesss...”

Madison rolled her hips, grinding down, relishing the way his base stretched her. She would miss the way he felt inside her when they went back to their lives. When she went back to her husband. Even as she rocked on Zaydan, she realized it would be horrible if this feeling popped into her head when she made love to Charles.

“Love how you just go for it, Melissa,” he moaned, taunting her. “Can't get enough...now that I opened you up...”

“You're such...an asshole...ohhh...I should climb off...and slap you...ohhh god...”

“But you won't...ahhh...because I'm right... I love your pussy...”

She wouldn't give him the satisfaction of telling him he was right, but she worked her hips harder, leaning in to fucking him. Her breasts hung forward, swaying with her motion. They were too tempting a target, and Zaydan released her hips to knead them. He was rough, and Madison loved it, shoving her tits into his hands.

“Fuck...yesss...just like that...ohhh god...Zay...”

“Can't...get...enough...can you?”

“I can't...ohhh fuck...I can't...”

“Come on my cock...show me how hard you can come, Melissa,” he growled, jacking his hips up hard into her, jolting Madison with every thrust.

“Fuck! Yes! Fuck me! Ohmygod!”

Madison cried it at the sky, no longer worried about who heard her or saw her. She just wanted to get as many orgasms out of Zaydan's thick cock as she could before he came.

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“At least Maddy seems safe for now,” Dentiger wryly commented, watching the poolside action unfold on the feed from the overwatch drone flying 40,000 feet above the Kharabati compound.

The optics were amazingly sharp for the distance. The team saw everything. Dentiger imagined he could hear her cries of ecstasy, but the feed from her comms was still down. He was just as worried as he’d been a few minutes before when they’d seen Kane dragged off the fishing boat, but he was annoyed that Madison was fucking the target while the bad guys did who-knew-what to her partner.

It was completely unfair. He understood that Madison couldn’t possibly know what had happened to Kane. But he wondered if she would stop fucking the prince long enough to ask where her partner was.

“Any progress with those comms, Sanz?” Bristow asked the team’s tech guy, ignoring Dentiger’s misogynistic comment. She knew he wouldn’t make the same crack about a male colleague.

“I’ve got nothing, but I’m still trying. I swear, it’s like they know exactly what tech we’re using, but that’s impossible, unless...” Manny didn’t finish the sentence because no one liked to think about that possibility.

“Unless the Kharabatis or the Russians have a source at the Agency. I don’t want to believe that’s true,” Cassandra replied.

“DS&T is locked down tighter than almost any other part of the Agency. I don’t want to believe it either, but they should not be able to jam this. They shouldn’t even know about this,” Manny complained.

“I’m sure it’s blind luck, or they thought of something we didn’t. Just keep trying. We’ve got to get in touch with them. We need to know what’s going on with Kane,” Bristow said.

“How long do we let this play out with Madison and Kane cut off like this?” Cassandra asked.

“As long as we have to. We do not make a move until Null:Echo is secured.” Bristow was firm.

“And if they get killed and we still don’t have Null:Echo?” Dentiger asked, flexing his fingers into fists. He was already working out plans to go around the Deputy Director.

“That’s not going to happen. We’ll just keep watching and be ready to go on a moment’s notice.”

That was exactly what they did, watching as Madison rode Zaydan as hard as she could, throwing her head back like she was shouting up at the drone.

ZAYDAN STARED AT THE PANTING, sweaty MILF on the other lounge and just did not want to believe she was anything other than the well-off suburban mom looking for excitement in her empty-nest days. It was inconceivable that the whole thing had been a setup and he hadn’t seduced her into his bed. He was a better judge of people than that. No one was that good of an actor.

The Russian was holding out on him. Zaydan was certain of that. He'd happily spilled every detail about CIA officer Damien Kane, but he'd refused to tell him anything about "Melissa Richardson." She was obviously another operative, Damien Kane's undercover wife. Sergei said he planned to make her part of the Null:Echo demonstration.

Zaydan had no choice but to agree. Dangling the promise of the massive payday didn't even budge the man. He could only hope that Sergei understood his position. His brother's advisors would be there. Zaydan could not be humiliated in front of them. He already had to disappear the Americans from the Earth. He would do the same thing to the Russians if Sergei was foolish enough to test him.

"Do you know where Dave is?" she casually asked, sucking on the straw of her pina colada. If she kept that up, Zaydan would see those lips around his cock again.

"I thought I told you. He went back with Sergei and his crew to the other house. He couldn't believe there's a Nets-branded indoor court back there. I think they were going to play a pickup game."

"Really? Dave knows he shouldn't be doing that. Not on that knee he blew out. How much did you have to drink on that boat?"

She lazily rolled onto her side to face him. The way her pale, naked tits looked in the sun—big, natural teardrops—was making him hard again already. Zaydan considered postponing Sergei's demonstration so he could take the redhead inside and spend one more afternoon fucking her. *Perhaps I will fuck the truth out of her*, he thought. Zaydan did not consider himself a cruel man, but he knew he could make a woman, any woman, tell the truth if he had to—even a CIA officer.

"I don't know, Melissa. He's your husband. Perhaps he is keeping secrets from you."

"That doesn't sound like him. Honestly, I'm surprised he left us alone together this long. He knows what will happen." She shyly looked away.

Lying bitch, Zaydan thought. He knows what will happen, but does he even care if you're just his assigned partner? He knows it's your job to whore yourself for America. They have even less regard for their women than I thought.

"That I will fuck you, Melissa? I'm sure he knows. He must have heard it all night last night."

"Zay, do you have to be so mean about it? We're all having a good time here. You don't need to go after my husband." She seemed annoyed, but made no move to cover herself.

"I am just being honest, Melissa. It's you and David who are lying...to yourselves. I fucked you silly last night. You were wild for my cock. And David must know. Even if he didn't hear, he must have had questions."

"We shouldn't talk about that. What's between Dave and me is private."

"Yes, you have your secrets. Married people do. If you want to see him, I'm going back there to work on my deal with Sergei. Why don't you ride with me?"

"Sure, that sounds good. Just let me run back to our room, get cleaned up, and change."

Zaydan openly stared at her tits. CIA officer or not, he knew she liked the way he looked at her. She liked being wanted by him. Perhaps he would fly her back to Kharabat when his business was conducted and enjoy her at his leisure before he disposed of her.

She laughed. "I cannot go back there naked, Zay. I'm already creeped out by the way those Russians look at me. I don't want them to see me like this, after you..."

"Don't want them to see you so well-fucked?" His laugh was louder than hers, harsher. "They know why you're here. We all know why you're here. Just throw your bikini on and let's go. I don't have time to wait anyway."

Madison warily eyed Zaydan. Something was off. This wasn't his usual swaggering confidence. He'd turned cold. That old spy sense she'd developed in the field was screaming that Zaydan was playing a different game. She wiggled into her bikini bottoms and hoped that he was too distracted by her shaking tits to notice a change in her. She was on alert.

Kane didn't go back to play basketball with the Russians. Zaydan should have thought of a better lie than that. He hated the Russians even more than he hated basketball. He was not a sports guy, except for his beloved Birds.

So, where is Kane? she wondered. *Did something happen on that boat?* She could see Sergei pushing Kane until he snapped. Kane was tough, but he couldn't take on all the Russians on a boat. Her blood ran cold. *What have they done to him?* Comms were down. *Does the team even know? Do they have another way of getting eyes on us in here?*

Madison did not want to go back to see Sergei and his men in her bikini, with Zaydan's cum running out of her, but she had to know Kane was safe. *Please, Damien. I need to know you didn't do anything stupid.* Suddenly, she didn't care about the mission at all.

She pulled the mesh cover-up over her head and tugged it down in place over her body. It actually covered very little, but it was better than parading around in the green string bikini. She slid her feet into her flip-flops and picked up her bag.

"Okay, lead the way."

THE HOUSE on the backend of the property was newer, boxy, and dark wood that made it look like several crates had been stacked on top of each other. The Kharabati compound had been created by combining two

separate, multi-million-dollar Hampton properties. They didn't complement each other aesthetically, but were far enough apart that they didn't clash.

Zaydan ushered Madison into the house unannounced. The short golf cart ride had been tense. She didn't know what she was going to find, but it wouldn't be Kane playing basketball with his new Russian friends.

Sergei and his crew were assembled in the great room at the back of the mansion. The floor-to-ceiling windows bathed the room in light and provided sweeping views of a long, pristine lawn and the bay beyond it. The bright, cheerful setting did nothing to dispel Madison's creeping dread.

The Kharabati advisors sat in their own corner of the room. They looked pleased, rather than sporting their normal stern countenances. Madison concluded they liked what they'd seen from Null:Echo. That dashed any hope that the quantum cipher was vaporware.

"What delayed you?" Sergei asked, rising out of a chair by the windows. "We've been waiting."

Zaydan flashed that grin that was becoming less charming every time he showed it. "I was distracted by Melissa's bikini. You can hardly blame me."

Sergei's face hardened. "I don't know why you're still playing these games."

Madison looked around the room. All the Russians were present, and Kane was not. She asked, "Is Dave still with you guys? Zay said he was back here?"

"Is busy," Sergei tersely replied.

Zaydan turned to his advisors and spoke to them in Arabic. Madison kept her face neutral, since she shouldn't be able to understand the conversation. He asked if they fully vetted Null:Echo. A serious man with a long beard and round glasses replied that yes, the cipher was everything the Russians promised.

An older member of the group, Madison had the impression he was a cleric, and told Zaydan that the mess the Russians discovered had to be

cleaned up. His tone made it clear that this was the prince's problem. He glared at Madison when he said it.

"I will handle it," Zaydan snapped.

"This behavior is unacceptable. You lower yourself by associating with..."

"I said I will handle it. Do not forget your place. My family supports your work..."

"I work for your brother. Prince Omar will be most displeased to hear what your whoring has led to. He already believes you spend too much time in the West. These decadent influences are tainting your soul."

"Hold your tongue until we have a chance to speak in private. My brother would not appreciate you gossiping about the royal family."

"The truth is not gossip, my prince."

"Go!"

Zaydan pointed at the door. The cleric was unbowed. He nodded to the others, and all but the money man followed him out of the room. The prince leaned close to Rami and whispered something that Madison didn't catch. The bodyguard nodded and spoke into his wrist.

"Is your drama finished? Can we get on with business?" Sergei asked.

"Yes, it appears that everything is set. My people are satisfied with Null:Echo's authenticity."

Madison tensed and began mapping the exits. The men openly discussing Null:Echo in front of her was not a good sign. And the cleric's anger toward her was about more than Zaydan *whoring* around. She felt like she was the only person in the room without the complete picture. *Where is Kane?* she worried.

"Then please, come sit," Sergei said, sweeping his hand at the long, L-shaped couch.

"I'm satisfied if my people are satisfied," Zaydan said. "We can just do the money transfer and be done with it."

“Sit, I insist. I must show you exactly what Null:Echo can do. I want you to know what you are getting.”

Zaydan looked at Madison, took her arm, and led her around to sit on the couch.

“What is Null:Echo? What’s going on, Zay? I really need to see Dave. I’m getting worried.” Madison hoped her worried, confused wife act sounded legitimate.

“He is downstairs. I’m sure you will see him soon,” Sergei said.

Madison looked around the room for anything she could use as a weapon. There were plenty of blunt objects, but none of them would help her. Sergei’s men were armed, and she was sure she’d seen a silver-finished pistol tucked into the back of his pants. If things were headed the way she suspected they were going, she was fucked.

The Russian tech nerd—she still didn’t know his name—worked on a laptop with a portable drive connected to it. Madison was sure that the drive contained Null:Echo. He pressed several buttons, and the large television over the fireplace mirrored his screen. A terminal window was open, and he typed lines of code she couldn’t understand. The code began scrolling in the window faster than she could follow, and a new, very familiar login window opened.

Madison stared at a CIA secure access portal.

“What is this? Is this all about a video game or something?” she asked, failing to keep the tension out of her voice. She tried to distance herself from Zaydan, but his arm tightened around her.

The portal dissolved into a cloud of dark blue pixels that collapsed. They were in, just like that. As the Russian typed screens flashed by. Madison was only able to catch an image here and there. They’d obviously been in the system before because he moved too quickly to be hunting for information for the first time.

Null:Echo let them right into the Agency's OPF system. Madison gritted her teeth to contain her shock. The Official Personnel Files were held with the tightest security the Agency had to offer because of the catastrophic damage that could be done if officers' identities were revealed.

Like a spinning slot machine landing on a jackpot, the flickering screens finally stopped on a single OPF file.

Madison stared up at her official CIA employee photograph.

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“Pleased to meet you, Mrs. Madison Sinclair,” Sergei said, cruelly grinning at her. “Or perhaps I should say, meet you again, *da*? It bothered me how much you looked like her, because it was impossible, but then you are never who you claim to be, are you, Milica?”

“What is this? What is going on?” Madison was frantic—at least to the men around her. She pulled away from Zaydan, twisting her arm out of his grasp when he tried to stop her, and stood.

“This is pointless, *da*? Do you not see this is over? But please, make this harder. I will enjoy it.”

The situation was so much worse than she thought. Sergei not only knew she was a CIA asset, he knew *exactly* who she was. He knew that she was the woman who seduced and shot his father all those years ago in Moscow. She needed a plan fast, or she was already dead.

“Zay?” She looked at the prince, searching for an opening. He didn’t appear at all shocked.

Zaydan knew. He’d known when he fucked her by the pool. She’d felt something was off, but couldn’t put her finger on it. But it hadn’t been purely a revenge fuck. He was still attached to her. Perhaps she could use that.

“This is all AI deepfake stuff. I don’t know why they’re doing this, but none of it is true. Do I seem like some kind of spy to you?” The words rushed out of her mouth like she was panicked, but she didn’t move toward the prince for protection.

“You are very good, *Madison*. I never suspected a thing, but your role is very close to your real life, according to your file. I suppose Melissa Richardson is a role you were born to play.”

“Zay, it’s not what you think...”

“Is it not?” Sergei asked, turning to track her as she tried to retreat.

“Does your real husband know...that you fuck other men? Or is that just for your fake CIA husband?” Zaydan asked, becoming visibly angrier as he spoke. “What’s his name?”

“Charles. Charles Sinclair. He’s a lawyer or something,” Sergei volunteered.

Fuck, they know everything, she thought, but they would if they had access to her OPF file. It contained her entire life story, if their access was deep enough. Madison had no doubt that Null:Echo had given them access to everything, which was why it was so dangerous. A sudden realization made her blood run cold. *If they know about Charles, they know about...*

Madison couldn’t even think it. That truth might mean the Russians had people watching her family. She knew what they were capable of doing. The Agency would already be in motion to protect Penny and Chaz, if they knew. But comms were down, and Null:Echo left no trace of its entry.

I have to get out of this. I have to warn them. “I don’t know what you’re talking about,” she insisted, almost shouting it.

“We have the files, *Madison*. We know!” Zaydan shouted back. He took a step toward her, like he wanted to strike her. “Stop with your damned games! We know who you are, and soon we’ll know everything else.”

“*Da*, you will give it up, just like your partner, Mr. Kane did,” Sergei added.

Her eyes snapped to the Russian. “Where is he?”

Sergei’s smile spread slowly. “No more denying you know Damien Kane? Good. I am glad we are past lying.”

“Where is he?” Madison was suddenly cool and steely. There was no need to pretend to be the panicked stay-at-home mom anymore. “He’d better still be alive, Sergei.”

“Much better. Our cards are on the table, *da?*” He was pleased, and she hated it. “Damien Kane is not the one you should be worried about, Milica.”

“Why do you keep calling her that?” Zaydan asked, looking between Madison and Sergei.

“Would you like to tell him, or should I?” Sergei waited a beat, while she glared at him.

“You are not the first man Milica here has trapped between her legs,” the Russian continued. “It has been so many years. I read your file, but it did not tell me everything, like how many dicks you sucked for your corrupt imperialist agenda. It must be hundreds by now. A thousand, Milica?” He looked at Zaydan. “Long before she whored herself for you, she whored herself to my father to penetrate his organization. I suspect there’s no one she won’t fuck for her country.”

“Fuck you, Sergei,” she spat.

“Perhaps I am the only one you haven’t fucked—yet. We’re just getting started. Who knows how desperate you’ll be before we’re done? You certainly gave me enough jerk-off material when I was young. For a moment there, I thought maybe I’d get to fuck you like my father did, but I convinced myself that if you fucked me, you would at least enjoy it.”

“Maybe if I had, you wouldn’t be such a miserable little shit now.”

“What is happening?” Zaydan shouted, moving between them. “She fucked your father? When did that happen? Isn’t your father...”

“She was *much* younger. Hotter. Easy for her to trap a man like my father.”

“You still want to fuck me, Sergei. Never got over that teenage crush, I guess.”

Sergei laughed. “Oh, I will still fuck you, Milica. I’ll use up what’s left of you.”

“I can’t wait to see you try.”

Madison spun, keeping Zaydan between her and Sergei and his Russian flunkies. She snagged a tall, brass cat statue that sat on the long, narrow table behind the couch before she broke for the door. She only had concepts of a plan, but the first step was getting out of the room before anyone could draw their weapon and get a bead on her.

Rami stepped into the doorway. Madison swung the statue high, but his huge hand caught it like she was a child with a toy. While she tried to yank it free of his grasp, the massive Kharabati shoved her backward with a hand on her chest, wrenching the statue out of her hand.

She slammed into the table behind the couch. Pain radiated up her back. Madison ignored it. She ducked, trying to go under Rami’s reach. She felt the other men were coming after her now, too. It was over if she didn’t get out of that room. Rami caught her cover-up, and the mesh fabric ripped with a violent sound. She ignored the pain of it biting into her flesh and tumbled forward when she was free of it.

Madison was scrambling to her feet when she heard the distinct sound of a gun cocking behind her. She froze.

“Stop,” Sergei commanded. “If I shoot your kneecap, you will wish I put the bullet in your head. And I will still fuck you until you bleed out.”

“Sergei, this is my house,” Zaydan insisted.

“And you brought fucking traitor into it for me to clean up. Do not lecture me, *pizda*. I do not need your money, but you need Null:Echo. Or I will use it to take your money anyway.”

Madison looked over her shoulder to see two of the Russians had their weapons pointed at Zaydan. Rami pointed his pistol at Sergei's head. But Sergei kept his chrome-plated Desert Eagle pointed down at Madison. She knew that weapon wouldn't just take out her knee. It would probably sever her leg. She definitely stared back into its large bore, but didn't move. The stand-off was not enough for her to escape.

"Let us take the temperature down. We're not going to kill each other over this whore, are we?" Zaydan said. "We're here to do business. Let's do business, and then we will deal with her."

"That will be the celebration, *da*?" Sergei suggested.

"Yes, we will decide what to do with her, but can we put away the guns?"

Sergei appeared to need a minute to think about it before he nodded to his men. They lowered their weapons. Madison thought that Rami might shoot Sergei anyway and then finish the other Russians—giving her a fifty-fifty shot to survive if the Russian's pistol fired in a death spasm. But Zaydan gave his man a look, and Rami holstered his Glock.

Amazingly, Sergei didn't turn and shoot the bodyguard. He said, to no one in particular, "Get the whore back on the couch."

Rami stepped forward and wrenched Madison up by her hair. She fought it, but was still roughly tossed onto the couch. He stared, and she realized she had tumbled out of her bikini top. She tucked her tits back into place.

Kharabati security, drawn by the commotion, poured into the room. If the violence touched off again, no one was walking out of there. Zaydan told his men to stand down with a wave. They lowered their weapons, but didn't relax.

Madison weighed her options. She had none.

KANE SLOWLY REGAINED BLURRY CONSCIOUSNESS. He was on his side on a hard, concrete floor in a dim, narrow room. His head pounded, and everything was stiff. When he tried to move, he discovered that it was because his arms were wrenched behind his back and his wrists had been tightly bound.

“Shit,” he muttered under his breath, realizing that he’d pull his shoulders out of their sockets before he got his hands free.

Enough light came under the door that he could make out his surroundings. His vision began to clear, and he saw that he’d been tossed into a pantry. Canned goods and boxes and jars lined the shelves around him. He rolled and levered himself into a sitting position. Fresh pain blossomed in his head.

“Fuck me.” After several steadying breaths, he sighed, “At least they didn’t kill me and dump me in the ocean.” His last moments on the boat were fuzzy, but he remembered enough.

Kane braced his deck shoes on the floor and slowly pushed until he was against the back wall. His plan to push himself up the wall and stand was quickly abandoned when the strain made his skull explode in agony. He clearly needed a minute.

“Phantom, can you hear me?” he whispered. “Phantom, are you there?”

It took a moment because of the pain in his head, but Kane realized his earwig was missing. Of course, the Russians found it. He’d understood that he was likely out of range on the bay, but he hoped the team took his comms being down as a red flag. They needed help. Even if Kane figured a way out of the pantry, he and Madison could not take on the Russians and Kharabati security on their own.

Kane tested the cord securing his wrists once again. There was no give. He hoped the cavalry was coming.

ZAYDAN STOOD over the shoulder of the Kharabati financial guru, who accessed the royal family's dark money funds on a secured laptop. His Russian counterpart sat opposite with a laptop of his own, completing their end of the transaction. Bitcoin was used for the transaction, but when displayed in US currency, the number contained a staggering number of zeros.

The Kharabati glanced at the prince for one final confirmation. Zaydan nodded. The money man touched enter. Moments later, the Russian's laptop dinged, and he smiled. In Russian, he told Sergei, "We have it."

Madison watched the exchange from the couch with a knotted stomach. Rami stood watch over her, but even if she could get past him, the room was full of armed Russian goons. It wasn't over yet, but she felt like Null:Echo was slipping away. Kane was likely dead. It felt like all of their sacrifices had been for nothing.

Madison would not give up. She'd battled through impossible odds before. *This would be a great time for the team to storm through the gates*, she thought.

The Russian tech nerd type and Madison's file disappeared from the television. He disconnected the portable drive from his laptop and handed it to Sergei, who offered it to Zaydan.

"It has been...*interesting*...doing business with you," Sergei said.

Zaydan took the drive and stared at it. The ruggedized rectangle of metal and silicone didn't look like it was worth such a fortune, but he understood its power. He was torn about what his brother planned to do with Null:Echo, but he understood sacrifices needed to be made for the greater good.

"Interesting is one word for it," he agreed.

Sergei looked at Madison on the couch. "And you've given me something that is almost worth more than the money, not that I plan to return the money."

“Given? Melissa—whatever her name is—is not part of the deal. I will deal with her.”

“Madison Sinclair owes a blood debt to my family. It will be paid.” Sergei tensed.

Watching from the couch, Madison feared a fresh outbreak of violence. She said, “Don’t talk about me like I’m not here.”

“You will keep your whore mouth shut,” Sergei snapped in Russian.

“The way you look at me, I think you’d prefer it open, Sergei,” she replied, her Russian as flawless as his. She savored his surprise.

“Keep talking. Keep making it worse for yourself.”

“Nothing I do will save me, correct? I may as well have my say.”

Sergei coldly smiled. “Oh, but you can make it so much worse for yourself.”

Madison didn’t believe that. Her confidence hid her horror at what she knew the Russian had planned for her. Both men wished her evil, but she knew she’d be better off with Zaydan than Sergei.

“I will deal with Madison,” Zaydan reiterated.

He had no idea what Sergei and the spy said to each other, but her fluent Russian was a fresh reminder that she was not who she claimed to be. A fresh humiliation. Zaydan would make her pay dearly for that.

“I am sorry, *tovarich*, but she must go with us. Her crimes against my family go much further back than whatever she’s done here. Perhaps you can keep a piece of her.”

“I’d rather stay intact,” she interjected.

Both men glared at her.

“Our transaction is complete. Now, you are simply guests in my house. Do not overstep, Sergei. You will take nothing that I do not allow.”

All of the Russians tensed. Rami’s hand moved to the pistol on his hip, and the Kharabati security in the room came to full alert.

“This is your house, and I know your security is very capable, *tovarich*, but do not underestimate my determination to have what is rightfully mine.”

The men stood toe-to-toe. Zaydan regretted not being armed, but he rarely carried a gun. He relied on Rami for that sort of thing. Sergei was a fool if he thought that he could bully Zaydan into taking what he wanted.

Honor demanded that he punish the American for her deception. When the prince was done with her, she wouldn't even remember her name, let alone her alias. He would try to sell her after that, but he doubted there would be enough of her left to fetch a decent price. However, Sergei had elevated the situation to a matter of pride. Zaydan would not let the Russian just demand her and walk away. Sergei was a common thug. He was Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati.

Zaydan lowered his voice to a whisper. The playboy exterior dropped. It was time to prove he was his father's son. Omar was not the only one with balls.

“We are done here. Test me, and the sharks will eat well tonight,” Zaydan said.

The screen came back to life with the image of an elderly man seated behind a desk. What remained of his white hair was clipped closely to his scalp, and a jagged scar ran through it up from the corner of his right eye. The left side of his mouth sagged slightly. He was thicker than Madison remembered. His voice was slurred when he spoke.

And none of that tempered his steel when he spoke. He was not a man to cross.

“Boys, we will settle this like gentlemen,” man on the screen said in accented English. “There is always a deal to be made. I understand her value to you, and I am prepared to compensate you for that. But I will have the American whore. She will spend the remainder of her short life repaying her debt to me.”

Anatoly Reznikov's tone brooked no debate. Madison was his, and the cost of taking her was immaterial. He would pay it.

"Fuck," Madison breathed.

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“I do not believe you have met my father, although I believe he knows your brother, Crown Prince Omar.” Sergei was smug. He knew the effect his father had on other men—even men like Zaydan.

“I am pleased to finally meet you, Prince Zaydan,” Anatoly Reznikov said on the screen. Although I wish the circumstances were better. I hold your brother in high regard. We’ve had many dealings together, which is why I trust that you and I can come to an arrangement regarding the American whore.”

Madison just stared. She knew the man was alive, but knowing it and seeing it were two entirely different things. The voice was raspier with age, slurred from what she’d done to him, but his deep rumble took her right back. Madison had spent months with the Russian crime boss sixteen years ago and heard that voice every day. She remembered how it sounded hungry and labored in her ear when he’d thrust into her.

Seeing Anatoly Reznikov scared Madison more than anything that had happened so far. Also, how deep in bed were the Russians and the Kharabatis? There was nothing in the Operation Scarlet Phantom briefing about an ongoing relationship between the two parties.

“I am sure my brother would send his greetings. He says you have been most cooperative. There is never a request that you cannot find a way to

fulfill,” Zaydan said, stepping back from Sergei and dropping his aggressive posture.

The prince knew Anatoly was not a man to be trifled with.

“I appreciate that, and I hope that goodwill makes this sticky point between us simpler to resolve. I want this American. You would be handing her over to me, not Sergei. He should have made that clear. I apologize.”

“Father...” Sergei interjected.

“Son, please. You have done well in the negotiations over this Null:Echo. I am lost when it comes to these new technology things. But I will handle this discussion. After all, I am the one Milica owes the blood debt to, am I not?”

“Her name is Madison Sinclair, Father. She is a CIA spy.”

“I am aware. I read the file you sent me.” Anatoly looked past his son. He smiled like he was truly greeting an old lover. “Why do you look so surprised to see me, Milica? Perhaps you thought you did your job better? American arrogance makes you sloppy.”

Madison glared at him while she groped for a strong comeback. The sight of the man had frozen her.

“Speak when my father addresses you, whore. Don’t you Americans love a good reunion, with your *Real Housewives* and sitcom reboots? That is not a ghost you are seeing. My father cannot be undone by a woman. You should have stuck to what you are good at and stayed on your back.”

“I guess you’d know. You’ve been sitting in the corner and jerking off to it since you were a teenager,” she replied with a smooth smile.

Sergei started at her, but was stilled by his father’s voice.

“Sergei is right, of course. I would not be here if you were as good with a gun as you are with your cunt. But what do you Americans say, if you love what you do, you’ll never work for a day? Something like that, I believe. And I know which part of your job you love, Milica. I have always remembered you, and not just because of how it ended.” Anatoly gestured

to his face. “A woman does not fuck like you do unless she loves it. That cannot be faked.”

Madison forced herself to stare into Anatoly’s dead eyes. Doing it through an 85” television didn’t make it any easier. “Every man believes that.”

Anatoly laughed. It was a disturbing thing, thick and guttural before it dissolved into a violent hacking. She’d wondered how he’d survived a bullet to the head. The answer apparently was *not well*.

“Oh yes, Milica, I so enjoyed your spirit. Especially when you were crying out, demanding more. Do you still love the cock like you did then?” He addressed Zaydan next, but she knew he was still staring at her on whatever screen was in front of him. “Is she still loud when she comes, Prince Zaydan?”

Zaydan stared at her like remembering how she was in bed made him want to keep her around. Madison would definitely use that if she needed to. She would fuck him again if it meant surviving. The dark, twisted part of her would enjoy it even more because of the danger.

“She does, sir. And a filthy mouth. This begs for it. I don’t believe I’ve ever had a more enthusiastic whore, and I’ve had many. Spy or not, her husband obviously is not giving it to her properly. Perhaps he is tiny. She can’t get enough cock. I plan to put that to the test. Many of my men would enjoy such an eager whore.”

“I understand your disdain, Your Highness. Before she was your whore, she was mine. And I mean no disrespect, of course, but if I was blinded by her charms, I cannot judge you for making the same mistake. There is no shame in being blinded to the treachery of a beautiful woman with a skilled cunt. They’ve exploited this weakness in men since the dawn of time. Perhaps your culture has it right when it comes to keeping your women contained.”

“I think I should be flattered,” Madison said, sitting up on the couch as she found a fresh reserve of confidence. “I don’t believe anyone has told me that I have a *skilled cunt* before. You always did say the sweetest things, Anatoly.”

She was petrified of what these men could do to her, but she would not go down cowering. And if she bought enough time, perhaps the team would do their job and come for her and Kane.

“I’m surprised you’re still at it, Milica. They should have put you out to pasture long ago. Aren’t you all used up and stretched out? Or do you just love to fuck so much that you insisted your CIA kept pimping you out? Bring her closer. Let me see how she’s held up.”

Zaydan grabbed Madison by the arm and dragged her off the couch. He positioned her right in front of the small camera mounted above the television and yanked her bikini top away with a hard tug so swift that she had no time to react. She frantically tried to cover herself, but Rami stepped up and grabbed her arms from behind, pinning them to her sides.

Anatoly licked his lips as he leaned forward for a better look at her. Madison felt his dark lust for her over the thousands of miles that separated them. She stopped struggling against Rami’s iron grasp when she realized it was just making her breasts bounce for the men. She was on display for the Russian mob boss, but all the men around her stared.

Her body betrayed her, nipples plumping under the attention, and she hated it. Danger and desire always had that strange effect on her.

“Hmm, I see why you were so taken, Your Highness. You’ve thickened, but the years have been good to you, Milica. Much better than they’ve been to me, but you had a hand in that, didn’t you? I thought you were too skinny back then. Bigger tits and wider hips suit you. Women are often sexier after they’ve borne children, wouldn’t you agree, Your Highness?”

“Yes, Anatoly. There is something about a woman who’s served her true purpose that makes her so desirable. And yes, these big tits are perfect now

that they've fed as they're meant to."

Zaydan's words were disgusting, and she tried to twist away when he groped her, but Rami was in control. She knew about his MILF fetish, but she'd always pushed it to the back of her mind when she was enjoying him. Madison was flattered that a younger man wanted her like that and chose to ignore the reason why.

He massaged her breasts and rolled her nipples the way he'd learned she liked it. Madison didn't want him to touch her because she didn't want him to feel how much she liked it. Her ability to compartmentalize sex from everything else had always been her greatest strength in the field, but here it was a severe liability.

"Is she still eager for cock?" Anatoly asked.

Zaydan cruelly chuckled. "She was just fucking me by the pool before we came down here. Look at her."

The prince tore away her bikini bottom as suddenly as he'd taken her top. But Madison could not stand there and let him humiliate her like that. She stomped her heel onto Rami's foot. He cursed and loosened his grip enough for her to twist free.

Zaydan moved with a speed she didn't know he had and backhanded her. She reeled, tasting blood, but came right back and smacked him even harder. Guns cocked around her, and Madison held her breath, waiting for the bullet to the back of her head.

"You dare lay hands on me whore!" he raged. He towered over her, touching and cradling his cheek where she'd struck him.

Pussy, she thought, wiping the blood away from her lip like it was nothing. "I've laid hands on you many times, Zay. If you'll let me, I'll do it again just the way you like it. I don't even mind if you get a little rough, but not here. Not like this."

Anatoly laughed again on the television. His labored hacking gave Madison the shivers, but her eyes remained locked on Zaydan's.

“Bring me a blade,” Zaydan said. The cold menace in his voice made her realize that she’d pushed him too far.

“I still expect her to be delivered to me, Your Highness,” Anatoly warned.

“Sergei said I could keep a piece of her. We have a simple remedy for this sort of offense in Kharabat.” One of his security men placed a machete in Zaydan’s outstretched hand.

“An eye for an eye,” Sergei said, nodding approvingly. “I appreciate the simplicity of your justice.”

“Rami, hold her.” Zaydan was emotionless, which was more frightening than his rage.

“No! No! Don’t you fucking...” Madison shouted, contorting when the bodyguard tried to grab her.

“Make sure she doesn’t bleed out. Do you have a torch to cauterize her? I want her alive,” Anatoly said from the television.

Zaydan didn’t hear anyone. His eyes were alight with his rage. He *wanted* to maim her. Madison didn’t think he had that level of cruelty in him—at least not if he had to carry it out personally. She felt like she was seeing the real him for the first time. He tapped the flat of the machete against his palm while he waited for her to be subdued.

Madison spun to drive the heel of her hand into Rami’s throat, but he batted the blow away. She swung a kick and caught him in the hip. He took it with a grunt. Fighting naked felt incredibly awkward, and that slowed her down, even as adrenaline flooded her system. Rami delivered an open-handed blow to the other side of her face. His sheer power knocked her sideways, making her ear ring and blurring her vision.

As she stumbled, Rami took control, roughly grabbing her once again and turning her toward the prince. He forced Madison to her knees and held her arm flat on the coffee table. She struggled, but it was like she was secured by a steel band.

“No! Zaydan! Please...don’t!”

“Yes, Milica. Beg,” Anatoly said, leaning even closer to his screen.

“This is just the beginning,” Zaydan sneered.

Zaydan reared back with the machete, taking it high in the air. Just as he tensed to bring down across Madison’s wrist, gunfire sounded in the distance.

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Bristow was shouting in his ear up until Dentiger slammed the armored SUV into the gates at the entrance to the Kharabati compound. The moment he crossed onto the grounds, comms cut out, jammed by the Kharabatis.

Dentiger had slipped out of the mansion while the team was still watching the drone feed of the Kharabati compound. The Overwatch image showed Madison going to the house where the Russians and the other Kharabatis were staying. Kane had been carried there from the boat. She appeared to go willingly, and body language was hard to read from 40,000 feet—even with their advanced optics—but Dentiger had an ominous feeling that he couldn't shake. Something bad was going to happen in that house.

The Deputy Director was focused on the monitor, berating Manny for getting the comms link reestablished. Dentiger knew he could slip out unnoticed. And when Bristow did realize he was gone, it would be too late.

Convincing the tac team to go took some effort. He wouldn't lie to the guys and tell them that Bristow said it was go-time. Their boss would realize what was happening before they cleared the grounds and call them back. They would turn around, and his credibility would have been shot. He

told them the truth and appealed to their sense of duty to their fellow officers.

“Comms are down. Our officers are in there, cut off, surrounded by Russian gangsters and the radical Kharabati Royal Guard. Bristow is too damned focused on getting this tech doohickey to worry about their lives. I can’t just leave them in there. And I can’t make any of you go with me when it could mean your careers. But I’m taking one of these trucks and going, even if I’m alone.”

“And what about the mission? Is it a failure if we don’t get whatever they’re after? Will all of this be for nothing?”

The question came from a tactical officer who looked like he’d come directly from training at The Farm. The men around him shifted uncomfortably. Dentiger knew right away that most of the older officers were with him. None of the tac team was read into the details about Null:Echo. They didn’t need to know.

“We’ll hit them hard and fast. They won’t have time to get rid of anything. We’ll get what we came for, and we’ll keep our officers alive.”

A man at the back shook his head and laughed. He was a clear leader in the room, and when he spoke, the other men straightened up. His head was shaved, but his beard sported more gray than dark hair.

“Damien Fucking Kane. Of course, he’s in the shit again. That son-of-a-bitch never thinks before he jumps in. Probably because he’s the luckiest bastard the Agency’s ever had. But thank God, because his luck rubbed off on me back in the Anbar Province.

“He refused to leave when he could, and they kept us pinned down for hours. He picked those cocksuckers off one by one until he was the last man standing. Then he put me over his shoulders and carried me out of there, even though he’d taken one in the arm. Yeah, let’s fucking go. I’m not leaving him in there.”

The men around him murmured and began nodding.

“We need to go if we’re going to do it,” Cassandra said from the doorway, surprising Dentiger. “Bristow had to take a call from Langley, but that won’t keep her occupied for long.”

Dentiger walked over and touched her arm. He didn’t care who saw the moment of tenderness. “You don’t have to do this, Cass. Let me take the hit. Tell her you tried to stop me.”

She put her hand over his, caressed it. “It’s my team, Tay. I have to do this. I’ll proudly stand behind this decision.”

“Hey, do you two need to slip in the back and make sweet, sweet love, or are we doing this?” It was the bearded officer.

“Fuck you. Let’s go.” Cassandra said it before Dentiger could get the words out. God, he was proud of her.

The SUV fishtailed and spewed tiny stones from the tires as Dentiger tried to take the turns in the long, gravel driveway as fast as he could. He knew they’d triggered an alarm the moment he crashed through the gate, but it would be a minute before they were in sight of the house where they’d taken Madison and Kane.

Bullets thudded into the windshield, and Dentiger ducked his head on instinct, even though the thick, armored glass held. Cassandra, in the seat beside him, didn’t react at all. She shook her head and told him to *nut up*. He smiled.

Heavy, sustained, automatic fire came from the house. Someone had a 60 on the roof and was laying down fire. He hadn’t seen that on the overwatch drone before they left. They must have run it out when the alarm sounded. The windshield began to web, and Dentiger cut the wheel hard. The rear of the SUV slid out to the right as they bounced off the driveway and onto the wide, meticulously maintained lawn.

The vehicle behind them shot across the lawn to the right, taking a wide arc toward the main house. The other half of the tac team was in the other SUV. Their job was to hit the two-story pool house—where Kharabati

security was based—and take out the frequency jammers. They'd be much better off if they knew what Overwatch could see. Bristow was pissed, but she wouldn't hang them out to dry.

Dentiger skidded the SUV to a halt, broadsided to the house. Weapons fire raked the side, finally shattering the bulletproof glass, as the team scrambled out of the driver's side and took cover behind the vehicle.

"We have to press," Dentiger shouted over the roar of gunfire. He pulled back the charging handle on his HK416. "We're going to get slaughtered if we stay pinned down here."

"If you lay down cover fire, a couple of us can try to get up to that low wall," replied one of the operators. Four members of the tac team had been in the SUV with Dentiger and Cassandra.

"Do you think you can make it?" she shouted. The constant hammer of gunfire was rattling her nerves. Cassandra had never been in a firefight before.

"We can try," the operator replied. "But Tay's right. We can't stay here. They'll flank us."

Two of the operators pulled the pins on smoke canisters and lobbed them into the space between the SUV and the house.

"Go on three," Dentiger ordered.

Everyone nodded.

"One...two...three!"

Dentiger popped up from behind the SUV and fired back at the house. Cassandra was right beside him behind the hood, while one of the operators leaned around the rear of the vehicle, and one of them leaned inside and took aim through the blown-out windows. The roar of their return fire dampened the assault from the house, and two of the operators darted forward through the hanging smoke.

Cassandra smoothly picked off the thug manning the M60 on the roof and dropped another thug standing at the front of the house. She'd never

been in a real firefight, but she was one of the best marksmen who'd ever passed through The Farm.

"Damn, girl. You been holding out on me?" Dentiger asked, risking an admiring side glance at his partner.

She smirked. "You should know I always hit what I'm aiming for."

The operators were nearly at the wall when one of them went down. The team wore body armor, but the round hit the right place. As he toppled backward, Cassandra shot the Kharabati who'd shot him. The other operator dragged his teammate behind the wall for cover.

"Motherfuckers!" Dentiger shouted, dropping another one, who looked like a Russian.

EVERYONE in the room tensed when they heard the gunfire. They looked out through the windows overlooking the bay, but the gunfire came from the front of the house. Sergei shouted to his men in Russian. Some of them rushed out of the room with the Kharabati security men.

"What's going on? What's happening?" Anatoly asked from the television. His son answered him in Russian.

"What is happening, Rami?" Zaydan asked his bodyguard, still holding the machete aloft.

Rami took his hand off Madison's arm to raise the microphone concealed in his sleeve to his mouth. She drove an elbow back into his gut, putting everything she had behind it. He grunted and bowed. She twisted her other arm out of his grasp and slammed the crown of her head back into his face. Rami staggered back and tripped back onto the couch, bright red blood geysering from his ruined nose.

The gunfire outside exploded in intensity. Madison heard a heavy weapon, possibly an M60, firing from the roof. Zaydan was stunned by

sensory overload, and she took advantage.

Madison delivered a savage kick between Zaydan's legs. He grunted and doubled over. The machete clanked on the floor, and she snatched it up. Sergei cursed behind her. She took a wild swing at the prince, but Sergei drew his pistol and fired, aborting it. The window behind Zaydan shattered.

Stepping on Rami, Madison bounded over the couch as another round from Sergei's pistol punched into the wall. She only checked her mad dash for the doorway when she spied her prize on an end table. Null:Echo. The whole reason she was dodging bullets naked in a Hamptons mansion.

It was a crazy risk, but she ducked back while Sergei and another Russian fired over her head. She was only saved when Rami began to return fire, thinking the Russians were shooting at Zaydan. Sergei took cover behind a grand piano. Madison grabbed the portable drive and was through the door.

Madison turned a corner and ran smack into Kharabati security. The guard raised his pistol, and she slashed with the machete. The meaty thud of steel against flesh and bone jarred up her arm, but the guard's pistol—and hand—dropped to the floor. He howled, staring at her in disbelief. She was a naked, flame-haired avenging angel. His howl was cut short when her backhanded slash opened his throat. Hot blood sprayed onto her, but she didn't slow down. She dropped the machete and took the pistol.

Madison found herself in the large, open kitchen. She'd memorized the layout of the entire property, but she had to slow her adrenaline rush and start thinking clearly. The gun battle outside became more heated. She assumed it was the cavalry.

"Can anyone hear me?" she whispered, testing her comms. She was still met with silence.

Slipping off the locket that concealed her covert camera, she stared into the lens. The device had no indication that it was active—that would have defeated the purpose. She waved at the camera anyway.

“Can you see me? Can you hear me? We need help. If that’s you guys outside, I have Null:Echo, but I have no idea where Damien is.”

Madison hoped there was a chance they saw or heard her. She’d escaped in the chaos, but she was running out of time. Glancing around the kitchen, she saw an apron and grabbed it. It wasn’t clothing, but it was better than literally nothing, and she couldn’t keep running around the house naked.

As she draped it over her neck, she heard men in the hallway. Frantically glancing around, she saw a doorway. It either led to a closet or a basement. Either was better than being caught. She gathered the Beretta 9mm and the portable drive and slipped through the door just as two Kharabati security men came into the kitchen.

The door led into a dark, narrow pantry. She laid the portable drive on the shelf beside her and gripped the Beretta in both hands, ready to fire if anyone came through that door. Her heart pounded so hard in her ears that she didn’t hear the sibilant whispering at first.

“Maddy? Is that you? What are you...”

Kane thought that his head injury must be worse than he’d thought because he couldn’t comprehend why Madison would be standing in front of him with her ass out and holding a gun. He’d already been trying to determine if he was really hearing gunfire. It was muffled in the pantry.

Even in their tense situation, he had to take a moment to admire her ass because it was so amazing. Once that moment passed, he realized that she was hiding from something.

“Maddy. What the fuck is going on?” he asked, slightly raising his voice.

She turned and froze. “Oh my God! Damien. What are you doing here?”

Kane smirked. “I tied myself up for a nap. Why are you running around, covered in blood, in nothing but an apron, with a gun?”

Both of them realized they were so scrambled by the situation that they were talking past each other.

“Don’t worry, the blood isn’t mine. They know who we are. The Russians hacked into the CIA using Null:Echo. I’m lucky they didn’t shoot me in the head and toss me off the boat.”

“I know. Sergei pulled off this big reveal. He even had daddy on Zoom.”

“Fuck,” he muttered.

“Yeah. I thought I was truly fucked. Zaydan was about to...” She didn’t finish the sentence, and Kane didn’t like how rattled she looked. “He was interrupted by the gunfire. I assume it’s our people, but comms are down. We need to get out of here and link up with them.”

“And you were barbecuing naked when this all went down?” he asked, nodding to her apron.

“I had to make a quick exit when the shooting started. I didn’t have time to grab my bikini. This apron was the first thing I found to cover myself.”

“It’s not doing a very good job,” he replied, leering at the generous amount of sideboob spilling from the untied apron.

“Don’t look at me like that, Damien. This isn’t the time.”

“It’s always the time when you’re half-naked, Maddy.”

She rolled her eyes and stilled, putting a finger to her lips. The Arabic-speaking voices were getting closer to the door.

The doorknob rattled, and Madison stepped back, aiming at the center of the doorway. She thought about firing through the door. The 9mm rounds would penetrate, but if she missed, they had no cover. They’d be shredded by return fire.

Light flooded the pantry when the door was thrown open. Madison was momentarily dazed, but she just fired at what should be the center mass of an average man and hoped for the best. The weapon was deafening in the confines of the pantry. The three rounds from her Beretta were answered with a grunt she barely heard through the ringing in her ears.

Bullets flew through the open door, shredding boxes. Madison was covered in a cloud of flour and raining pasta. She ducked low and rolled out of the flour storm. When she came up in her firing stance, the other Kharabati guard was so startled by the sight of her that he didn't react before he put a round neatly in his forehead. He toppled backward.

The ringing in her ears slowly cleared, and she heard Kane calling her name. "Is he down?" he asked.

"I got him."

"Then cut me loose."

The kitchen was full of knives, and Madison had Kane free in moments. He rubbed his wrists as he stood. He briefly stumbled against the shelves, and she asked if he was okay.

"They knocked me out on the boat. I'm fine. Just need to get my bearings."

She frowned with concern. "You really need to stop getting hit in the head. You're probably one concussion away from drooling into your ice cream."

"I'm fine, Maddy. Let's get out of here."

Kane wasn't quite fine, but he felt much better when he was out of the pantry and able to move and take a deep breath. His head hurt like he'd been kicked by a mule, and the lights had slight halos, but he wasn't seeing double, and he felt like he could move fine. He could see well enough to appreciate watching Madison slip into the guard's shirt.

The black t-shirt had been tight on the guard she'd shot in the head, but he was nearly twice her size. She threw off the apron and pulled the t-shirt over her head. It fit like a baggy minidress, but it was an improvement. She didn't think anyone would stop to check out her ass if she bent over anyway. Except for Kane. He was definitely looking.

"Jesus, Damien. Do you ever stop thinking about sex?"

“Stop flashing me, and I’ll stop looking.” He bent over and took a pistol from the floor. A quick check of the magazine revealed it was full. He took another off the previous owner’s body.

Madison swapped out her Beretta for a P90 from the other guard. The compact submachine gun was a major upgrade. She ducked back into the pantry and grabbed the portable drive containing Null:Echo. She dusted the flour off of it and pressed it into Kane’s hands.

“Don’t lose this,” she said.

Kane turned it over in his hands. “This thing could bring about the end of the world?”

“Are you ready? We need to link up with the team.”

“Let’s go,” he replied.

twelve

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“This is Phantom Six. Do you read me? We’ve secured the pool house and disabled the Kharabati equipment.”

The unfamiliar voice in her ear was the first thing Madison had heard over comms all day.

“Copy that, Phantom Six. This is Phantom Actual. We hear you loud and clear. Phantom Three, what the hell is going on over there?”

Phantom Actual was Bristow. They’d switched to more formal comm protocols since they’d entered into an active tactical operation phase.

“This is Phantom Three. We’re in front, trying to penetrate the back residence. Making progress, but we’re under heavy fire,” Cassandra replied.

“Why the hell are you in there at all, Phantom Three?” Bristow asked.

“Phantom Four. Is this really the time for that? What do you fucking see on Overwatch?” Dentiger interrupted.

“Phantom Actual. There are still three at the front of the house pinning you down. But it looks like another team is circling from the far side of the house to your left. You need to get out of there.”

“Fuck,” Dentiger muttered.

“Phantom Actual. Tac Team Three is on its way. Hold tight. Phantom One, Phantom Two, are you on comms?”

“I’m here,” Madison answered. “Phantom Two is with me. We’re okay, for now. But there are hostiles everywhere. We’ll try to get to the front of the house.”

“Do you have the package?” Bristow asked.

“Phantom One. Affirmative. The package is secure.”

“Phantom Actual. Thank God. Hold tight. Help is on the way.”

Madison was sure she heard relief in Bristow’s voice. She knew it was for Null:Echo, not that she and Kane were safe.

“911 has received calls about gunfire. Local law enforcement is on the way,” Manny chimed in.

The local police department only had three full-time officers. Whoever showed up was going to get themselves killed if they tried to intervene.

“Phantom Actual. Listen everyone. We need to wrap this up as quickly as possible.”

“Phantom Three. We’re working on it!” Cassandra’s voice was strained.

Madison and Kane didn’t encounter any resistance moving toward the front of the house. Security seemed to be engaged in dealing with the known threats, but she was sure Zaydan had people looking for her. The prince himself was probably in a safe room somewhere.

The front door was open, and a guard was crouched, ducking out to fire before pulling back. Another guard was to his right, firing through a large, blown-out window. Madison deduced that the third guard must have been outside. She nodded to the left, indicating which guard she’d take. He nodded to the right.

Madison fired a short burst from the P90, stitching rounds diagonally across the guard’s back, from his waist to his shoulder. Kane was half a beat slower, and his guard began to turn before he put three bullets into him. The last shot caught the guard in the neck, and blood rhythmically sprayed as he slumped to the side.

The third gunman, a Russian, appeared in the doorway from the outside. Madison and Kane both raised their weapons, but gunfire took the guard out from the rear before either could fire.

“Clear,” Dentiger shouted from outside.

“Clear,” Madison echoed.

Madison and Kane stepped outside to see Dentiger, Cassandra, and two tac team members rising from behind a low stone wall on the far side of the circular driveway. Another man knelt, tending to the wounded team member. The front of the beautiful mansion was pockmarked by bullet holes, and the landscaping had been destroyed. The team came forward toward Madison. She caught Dentiger’s reaction to her attire.

“Hope we didn’t catch you at a bad time,” he said.

“The party was just wrapping up.” She smiled.

“Incoming at your three o’clock,” Bristow called out over comms.

The entire reunited team turned to see a squad of Kharabati security coming around the far side of the house. They all opened fire. The devastating violence they unleashed on the new arrivals ended the encounter in seconds. Madison’s P90 clicked dry just as the whole scene went silent. The soft sound of wind rustling the trees on the bright summer afternoon felt surreal after what had just occurred on the bayfront estate.

“It looks like you took care of that,” Bristow said on comms, sounding pleased.

“Phantom Actual, have you seen Zaydan or Sergei flee the house yet?” Madison asked.

“We’ve seen people running out, but no one we identified as either of them.”

“So, they’re probably still in the house,” Madison concluded.

“Let’s round them up,” Cassandra said. “Did I hear correctly? You have the package?”

Kane pulled it out of his shorts pocket, where the cord hung out like it was a drive containing family photos, not the cipher that could alter the balance of power in the world. He handed the device to Cassandra.

“Take good care of our baby,” he said.

She tucked the portable drive into an internal pocket on her vest. “After everything we’ve done to get this? I’ll guard it with my life.”

“We need to round up Zaydan and Sergei. Neither of them can get away,” Madison said.

“We can go into the house and divide into two teams. We’ll clear it quickly,” Cassandra said.

“And if they got out in the confusion?” Kane asked.

Cassandra touched the stud to speak over comms. Unlike Madison’s earwig—which was always on—her had to be activated. “This is Phantom Three. Phantom Six, we’re sweeping the back house, looking for the targets. Leave someone on the pool house and start coming forward. Tac Team one will be sweeping down to meet you.”

“Phantom Six. Roger that, Phantom Three.”

Cassandra nodded, and the two tac team members with them started around the corner of the house. “Tay and I will go one way, you and Kane can take the other. Sound good?”

“It’s as good a plan as any,” Madison agreed.

They moved into the house.

MADISON HAD PULLED a fresh magazine off one of the Kharabatis and reloaded her P90. Kane took a P90 off another of the guards. He led the way down the corridor, with Madison right over his shoulder. They didn’t encounter any resistance, and she thought all of the bad guys must have fled the house, but she heard gunfire from the other wing, where Dentiger and

Cassandra had gone. Over comms, Dentiger said, *“Phantom Four. Three hostiles cleared. No sign of either target.”*

“Phantom Actual. Copy that. Keep looking.”

Madison and Kane passed the kitchen, working their way back toward the room where it had all started. They heard voices speaking in Russian. Kane held up a closed fist and they stopped short of the door.

“I think that’s Sergei and his father. The video link must still be up,” Madison whispered.

“How many men were with him?” Kane asked.

“Three or four, but I don’t know how many there are now.”

The sounds of a gun battle carried in from outside.

“Sergei isn’t going to linger. This is not going his way. I go low, you go high?”

“Is that because your old knees can’t handle crouching?” she asked, affectionately rubbing his shoulder.

“I just want to see you crouch in that t-shirt.”

They paused to ready themselves and swung through the door, Madison low, Kane high. The room was full of dead men. The bodies of Kharabati security and Russian thugs littered the floor. The only man standing was Sergei. He was close to the television, talking to his father, with no idea that the Americans had entered. It was Anatoly, looking through the camera, who warned his son.

Sergei spun, bringing his pistol up, but he stopped short when he saw that both CIA officers had their weapons trained on him.

“I’d move a lot more slowly than that, Sergei. I’d hate for us to have to shoot you like we did your daddy,” Kane said, moving to the Russian’s right. Madison calmly walked to the left. There was no doubt they’d cut Sergei down if he brought that pistol above his waist.

“No more pretending you’re a sissy cuck who likes to watch men fuck his wife. We’re showing who we really are. That’s good,” Sergei said,

grinning like he had the upper hand. He still hadn't dropped his weapon.

"And you're a little man who never figured out how to get out of daddy's shadow," Madison said.

Sergei snorted. "Big words from a whore."

"You don't have to be mean because you couldn't close the deal, Junior," Kane said. "She's just one more thing your dad got that you couldn't have. You've been jerking off to her since you were a teenager. Keep calling her a whore, but she wouldn't fuck you, would she? What does that make you?"

"Enough!" Anatoly called from the television. "Let my son go. I can move millions into accounts in the islands for both of you right now. Your CIA will never know. Tell them you couldn't find Sergei."

"We can't be bought. Someone like Sergei has a lot of secrets to share," Kane replied. "No way we're just letting him go."

"I'll never talk. Do not waste your time," Sergei spat.

"Everyone says that," Kane chuckled. "You'll be wetting yourself in the corner before we even get started with you."

Sergei's gun hand twitched, but Kane shook his head. "Tsk, ts. I'd love to shoot you. Don't make it easy for me."

Anatoly stared at Madison from the screen. "Give me my son, and I will give you your family, Milica."

Her jaw set firmly. "Don't talk about my family."

"We know who you are..." He paused to look down at something on his desk. "...Madison Sinclair. A husband, two teenage children. They could be gone..." He made a dismissive gesture. "...like it was nothing. Penny is on a football travel team now, yes? I believe they are playing in Maryland today. I have assets everywhere, Milica. You should know this."

"If you go anywhere near my family..."

"We are already near. All I have to do is send one text. My men will wait for an opportune time, and..."

“I will never stop hunting you, Anatoly.”

“Hunt me. Take my son, and I don’t care what happens to me. You’ve already taken everything else from me, Milica. Let him go. This is a gift.”

“He’s bluffing, Maddy. There’s no way he has men on the ground out there—wherever Charles and the kids are,” Kane said.

“Sinclair, don’t take the bait,” Bristow warned over comms. “We need Sergei alive. We need to interrogate him. The Agency will protect your family. I’ll get a detail out to them right now.”

They both knew Kane was lying to make her feel better. Madison also knew that there was no safety for her family unless the Agency put them into witness protection, destroying their lives. The Reznikovs may not have eyes on her family at that exact moment, but the Russian mob had assets everywhere. Anatoly could have someone out to her family before the tournament was over.

“We’ll never be safe while your psycho son is out there. He’s made that clear,” Madison said.

Sergei smiled. “You’ll just have to trust us. Maybe you should suck my cock for extra incentive before you let me go,” he mocked. “Or else I will teach your Penny how to do it properly.”

Kane’s bullet took the Russian high in the chest, and he staggered backward. Sergei brought his weapon up and returned fire, getting off a shot that sprayed blood from Kane’s arm, before Madison cut him down. She squeezed the trigger hard and shredded Sergei with the P90 on full auto. He was obscured by a red mist as the rounds hammered him backward and through the floor-to-ceiling window behind him. His body dropped out of sight.

“You bastards!” Anatoly screamed from the screen.

Kane shot the television, destroying it.

“Damien, what have we done?” Madison quietly said.

“It’ll be fine. We’ll take care of this,” Kane assured her.

“What happened, Sinclair? What was that gunfire?” Bristow shouted in her ear.

ZAYDAN STOOD on the boat with his hands in the air. The prince stared down a squad of Americans with guns pointed at him, and moved very slowly, smiling the entire time. Rami was sprawled on one of the benches beside him, bleeding out. The bodyguard had been loyal to the end—his end.

“How can I help you, my American friends?”

“If you have a weapon, pull it out with two fingers and toss it onto the dock.”

The command came from a pretty Asian woman. Zaydan couldn’t place her, but there was something familiar about her. He would have tried to charm her, but that clearly wasn’t going to get him far.

“Now,” barked a large Black man beside her. Both of them had automatic weapons trained on him. Behind them, even more agents of the US government had guns trained on him.

“Of course. It is not illegal for me to be armed on my own property, is it? Aren’t you Americans all about the right to bear arms and self-defense?”

Zaydan moved very slowly and drew the handgun that was tucked into his waistband at the small of his back. He tossed it onto the dock with a flick of his wrist.

“Now, hands on your head and step onto the deck,” the woman ordered. She came forward and kicked his gun back, where the Black man picked it up and tucked it into his own waistband.

“I’m flattered that you believe my balance is that good.” Zaydan laughed. “Don’t shoot me if I stumble.”

He kept it light, but knew the trigger-happy Americans could take him out with the least provocation. They were not trustworthy. He'd learned that long ago when his uncle had disappeared, and it was confirmed once again when they sent that redheaded whore after him. It didn't matter that he was the son of the King of Kharabat.

"Just keep your movements slow and smooth, and we won't have a reason to, pal," the Black man said.

"Of course, my friend."

Stepping onto the dock from the bobbing fishing boat was even more precarious than he'd anticipated, but Zaydan didn't stumble. He wouldn't give the Americans the satisfaction. The moment he stepped on the dock, the Black man rushed forward and forced him to his knees. He roughly wrenched Zaydan's hands behind his back and secured them with a zip tie.

"I don't suppose any of you have a warrant to show me, do you? As I said, this is private property. Under what authority are you detaining me? What agency are you even with? I don't see any badges."

"We don't wear badges, asshole." The Black man casually checked him in the back of the head.

"Take it down a notch, Tay. We have him," the woman said. She was clearly in charge. Zaydan almost laughed. A man would never defer to a woman like that in his country. She paused like she was listening to something. "Reznikov is down. Maddy and Kane got him."

"Good," the man snorted.

"But he made some...threats. We may need to mobilize."

"I've been cooperative thus far, because you have all the guns, but I ask you again, under what authority do you dare to detain me? I am Prince Zaydan bin Zalman al-Kharabati. I am not subject to your petty laws."

"You're subject to whatever we say you are, asshole. Pipe down," the man said behind him. Zaydan braced for another blow, but it didn't come.

“We can start with providing material support to terrorists and go from there,” the woman said.

Cassandra watched the prince smile once again and hated him for it. She wanted to hit him every bit as much as Dentiger did, but they had to be careful and do everything by the book. Unfortunately, he was right. He was the son of a head of state. Every I had to be meticulously dotted, every T perfectly crossed.

They never discussed actually taking the prince down. The focus had been on obtaining Null:Echo. She didn’t actually know what to do with Zaydan, but she had no intention of letting him sail off into the sunset on his little boat. Ultimately, his fate was above her pay grade.

“Believe me, I would love to see you try to prove any charges against me. That would be entertaining. And I would love to expose your whore—what is her name, Madison Sinclair?—for what she is in open court, we’ll never get there. Your friend may as well remove these restraints now and let me get on with my day. The longer this drags on, the worse the international incident becomes.”

Dentiger rolled his eyes, and Cassandra laughed. “Is that so? We have you red-handed doing business with known members of the Russian underworld.”

“I’m afraid he’s correct. Dentiger, cut him loose.”

The command came from Bristow, who was walking up the dock. She did not look pleased.

“What the fuck, chief? I know his daddy is a big deal...” Dentiger complained.

“Would you like to tell them, or shall I?” Zaydan smugly asked.

“His father has exercised diplomatic immunity,” Bristow explained. “He doesn’t automatically carry it because he’s not part of their diplomatic delegation here in the US, but the Kharabati government can always exercise it—especially when it comes to a member of the royal family.”

“Would you please?” Zaydan asked, leaning forward to present his wrists.

“*Motherfucker*,” Dentiger muttered. He wasn’t gentle when he cut the prince loose. The trickle of blood was a small victory.

“I am, as you said, a *motherfucker*. Isn’t your CIA whore a mother?”

Dentiger took a step, but the look on Bristow’s face stopped him short. She wasn’t fucking around.

“Enjoy this while you can.” Bristow stepped forward, right into Zaydan’s face. They were close enough to kiss, but she was not in a romantic mood. She kept it all business as she delivered the only blow she could.

“Prince Zaydan bin Zalman al-Kharabati, you are hereby expelled from the United States, and you will not be permitted to re-enter the country. The gentleman behind me will escort you directly to Teterboro, where your private jet is waiting to remove you.

“Madam, you must give me a chance to confer with my father...”

“I don’t have to let you stop to wipe your ass. If you do not go willingly, I’m sure my officer here...” She nodded to Dentiger. “...would love to personally escort you to the airport. No more playing your games with married women, at least not here. You’ll have to settle your mommy issues somewhere else.”

Zaydan looked like he wanted to strike her. Bristow would have loved for him to try. They stared each other down. Zaydan broke and slumped away from her. She nodded to the men behind her. Two stepped forward and took him by the arms. He shrugged their hands off, but went with them.

“Bitch,” he muttered.

Bristow smiled. “Directly to the airport. Do not let him communicate with anyone. Watch the plane take off and let me know when it does.” She looked at Rami on the boat. “Someone get him a medic.”

Dentiger took Zaydan's place right in front of the Deputy Director. He was rigid with anger. "How can you just let him walk away like that? You know what he's done. What he would have done with Null:Echo. We could have disappeared him down a hole."

"Check yourself, officer." Bristow didn't shrink from his anger. She remained calm. "You're in enough trouble as it is. This is why you fucking follow orders. We were never going to be able to touch him. I thought you were smarter than that. Just sending Sinclair to work him was enough to cause an international incident, if the Kharabatis really wanted to push it. We needed this operation to stay under the radar."

"I didn't blow that up. Reznikov fucked all that up. But I wasn't going to sit in that fucking house with you while they slaughtered Maddy and Kane."

"They knew the risks when they went in. I hope this was worth your career, because it very well may have cost you everything. The only reason you're not going into custody to be debriefed right now is because we have one more thing to do."

"This is on me, ma'am. I was in charge. I went in with Tay," Cassandra said.

"Oh, I am aware. I don't think you could have stopped him, but that's another problem. Both of you will be lucky if you're not stuck doing SIGINT at the North Pole for the rest of your careers. Do you have the package, Cass?"

Cassandra nodded.

"Get it to Manny. I need it authenticated and secured," Bristow ordered.

"Yes, ma'am. Pardon me, but what else do we need to do? You mentioned that we're not finished," Cassandra asked.

A chopper was coming in low over the bay. Water whipped up over the dock, and Bristow grabbed her ponytail when it passed over them to land on the lawn. We need to get down to Maryland and mop up the Russians. Our

team has eyes on the Sinclairs, but Madison wants to deal with this personally. You're all going—as soon as you put the package in Manny's hands. Get moving.”

thirteen

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Charles knew something was going on when he spotted the security detail. Before he went into private practice, he'd spent years at the Justice Department, and he'd been around there long enough to know the signs of a security detail that was trying to blend in. There were hundreds of people at that huge sports complex, but he spotted the team right off.

The unsettling thing was that he knew they were there for him and the kids. No one approached him, but he just *knew* it. He thought, *Madison, what are you into?*

Once Charles knew the detail was there, he started to look for the why. They were sent to protect them from *something*. Something bad enough to require armed operatives who needed to blend into a travel soccer tournament.

They didn't, not even the tall, blonde operative in the polo dress who did everything she could to play the casual soccer mom. She even cheered for an imaginary kid—while never looking at the field. Her eyes were constantly scanning. He saw it behind her sunglasses. She was anything but casual.

The only saving grace was that Chaz was oblivious, with his face buried in his phone, and Penny was all about the game, sequestered with her team.

No one else seemed to notice the operatives either. They were invisible to civilians.

Whatever they were looking for—*whoever* they were looking for—either wasn't there, or they were better at hiding. Charles didn't see any threats. He should have relaxed, but that made it worse. It took everything he had to keep from approaching one of the operatives and asking what was going on. He knew they wouldn't tell him anything—just like Madison wouldn't tell him anything the last time she was home.

Madison. The blood chilled in his veins when he realized she hadn't called. If something serious was going on, she would have called. She would have been there if she could have been. Only something dire would have kept her away.

Oh God, are they here to keep an eye on us until someone official can come to deliver the bad news?

He thought about Jennifer Bristow and his wife's casual-tense conversation with the CIA Deputy Director at that fundraiser. Their act didn't fool him. They knew each other. *Is that woman going to show up and find a quiet place to tell me the unthinkable?*

Madison's phone went straight to voicemail. Charles tried to hold it together. He had to for the kids. And then he got a text that changed everything. The number was blocked.

The video was dark and blurry at first. Charles turned up the sound and heard laughter and what he thought was Russian. The image remained shaky, but he saw that the video was shot somewhere near water at night. The scene looked like a high-end spa or something. When the camera was fully focused, he saw a woman from behind. She was stripping. Her dress slid to the patio, leaving her naked. Her red hair was dulled by the night, but he knew that figure anywhere. He'd stared at his wife's ass enough times to know it was Madison before she turned and looked back at someone.

It didn't matter, but Charles wondered how many people watched his wife do this. How many of these Russians were there?

Madison waded into that pool gloriously naked. A man waited for her in the water. A younger, dark-skinned man. Charles thought he looked familiar, but the video was taken from too far away to see detail. A man's thigh kept moving into the frame, like the video was shot surreptitiously.

What came next pushed all of the fears out of his head. The hundreds of parents and grandparents cheering around him in the hot Maryland sun, the kids screaming on the field, the referees' whistles, all of it fell away. What Charles saw on that screen took every ounce of his brain power to comprehend. He walked around to the back of the bleachers as he watched it, moving into the only shade available. He couldn't risk anyone else seeing what was on his phone screen.

Charles didn't want to see it, but he couldn't look away.

MADISON WENT STRAIGHT into that younger man's arms, and they were all over each other. No man should ever see his wife kiss someone else like that. She kissed that man like she'd been waiting for it all day. It made Charles want to throw up there behind the bleachers.

And then it got worse.

The man put Madison against the edge of that pool, and he fucked her. She took it loudly and enthusiastically. More enthusiastically than she'd ever made love to him. Charles realized that it could have just been the disgust and rage the video sparked in him, but it felt true.

Did Maddy ever beg me to fuck her like that? Is this her job for the CIA, going to exotic locations and getting fucked?

Charles laughed mirthlessly when he remembered that old canard, *if you love what you do, you'll never work a day in your life*. Madison certainly

seemed to love her work. She came at least once, and the man kept screwing her.

She's a goddamn call girl for the CIA, he thought.

Charles was a couple of minutes into watching the video before he remembered she was doing all of that in front of an audience. His wife was having wild, uninhibited sex in a pool with God knew how many people watching? Cruelly, he wondered if they were lining up to take their turn. He didn't feel bad about it.

The heat he felt under everything was a painful realization. Charles understood that he didn't want any of this—he didn't want his wife to be a whore. His reaction wasn't about what he wanted or what was right. That charged heat that rushed through him and made him hard—even though he was surrounded by hundreds of people and horrified by Madison's behavior—was involuntary.

It was something she'd always summoned in him, and seeing her with someone else didn't change that, even though it should. Her cries into the night, her begging for it, just did something to him, whether he wanted it to or not. He wanted to abolish the dark thrill from his mind.

He was detached from reality when he felt the pistol pressed to the small of his back. That feeling brought him slamming back into reality.

"Do not fight. I don't care about shooting you or your brats right here. You will come with me, and maybe you will not die badly." The stranger's Russian accent was so thick that he barely understood the words.

Charles was sobered in an instant. His cool, analytical lawyer brain engaged. The man did not say he was going to live, just that he would not die badly. He knew the man meant to kill him, but Charles would go along anyway because it bought him time to save the kids. That was all that mattered.

“WE’VE LOST visual on Sinclair. He went behind the bleachers, and by the time we got back there, he was gone. We’re closing on the kids now. We’ll secure them.”

Madison felt helpless listening to the comms chatter. She didn’t interrupt, but wanted to shout at the team to find her husband. Get her kids! The SUV sped toward the Maryland sports complex, sirens blaring. She wanted to tell Dentiger to go faster.

She released her white-knuckled grip on the armrest and unholstered her Glock, checking that it was loaded for the tenth time. She was ready to sprint out of the vehicle the moment it came to a halt. Bristow had tried to tell her to stand down and let the team deal with the Russians, but no one believed that was going to happen.

The sound of gunfire rang out over the comms channel, followed by the screams of a panicked crowd.

“Shots fired! Shots fired!”

“Dammit! I’ve lost sight of the girl. Does anyone have eyes on her? Can’t push through this fucking crowd!”

“Can’t get into the stands to the boy! Too many people running. They’re trampling each other. Shit, someone is pulling him in the other direction!”

The agitated voices tumbled over each other. Madison couldn’t stop the choked sound that escaped her lips. They were still several minutes out, and she had no idea what was going on. Had the Russians fired into the crowd? *Did they shoot...* Madison couldn’t even finish that thought.

Kane, beside her in the back of the SUV, clasped her hand. The medics had insisted that he stay behind in New York. His succinct reply had shut them down. “Patch me up and fuck off.”

Cassandra looked back from the front seat. “They’ll be okay. The team knows what they’re doing, and we’ll be there in a second.” She turned forward. “Tay?”

The engine roared, and they were all tossed around the inside of the vehicle when we swerved around a senior citizen driving a Buick. A horn blared as they swung back into their lane. They were on a narrow, two-lane road, just off the interstate. Traffic was increasing, slowing them down, but Dentiger had a break to shoot ahead.

“I’m going as fast as I can. Don’t these assholes know what a siren and lights mean?” he muttered, eyes locked on the road.

The light ahead of them went yellow, and then red. Dentiger didn’t let up on the gas, even as cross-traffic began to move. He leaned on the horn, shouting, “Get the fuck out of the way!” The other cars, unable to hear him, kept moving.

Their SUV flew into the intersection, and more horns blared, cars screeched when their drivers stood on the brakes, and several vehicles crashed into each other, but Dentiger weaved through the chaos like it had all been choreographed.

“I’ve got them. I’m on them. They’re in a blue Expedition. Looks like a cop edition.” The voice shifted into a shout. *“Hey, stop! Lower your...”*

The report of gunshots sounded over the radio. Other officers called out to their comrade. He didn’t answer. Someone shouted, *“Cobra is down! Cobra is down!”*

“Fuck! Get through this, Tay!” Madison yelled from the backseat.

They saw the entrance to the sports complex ahead, but the traffic approaching it was at a standstill. Cars waited to be directed in. And then, screaming people poured through the gates. And a blue Expedition was edging past them and making a right, going in the other direction.

“Tay!” she repeated.

“I see it. Fuck,” he said.

Dentiger wrenched the wheel and jumped the curb. Only a handful of people walked the sidewalk that far down, but it was crowded ahead. He

pressed the accelerator anyway, mangling a bush before he brought the SUV under control and raced forward.

The crowd parted, and some of them cursed, but they got out of the way. Dentiger went as fast as he could safely go. The closer he got, the faster they parted. Those people had been there for the gunshots and assumed the CIA team was the police responding. Dentiger clipped a stop sign post and clanged off the windshield, cracking it.

“Tay, careful!” Cassandra admonished.

Dentiger didn’t answer, but rammed the front end of the bumper of a Prince George’s County cruiser that had been parked on the grass for traffic control, before the action started. The team jolted inside the SUV, but it hardly slowed, and Dentiger steered them back on the road again, clear of the sports complex.

“This is Phantom Team,” Cassandra said, speaking into the mouthpiece of her radio. “We have targets in sight and are pursuing. We are southbound on County 537.”

“We’re going to catch them, Maddy. We will, and we’ll get everyone back,” Kane softly said in the backseat.

Madison heard sirens behind them and saw that several police cars had joined the pursuit. She wondered if they realized the team in the SUV was not fellow police.

We’ll catch them, she told herself. We’ll catch them, and we’ll end this. And then I will end it for good, even if I have to go all the way to Russia. I will end this.

CHARLES WAS SHOVED into the rear of an SUV. Every time he tried to raise his head and check on the kids, one of the Russians hit him and told him to keep his head down. Chaz was crying, which made the Russian yell at him,

too. Penny sounded remarkably calm as she tried to comfort her brother and told the Russian to leave them alone.

She's her mother's daughter, he thought, still proud of that even though this was all Madison's fault.

He heard sirens behind them, which gave him hope to cling to. They weren't alone. They were going to be saved. He wouldn't have to die trying to protect his children.

The vehicle swerved and hit something, throwing Charles around in the back. He slammed his head hard enough to see stars. Penny shouted. And then there was automatic gunfire.

Wind rushed into the SUV when one of the Russians leaned out of the window and started firing back at whoever pursued them. The chattering weapon was so loud that he covered his ears. The kids were screaming. The Russian gunfire was met with responding fire that thumped into the tailgate behind him, but only for a moment. He thanked God whoever it was stopped firing because his kids were in that SUV.

Charles heard a meaty thud and something wet sprayed into the SUV. The kids were still screaming, but now the other Russians were screaming. The vehicle skidded hard to the right, and it jostled so hard that he felt like he was being thrown around in a dryer. When they stopped, he didn't quite believe it.

The doors flew open, and the Russians, there were four of them moving, were shooting. The fifth hung limply in the open window of the right rear door. Charles was scrambling over the backseat when the tailgate rose. His kids weren't there. He was yanked back by the ankle.

The sunlight was blinding after being shoved in the back of the vehicle. Charles felt a gun pressed to his head, and the man who did it was shouting at someone to back off. His eyes adjusted, and he saw that he—and the kids—were being used as human shields. A team in black tactical gear was advancing on them with weapons drawn.

“Let them go. Don’t make this worse.” A large Black man shouted that. He kept switching his rifle between the Russians, but there was no shot.

They were in a field, backing toward a tree line. Charles knew the Russians hoped to lose their pursuers in the woods. They couldn’t reach that tree line.

“It’s not too late to make a deal.” An Asian woman shouted that.

“Fuck you! There is no deal. We do this, or we’re dead anyway. You can’t protect us.” The Russian who held Chaz shouted that.

“Back off or we drop the kids,” screamed another Russian.

“Take me. He wants me anyway. Let them go.”

Charles lasered in on that voice. Madison stepped from between the others. She was dressed like them, black pants and boots, a black tactical vest over a black t-shirt. She had a pistol extended out in front of her. The situation was dire, but he still marveled, *Who the hell is she?*

The Russian laughed. “He wants all of you. Come with us, and I promise we’ll make it easy on them.”

Madison laughed. “Respect me enough not to lie to me.”

“Had to try, he replied.

Madison met his eyes for a second. Her’s said, *I’m sorry*, just before her expression hardened. She shifted her focus back to the Russian and fired.

The bullet caught the Russian holding Chaz square in the forehead, and his head snapped back. Their son was too small to use as a proper human shield anyway. The man fell backward, and Chaz fell, tangled up with him, but the Russian’s gun fell to the ground.

All hell broke loose then. Cassandra fired with the confidence that she always had the shot. The man holding Penny fell. One of the Russians took off for the tree line. Dentiger chased him. But the man who had Charles dragged him backwards, trying to get around the edge of the SUV.

Madison came forward like an avenging angel. Her shot passed so close that Charles felt its heat. The Russian returned fire, taking her solidly in the

chest several times. She staggered back, going to one knee. She wore the tactical vest, but Charles still screamed, elbowing the Russian as hard as he could.

The gunshot next to his ear was so loud that Charles became completely disoriented, like a bat “blinded” by a loud noise. He didn’t even feel the searing pain at first. After a moment, his chest was white hot with agony. He couldn’t breathe. He started getting cold, and his legs stopped working. The Russian let him go as he stumbled.

“Fuck!” Kane exclaimed, rushing forward. He was torn between giving aid to Charles Sinclair and going after the Russian. His rage won out.

The man shot Madison. Kane couldn’t let that go. He fired as he came forward, one of his shots taking the fleeing Russian in the back of his shoulder, knocking him down. He tried to crawl to his feet, but Kane was there and kicked him, making the Russian roll over. He started to bring his gun up, but Kane stepped on his wrist.

“I don’t think so, Ivan,” Kane said. “I’d say to tell Reznikov not to send the B team next time, but you won’t be telling anyone anything.”

Kane emptied his Glock into the Russian.

Cassandra rushed forward and pulled him back. She glared at him. “You just executed him.”

“He had a gun. We’re not the cops, Cass. We don’t have to read them their fucking rights. These Russians held guns to the kids’ heads. I did the right thing.”

“Damn it, Damien,” she cursed.

Madison was on her knees beside Charles. She’d ripped his shirt open. Blood was everywhere. The bullet went down into his right shoulder. She didn’t see an exit wound.

“Hold on, Charles. You’ll be fine. I’m here.” The words rushed out, and she hoped she sounded confident. They were raspy. Her chest was aching from the shots to her chest. It was difficult to breathe, let alone speak. Over

her shoulder, she shouted, “Get the med kit! Now!” She didn’t understand what everyone else was doing. Dentiger was gone. Cassandra was talking into her radio. And Kane was reloading as he walked away from the dead Russian.

“The kids,” Charles weakly said, coughing up blood with the words.

“They’re okay. The Russians are down. Everyone is okay now. You’ll be okay.”

Madison tapped into her cool professional side. She tore his shirt completely off and pressed it hard against his wound. His eyes went wide with the pain. She said, “Sorry, honey. I have to. The bleeding.” The pressing hurt her almost as much as it did him. Her chest screamed.

Where is the damn med kit? she wondered.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Kane with the kids. He was on one knee. He was comforting Chaz, a hand on his shoulder. He was keeping Penny back with his other hand. She wasn’t as malleable as her brother.

“Let your mom work. She knows what she’s doing. This isn’t her first shootout,” Kane was telling them.

“What are you talking about? Mom doesn’t know how to fire a gun,” Penny complained.

Cassandra was there with the med kit, and she cracked it open. She tore into a pouch of QuikClot, and Madison pulled the blood-soaked shirt aside long enough for Cassandra to pull it into the wound. Madison tossed the shirt side aside and continued applying pressure with fresh gauze from the med kit. That soaked through, too, but she kept pressing.

“There’s a chopper four minutes out, Maddy. Just keep pressing. Do you need me to take over?” Cassandra asked.

“No, I’ve got it. Stay with me, Charles. Hey, look at me. You have to stay with me.”

He stared up at her, eyes unfocused. His voice was a weak mumble. “Maddy, what...”

Penny pulled away from Kane and rushed over. “What the hell is happening, Mom? Why are you dressed like that? Ohmygod! Daddy!” She fell to her knees, white as a sheet.

“Back up, honey. Your dad needs room. He’ll be okay, I promise,” Madison said, wishing she believed it. It felt like he was slipping away. She almost put a hand on her daughter, but it was covered with her husband’s blood. She heard the chopper coming in hot.

Madison said an Our Father for the first time since she was sixteen years old.

fourteen

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Madison sat in the dim interrogation room in the SCIF at Langley and answered the same question for what had to be the twentieth time. She knew how interrogation worked, and she knew how to evade it—not that she had a reason to. Madison had nothing to hide. This was officially a debriefing, but she knew an interrogation when she saw one.

The room was cramped and hot by design. The utilitarian desk had a ring bolted into the surface for more contentious conversations. The only light—bright and cold—came from the ceiling above them, a perfect circle falling over the desk and the people on either side of it.

Bristow leaned against the wall, arms crossed. Madison had no idea what was watching through the two-way mirror. She didn't care either. She had to get out of there and get back to her real life. Or what was left of it.

"Null:Echo worked? You saw it work at the Kharabati residence in the Hamptons?"

The man who asked the question was as outwardly bland as the way he referred to Zaydan's waterfront mansion. He was the definition of non-descript, which was why he was so scary.

The Kharabati Residence. A residence was a house, not a \$78 million compound. The things that had happened there, the things Madison had done—even before the violence—didn't take place at a *residence*.

“Yes, it obviously worked. The Russians were in our system,” she replied, exasperated to be answering the question again.

He paged through a file. “I see you were under considerable stress. *Agitated*. Are you sure it wasn’t a ruse?”

“I know what I saw. The Kharabatis verified it. They wouldn’t have transferred all of that money if they hadn’t.”

“Yes,” he dryly replied. “The money transfer. The Russians got the money, but the Kharabatis didn’t get Null:Echo. That should be a major issue between them, don’t you think? We haven’t heard any chatter about it.”

“We don’t know *everything*,” she replied, an admission that didn’t come lightly.

“Unless they did. Can you be 100% sure they didn’t switch out the device, and you walked away with a fake?”

Madison racked her brain—again. She’s done it so many times since she heard that Null:Echo didn’t work. Manny had plugged it in and said the drive was full of MILF porn. They put it through every test back at Langley, and still no Null:Echo. But Madison didn’t see how they possibly switched out the drive—not with everything going on.

And why? They thought they were going to ship her back to Moscow to torture and dismember her. When they were done with their fun. She still shuddered when she thought about it. That was one of many nightmares she couldn’t shake.

“No. It was never out of my sight. They had no reason to try to switch it out. They thought they had me. Null:Echo was real, and it worked. I saw it.”

The man looked skeptical. That was his job, but she still hated him for it. “It seems to have vanished from that drive.”

“Unless it was never on the drive. Have you considered that? Null:Echo could have been on that laptop the Russian used the whole time. Maybe the

Russians ripped off the Kharabatis. We both know there's no real honor among thieves."

"That would be a risky gambit," Bristow said, coming off the wall. They were the first words she'd said since informing Madison was only there to observe when she walked in. "The Kharabatis wouldn't take losing that kind of money lying down. The Russian syndicate is tough, but they don't want that kind of trouble."

Madison met the Deputy Director's challenging gaze. "Or there was a failsafe on the drive. It's possible that Null:Echo was programmed to delete itself if the drive was connected to an unauthorized source."

"Did Sergei Reznikov mention that when he gave it to the prince?" Bristow asked.

"No," Madison conceded. "But that doesn't mean it's not true. They could have told Zaydan's tech people. They're the ones who actually verified Null:Echo was real."

"If that's the case, Manny should have accounted for that. The loss of Null:Echo would be on him. He was the first one to try to access it."

"That's not fair. A lot was going on that day."

"Null:Echo was the most important job he had that day," Bristow said.

Not keeping Kane and me alive, Madison thought. She was glad that she was never under any illusions about who Bristow was, or what the Agency's priorities were.

"If we could get back on track. I'd like to go over your interactions with Prince Zaydan while comms were down. We have a lot of unaccounted for time," the man said.

The man betrayed nothing, but Madison couldn't help feeling that he wanted to get how many times she fucked Zaydan down on the record—how they did it, how much she liked it—both so the Agency could impugn her integrity if they needed a fall guy, and for his own personal

gratification. Madison would give him what he wanted. She was not ashamed of doing her job. Not that she would admit to this man anyway.

“I think you have what you need,” Bristow interrupted. “She’s been over this again and again. Sinclair was technically on leave anyway. We shouldn’t take up any more of her time than necessary.”

“I appreciate that, ma’am, but I’m not finished until Scarlet Phantom is all locked down.”

“We can take it from here, Sinclair. You’re excused.”

Madison pushed back from the table, the metal legs of her chair screeching on the concrete floor. She straightened the dark jacket of her pantsuit and excused herself, but she didn’t leave. She was waiting in the hallway with her arms crossed when Bristow emerged from the small, dark room.

“Sinclair,” Bristow coolly said.

Madison smiled. It was interesting how she’d been *Sinclair*, *Madison*, and even *Maddy* when it suited Bristow’s purposes. But now that the Deputy Director had no further use for her, she was firmly back to *Sinclair*.

“I can’t believe Manny just screwed up and somewhat deleted Null:Echo. He’s good at what he does. The Agency can’t just put it all on him,” Madison said.

“It’s going to be put on someone. You know that. Would you rather they looked in your direction? I appreciate everything you did, Sinclair. Everything you lost. I don’t want them coming after you.”

“They can look all they want. I did my job. Everything *you* asked of me. I have nothing to hide.”

“We both know that you don’t want them overanalyzing how close you got to Prince Zaydan. They look at that sort of thing, and they begin to question if the lines started to blur for the officer.”

By *they*, Bristow meant the high-placed men in the Agency. It had always been that way. They asked their female officers to make sacrifices

they'd never ask of a man, and then they judged them for it. Madison did her job knowing that. And even after everything, she'd do it again. She saw that Null:Echo was real, and she knew what it could do.

"I can take it. Anyone who questions my loyalty to this country isn't paying attention. Is there going to be serious blowback if Null:Echo doesn't turn up?"

"I'm working hard to convince them that no one having Null:Echo is a good outcome," Bristow said. "But they had plans for it. It is possible that Glacier Flame still has a copy, but we're actively working to neutralize the syndicate run by Reznikov, so that won't be a problem one way or the other."

"I'd like to personally make sure Anatoly Reznikov is finished this time."

Bristow held up a hand. "I sympathize with you, Sinclair. I know what he's cost you—what he's taken from you. But you'll have to trust me on this. The mission to remove Anatoly Reznikov is in the best hands. He's too dangerous to leave out there, for both the US and your family. We've located him. It's just a matter of time now."

"You'll have to forgive me if I'm skeptical."

"Go be with your family, Madison. They need you, and we've got everything covered. There's nothing you can do here."

Madison wanted to argue, but she knew Bristow was right. They did need her. The kids' lives had been upended. No child should ever have to go through that kind of loss. Charles's sister was with them while she was being debriefed. Madison thought they preferred her these days. They blamed their mother for everything that had happened, and they weren't wrong.

"Keep me updated. I need to know," Madison said.

"I promise. You'll be my first call when we take him out."

THE CIA SAFEHOUSE was a forty-five-minute drive deeper into Virginia from Langley. It wasn't so far away from McLean, but it felt like a different world. Madison had the flexibility for that kind of sudden, extreme change. Her family did not. At least they were in a house, even if it wasn't theirs. The first few weeks after everything that happened in Maryland had been spent in housing on The Farm.

The SUV pulled into the garage, and the door closed behind it. Madison got out of the backseat, but the driver waited in the vehicle. He would be driving Charles's sister home. Having Catherine there at all went against every security protocol, but the family wouldn't go into protection without her. Catherine would be blindfolded before the garage door went up. Her phone was in a Faraday bag. There was no chance she could disclose the location of Madison's family—even under extreme duress.

Catherine was positively icy. The women had never been close. Catherine had treated Madison like an interloper when Charles first brought her home, and then like a gold digger when she learned about Madison's background. But now, after what Madison's work had done to her brother, Catherine didn't even mask her hatred.

Coming back to that safe house to face what she'd done was awful. There was a reason she wanted to hide at Langley. Catherine just glared at Madison as she passed. And that wasn't even the hardest part. Madison grabbed a bottle of water—she really wanted a real drink, but it was barely five o'clock—and she started up the steps.

Madison heard the television and then laughter from the hallway and thought about turning around and letting them have their peace. Her presence created a tension no one needed these days. But she took a deep breath and walked into the big bedroom.

"Hey guys, what are you watching?" she asked, plastering on a smile.

The temperature dropped twenty degrees when she entered the room. Chaz shut right down. He hated Madison for having to give up his friends, his entire life, but he hated her even more for having to watch his father bleed out in that Maryland field. Penny was cool to her, but she'd been that way with Madison for years.

At least they'd been able to talk, and in some small way, Penny seemed to get it. She seemed to understand her mother in a way she never could before. But she also couldn't unsee her father lying in the field and her mother covered in his blood.

"So, you're some kind of spy?" she'd asked.

"I work for the CIA, yes," Madison had replied. The State Department fiction was completely blown up, but that didn't mean she was going to start spilling state secrets to her teenage daughter.

"And you were on a mission? That's why you were away so much, why Dad..."

"Yes, baby, I'm sorry."

"You're not the one who hurt him."

"But I'm the reason they did."

"Will we ever be safe?"

"We're working on that. I promise."

"It's a dumb movie about a family that finds out their dad was a hitman or a spy or something," Penny answered, dismissively. At least that felt normal. "I'm sure you'd hate it. You'd tell us all the ways that it's not realistic."

The mention of a dad made Madison's chest tighten.

"Give her some credit. Your mom knows everything doesn't have to be serious and real. I think we've all had too much reality these days."

Madison stared at her husband. It had been weeks, but his voice was still a weak rasp. She made herself do it because it was still hard to look at

Charles and see what she'd done to him. The hospital bed was tilted up so he could watch television with the kids, who sat on either side of him.

It broke her heart to see Charles in that bed. The strong, gregarious man she'd married was a shell of himself, pale and hollowed out. Weeks of fighting for his life had taken their toll. It was touch and go for a while. The only reason he was alive at all was that the staff at Walter Reed wouldn't give up on him. He'd spent weeks in the ICU before they moved him to the safe house. A nurse was in the next room.

The Agency provided security, but Madison had to be pried away from his bedside. She only left him when she was convinced that the kids needed her. And then she went to the safe house and sat up every night with the Glock in her lap. Security officers kept an eye on them, but all she saw when she tried to close her eyes was Anatoly's men coming through the door.

The room fell silent except for the television. They were a family that had lost that easiness of being together. Madison had no idea what to say to begin to make it right.

"Hey, guys, why don't you give your mom and me a minute? Go downstairs and look at the menus and decide what you want for dinner," Charles said.

Chaz stared at Madison like he didn't trust her alone with his dad. He'd been doing a lot of that. Penny took his arm and gently pulled him to his feet. "Come on, help me pick the most expensive things. After all, our tax dollars are paying for it," she said. As they passed, she gave her mom a look that said, *Check yourself. Don't get Dad worked up.* Penny closed the door behind them.

fifteen

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“How did your debrief at Langley go?” Charles asked when they were alone.

Madison stayed on the other side of the bedroom. The distance between them broke her heart. They’d talked some when he’d been well enough. She’d answered all of his questions, but there were still questions he hadn’t been ready to ask, and she didn’t know if she’d ever want to answer them. Those answers might change everything between them, but she would tell Charles whatever he wanted to know. She wasn’t going to let security clearances come between them anymore.

“They asked the same questions they’ve been asking for weeks. I gave the same answers. They can ask as many times as they like. My answers aren’t going to change.”

“Christ, come over and sit down, Maddy. You’re making me nervous standing over there. You look like you want to bolt out of the room.” He managed a weak smile.

She tentatively sat on the side of the bed. “How are you today? Did the doctor come out?”

“He didn’t come out, but I spoke to him. He likes the way my tests are trending. He’s still not happy we’re not doing this at the hospital, but he knows that’s not his call. He wants me to start physical therapy this week.”

“That’s good, babe. You’ll feel better when you’re back on your feet. I know it’s killing you to lie here like this.”

Madison took his hand without thinking. She tried to move it away, but he stopped her, squeezing it.

“Why are you so nervous around me? I’m your husband. Is there something you haven’t told me?”

Looking up, she fought the tears forming in her eyes. *There’s so much I haven’t told you*, she thought. “It’s just... It’s hard to see you like this, knowing I’m responsible. I don’t know how to say I’m sorry. I know words aren’t enough.”

“Look at me, Maddy.” He tugged her hand and wouldn’t go on until she did it. She saw the effect her unshed tears had on him and hated herself for that, too. “You’re not the one who shot me. You saved me—saved the kids. You and your team. I don’t even want to think...”

His eyes went unfocused, and she knew what he was thinking about. The *what if*... The only reason he had to consider that was that she brought trouble to their doorstep. Madison knew exactly what that *what if* meant in a way he never could.

“Don’t think about it. Please. Just don’t. Everyone is safe, and I know you’ll be fine. I’m sorry it’s so hard, but I know you’ll be fine.”

Charles grinned. “Missing half a lung will take some getting used to. I think my marathon days are over.”

Madison looked at him quizzically. “You don’t run marathons.” She got that he was kidding and allowed a little laugh. “Sorry to dash your dreams.”

He reached up, wincing when he did it, and touched her cheek. She brushed the tear from the corner of her eye. “Stop apologizing, Maddy. I mean it.”

“I’ll try,” she said, doubting he’d feel that way when he knew everything. It was only a matter of time until he asked. He’d want to finish

that conversation they had when he found their Plan B pills, and this time, she wouldn't deny him the answers. She owed him the truth.

"You said everyone is safe. Are we? You wanted me out of the hospital. We're here—wherever this is—we're not at home. The kids can't talk to their friends. Is it over, Maddy?"

"We will be. There are just a few loose ends to tie up. We need to neutralize the man who sent those people after you. After that, I think we can go home. There was another party in this, but Bristow tells me that's been handled."

"CIA Deputy Director Bristow?"

"Yes, this has been her operation from the beginning."

"So, you're her spy? She's like M, and you're James Bond?"

"Right. It's exactly like that. She sends me to exotic locations, and I kill people and sleep with beautiful women."

She stopped suddenly when she realized what she had said. It wasn't beautiful women, not usually, but... Charles let it slide.

"When you say neutralize..."

"Anatoly Reznikov is a very bad man. We have history. If the Agency doesn't deal with him, he won't stop."

"Can you say why?"

Madison took her hand from his and reached for the tie holding her hair in a ponytail. She shook it out and ran her fingers through her ginger locks. She didn't want to look so severe when she talked about this. She wanted to remind Charles of the woman he fell in love with.

"The immediate answer is that I killed his son. Damien and I did it, right before we came and found you."

"Damien?"

"He's a member of my team," she quickly replied, seeing that Charles knew it wasn't a complete answer. "We killed his son Sergei, and Reznikov wants revenge."

“You said that’s the immediate answer.”

“Yes, that’s what just happened. But I have a history with Anatoly Reznikov. Many years ago, when I still worked in the field, I was assigned to...get close...and disrupt an arms deal. Things went sideways. We barely escaped with our lives. I shot him then and thought I killed him, but apparently not.”

Charles squeezed his eyes shut. He looked pained. “I’m sorry, Maddy. I’m trying to process all of this, but I’m just having trouble picturing this other version of you. A version that shoots people. I mean, I saw it, but everything in that field is hazy. The woman I know isn’t *getting close* to Russian bad guys and shooting them. She makes sure we have full-sized candy bars to hand out on Halloween. We’ve been together for so long, but I feel like I don’t even know the real you. Is it the woman who shoots people or the one who gives out candy bars?”

“Can’t I be both?” Having to ask the question broke something inside her.

“I don’t know. How do you just switch off between those two versions of you?”

“I don’t. I’ve been on a desk at Langley the whole time we’ve been married. I gave all of that up. I chose you.”

“Until now.”

“I didn’t have a choice. This thing...this weapon...we couldn’t let it get out there. It had to be stopped.”

“And you’re the only one they had that could do it?”

“This was a very specific circumstance. We needed a way in. One of the men involved in the deal, he has...”

Madison groped for a way to tell her husband that she was chosen because Zaydan likes to fuck older, married women. *How do I tell him that my job was to fuck another man?*

“So, you were sent in to *get close* to someone.”

It was a statement, not a question. Madison looked away instead of trying to answer him. Charles knew the answer.

“Are redheads his thing? The Agency must have other redheaded field officers. There’s dye.”

“Do you really want to know? I’ll tell you, if you do.”

Charles weighed it. He was pretty sure he didn’t want to know. But he had to know. He looked at Madison sitting there beside him, and she looked like the wife he knew. But now that seemed like a mask.

Superimposed over the mother of his children was the woman in the field in Maryland who shot a man in the head without flinching. The women who *got close* to men for the CIA. He knew the former should be the bigger problem—letting that violence near their children—but he was hung up on the latter.

He took her hand back, anchored her to him. He thought they both needed it. “Tell me, Maddy. We can’t have secrets anymore. I can’t love part of you. I need to know all of you.”

“And what if you can’t? I’ve done things... They were necessary, but I’m not proud of them, Charles.”

“I know how the world works. I know that sometimes people have to do the necessary things to keep us safe, the things we can’t face and call ourselves the good guys. It’s a terrible burden to put on the people who do it. I don’t want you to carry it by yourself.”

“But you didn’t answer me. What if you can’t carry it?”

“I’ll do my best. I love you. That’s all I can promise you.”

Charles watched Madison sit there and work through it, find a way to tell him all of the things she never wanted him to know. He understood that saying he wanted to carry them was one thing, but actually doing it was another. He’d always known that Madison was strong, but now he knew that he’d had no idea how strong. He had to hope to be as strong as she was.

“Zay...*he*...has a weakness for a certain sort of woman. I think he has mommy issues. And he likes taken women. He’s entitled, and I think he wants to take things from other men because he should have anything he wants. The Agency thought I was uniquely *qualified* to get close to him.”

“Bad guys bring dates to their meetings? Did he confess his plans like a Bond villain, too?” He had to try to find some lightness in the dark. He’d already heard things he couldn’t process.

Mommy issues. Taken women. Madison was taken—by Charles. She was a mother. He understood why this man—whoever he was—would want her. And he understood how honeytraps worked, but how open would someone be with some married woman they were fucking? His stomach clenched when he thought it.

Madison fucked him.

“Well, no. There was another wrinkle. This man, he likes to spend time at a private club. We thought he’d conduct business there because privacy is at a premium there. It was the perfect place to insert someone and get up close to the deal. I’m sorry, Charles. I know you understand what this means.”

“I meant it when I said to stop apologizing. Maybe I’m trying to get my head around what you do, but I know you were doing your job.”

A look crossed her face. Doubt? Real guilt—not regret about her work—but real guilt. It clicked for Charles. Madison didn’t just go in there, seduce this man, and close her eyes while they had sex. She liked it. She could say that it was her job all she liked, but Madison liked her work.

She liked fucking other men.

How many times has she done this? How many men has she fucked? How many has she fucked while we’ve been married? Madison said she had been out of the field, but Charles knew there were still things she couldn’t tell him.

He'd told Madison that if she had to do it, he wanted her to find some pleasure in it. But faced with the reality of it, Charles didn't know how to handle the thought of his wife spreading for other men, taking them with enthusiasm. Coming for them.

Madison had always been wild. She was the most sexual woman he'd ever known. Part of him felt it was unfair to judge her now for being exactly what he knew she was. It wasn't like she was going out to fuck random guys. She used her body in service to their country. He could intellectually understand it. But the feelings that came...

"This man, your target, he was this Russian's son?"

Charles felt a chill when he thought, *Maddy fucked the father and the son. She seduced them both. Did she compare them? Did this man want Maddy because she fucked his father?* The more he thought about it, the more he became lost in the labyrinth of depravity. And his wife was at the center of it.

"No. Sergei was on the other side of the deal. He's an animal. I wouldn't let him touch me."

Charles was relieved that she had a line. That's where they were. He was relieved that there were some men out there who were too evil for his wife to fuck.

"And this other man? He's not a threat?"

"No. He has much more to lose than the Russians. He's a state actor, not a gangster. His country has backed off in exchange for a certain set of assurances."

Madison had been worried about Zaydan. The prince had many more resources to come after her than the Russians, and he'd been thoroughly humiliated. But the Royal Family didn't want that humiliation to extend to them.

The Kharabatis had many reasons to bury the whole affair, their business interests in the West being paramount among them. The Kharabati

government was a state sponsor of terror, but they were also an important partner to the United States. They sat on the world's third-largest oil reserves. No one wanted to see that relationship unravel. They certainly were not going to do it for Zaydan.

The prince returned to his country as a pariah. Not only had his recklessness nearly caused an international incident, but the Royal Family also was out billions of dollars, and they had nothing to show for it. Anatoly Reznikov did not offer refunds. The CIA had been hoping that the Kharabatis would do their work for them and take out the Russians.

The Null:Echo affair finally gave Crown Prince Omar the excuse he'd been looking for to crack down on his younger brother. His father would not protect Zaydan this time. He'd been sent to Kharabat's strictest madrasa, where the clerics were purging the evils of the West from him day and night.

Charles looked at his wife, and the images came, unbidden, as they had after he found those pills. Madison smiling for another man that way she does when she wants something. Touching him in that encouraging way women do when they're interested. On her knees, using her skills to cement his attachment. He knew better than anyone that Madison could make a priest renounce his vows with that mouth. On her back, breathlessly begging for it, clenching around him when she came.

The thoughts twisted him up inside. Charles thought he'd never be able to touch her again when they came. But there was that other thing. That shameful thing. He didn't want it. Didn't want any of it.

But the visions touched him on some primal level, the part of him that had always been proud that a woman like Madison chose him. Part of him liked that his wife was so fucking hot that she could save the world by slipping off her dress and opening her legs. Her body was a weapon of mass destruction.

Every man, on some level, wanted other men to covet what they had. Charles wasn't above that. And Madison was the ultimate prize. Her passion was irresistible. It might kill him, but some part of Charles wanted to see Madison in her full power. To experience it.

"I would have never done any of this if I didn't have to, Charles," she said, pulling his attention back to the present. "This is the life I want. You're the one I want."

He wanted to believe that. "Now that it's all over, you just go back to Langley? Back to your desk? Just close off that part of yourself?"

"If I stay with the Agency, yes. I think I need a clean break after all of this. I've worked for them for my entire adult life, but being an officer isn't who I am. It can't be. *This* is who I am. A mother. Your wife, if you'll have me."

"This is all a lot, Maddy. I won't lie. Our world has been knocked off its axis. But I'm not giving up on our family that easily. I want to believe that if we work at it, we can figure out what we are now, even if it's something completely different than what we were. That's if you can truly leave it all behind."

"I chose you sixteen years ago. It's even easier this time. It's not even a question."

"And if they call you again? If there's something only you can do? If there's someone only you can..." He regretted saying the last part when he saw her face and couldn't finish it.

"I tell them to find someone else."

"And if they can't?"

Madison stopped and thought about it. "Then I come to you, and we decide together."

Charles thought that was an answer he could live with. He was about to tell her so when her phone dinged. Madison took it out of her inside pocket and read a text.

“I’m sorry, I have to go. The mission is over, but the Agency isn’t happy with how it ended. I need to make sure my people don’t get scapegoated.”

“Go, finish all of this. If you’re really going to put the CIA behind you, you’ve got to wrap this up.”

“Thank you. I love you.”

“I love you, too,” he said.

sixteen

. . .

“Thanks for coming,” Kane said, holding the door to his DC townhouse open.

The townhouse was better put together than she would have expected, but Madison realized that she didn’t really know who he was. Not anymore. It had been over fifteen years since she had intimate insight into Kane. People change a lot in that span of time. However, the townhouse had all the hallmarks of being a rental, down to the furniture, so it didn’t say anything about Kane at all.

“You said it was urgent,” she replied. She hated leaving her husband to rush to Kane’s side, but they had unfinished business.

“I wouldn’t have reached out if it wasn’t. I know you’re taking care of your family.”

“When I can. They dragged me back to Langley again today to go through all of it all over again. They’re dissecting every moment of what happened in the Hamptons. Null:Echo is gone. They aren’t going to take it lying down. This is going to be somebody’s fault. The government had plans for a tool like that.”

“Which is why they couldn’t get their hands on it,” he simply said, like it wasn’t a question.

Madison turned the corner into the living room and stopped short when she saw Manny sitting on the couch. He was pale—paler than usual—and his eyes were bloodshot. He twitched with nervous energy. He looked like he hadn't slept since they left the Hamptons.

"What's going on?" she asked, looking between the two men.

"I don't know what to do. I think they're going to bury me in the deepest hole they have, and cover it over," Manny said. His words tumbled over each other. "Do you know how small a supermax cell is? It's like seven-by-twelve. The window is four-by-four. That's your entire world. It's like living in a coffin. I can't do that."

"Why would they put you in a cell, Manny? What do they... What did you do, Manny?" She turned to Kane. "What's going on? What did he do? What part do you have in this, Damien?"

"Do you want a drink?" he asked, going to an open bottle of bourbon that sat on the counter between the living room and the kitchen. He was back to drinking Maker's Mark, not the experience whiskies he had at Nox Venari.

"I'm good," she replied.

"You might change your mind about that."

"What did you do, Damien? Did you switch out Null:Echo when I gave it to you? Please tell me you didn't..."

"Do you think I'm smart enough to figure out something like that? I didn't even know what it looked like before you gave it to me."

Madison zeroed in on Manny. "You did it. You switched out the drive somehow. Why would you do that? Do you know what you've done? You're right, they will bury you for this. It has to be either me, Kane, or you. And I'm pretty sure I convinced Bristow it wasn't me."

"Cass had her hands on it, too!"

"No one believes Cass would have stolen Null:Echo. She's a straight shooter."

“I didn’t switch it out! I wouldn’t steal something like that. They’d give me the needle for that! Oh fuck, what if they charge me with treason and execute me?”

“Calm down, Manny. They aren’t going to execute you for anything. They don’t actually *know* anything yet,” Madison said. Part of her was glad to turn her attention to someone else’s problems. “They can’t charge you with treason if they can’t prove anything.” She turned back to Kane. “Why is he here?”

Kane downed two fingers of bourbon and poured two more. “I told him to do it. At the beginning, long before we had our hands on it, I convinced Manny that no one could have Null:Echo. Something like that shouldn’t exist.”

“Jesus, Damien! That’s not our call.”

“Do you trust the assholes in charge with that kind of power, Maddy?”

The answer was *obviously not*, but she would have never taken it upon herself to just take it from the CIA. “Where is it?”

“It’s gone.” Kane waved his hand. Madison noted that the bottle was half-empty. “Like all those people in the *Avengers* movies. Dust in the wind. Hiding it didn’t make any sense. Someone would have found it.”

“Can’t they just build another one? For all we know, Glacier Flame only handed out a copy. They might still have it. The Russians aren’t exactly honest actors.”

“That’s what I told him,” Manny said. A glass of the amber liquid sat in front of him, but it looked like he hadn’t touched it. “Someone else will figure it out and build a new Null:Echo. It’s inevitable.”

“But the CIA doesn’t have *this one*, so I can sleep at night for a while longer,” Kane said. “Hopefully, they’ll develop quantum encryption before China builds the next Null:Echo.”

Madison walked past Kane and tipped the bottle into her mouth. The burning felt like the punishment she deserved. “Jesus, Damien. You were

always good at creating a mess. What's the plan? The Agency isn't going to stop until they figure out what happened, or they decide what happened and make that the official story."

"I know. I think we should pin it on the Russians. They fucked the Kharabatis over. The Russians never had any intention of giving them the real thing," Kane said.

"And how are you going to prove that?"

"Maybe it will be Reznikov's dying declaration."

"How do you plan to make that happen? Bristow told me they're closing in on him right now."

Kane snorted. "Bristow is full of shit. I think they'll cut a deal with him before they kill him. A man like that knows where all the bodies are buried. If he promises to roll over and be a good boy, they'll look the other way."

"They can't. You know they can't. I don't care what he promises. We killed his son. I shot him all those years ago. Anatoly will never let that go. My family will never be safe. They have to know that." Madison barely resisted the urge to throw Kane's bottle.

"Maybe they'll try to put you into permanent witness protection. Tell you some bullshit like they couldn't get to him after all."

"No. I won't do that to my family."

"I know. I agree. Reznikov has to be dealt with, and we can't leave it to the Agency."

"What can we do?"

"I don't know. I don't know if I can do anything anymore. They haven't said anything official, but they're putting me out to pasture."

"What?"

"They're going to offer me a teaching post at The Farm, knowing I'll never accept it. I'd watch your back, too. Cass and Tay can probably escape it because they weren't on the inside, but you and I, we can't escape the

taint of Scarlet Phantom. They're always going to suspect us of being involved with this Null:Echo thing. Our careers are over."

"What about me? You guys seem to have forgotten me," Manny complained.

"You need to pull the ripcord, like you said. Don't wait around for them to grab you," Kane suggested.

"What's the ripcord?" Madison asked.

"I've been building another identity for years. I can slip into it like I've always been him."

"It's the CIA, Manny," Madison countered. "They find people."

"And I know exactly how they do it, which is why they won't find me. I can be gone. I just don't know what I'll tell my mother."

"So that's it?" Madison asked. "Manny disappears? You what, retire? Take up fishing? And what do I do?"

"Go back to your family, Maddy," Kane said, looking her in the eyes. "Be thankful you have something to go back to. You made the right decision all those years ago. You always were smarter than me."

Manny was up and pacing. "Fuck. I have so much to do, and I have to do this fast. I'm gonna go. Thanks for helping me think this through. You're right, Damien. I have to go. Forever."

Kane gave Manny a hearty handshake. "Good luck, brother. And thank you for having the balls to do the right thing. It's a shame no one can ever know what you sacrificed."

"Thanks, but you didn't talk me into anything. I knew no one should have Null:Echo. I knew it from the beginning. I just needed to know that someone else agreed."

Madison gave Manny a hug and let it linger when he held onto her. "Good luck. Thank you for everything. I think you're the reason we're still here. Thank you for everything."

"It was an honor."

And with that, Madison and Kane were alone one more time.

“WHAT ARE you going to do, Damien?”

Madison took another long pull on the bottle. The fuzziness pushed in from the edges, and it was a relief. She put her hand on his on the counter.

“Wrap up all my business and settle all my accounts. Then maybe I’ll follow Manny and exit stage left. He’s not the only one with a backup plan. Don’t we all have them?”

Madison hadn’t had a go bag with a cache of passports tucked away in years. There was no quietly slipping away in the night when you had a family. “I get that you think you’re finished with the Agency, but what will you do? Have you built a life outside of it?”

Kane laughed softly. “Do you want to hear that I have a cute little family tucked away outside of Omaha? They think Daddy goes on the road to sell medical equipment? They’d have to believe I’m the most accidental motherfucker on the planet with all these scars. There’s no quiet little life for me. That ship sailed a long time ago. I didn’t get the happy ending I wanted.”

If he was trying to break her heart, he was doing a good job.

“If you’re going to leave the Agency, you need to figure out who you are without it.”

“There is a lot of work for someone with my skills on the private market. I’ll be good. I have a pension.”

“That’s what you do, Damien. It’s not who you are.”

He laced his fingers through hers. “And if I asked you to disappear with me?”

Madison ran her thumb over the back of his hand. “You know I can’t do that.”

“Choosing him again.”

“It’s not just him this time. Penny. Chaz.”

“Will he take you back, now that he knows everything? I assume you had to come clean.”

“I told Charles everything he wanted to know. It’s probably too much, but he didn’t run away. Not yet. Maybe he can live with it.”

“I hope so, Maddy. I really do. You deserve to be happy. You were smart enough to build a different life. Now go live it.”

“Damien...”

“It’s okay. At least I really know it’s goodbye this time. You’re not just slipping away after fucking me one last time.”

That hurt, but he wasn’t wrong. “I was a coward. I couldn’t...”

“It’s okay, Maddy. Obviously, I don’t hate you for it.”

All that Madison saw in his eyes was the love he’d carried for her for sixteen years, despite everything that had happened, despite her walking away. She was in limbo, wondering if Charles could accept knowing all of her, but here was Kane, who already did. He knew who Madison was and accepted her for it.

She couldn’t imagine not having the kids, but she had to wonder what her life would have been like if she’d made a different choice. She could still have it if she were the kind of woman who could walk away from her family. But she wasn’t. She had to hope Charles could accept her.

But she didn’t have to walk away from Kane without a proper goodbye as she’d done sixteen years ago. Madison looked into those eyes, and that acceptance was what she needed before she went back to a life that might not take her back. Madison could finally give Kane a proper goodbye.

Madison tenderly kissed him. He whispered her name. It was a question. And then she kissed him again. The tenderness sparked their passion, and she was in his arms. Her nails dug into the back of his neck when she pulled him down to her and darted her tongue between his lips.

“Are you sure?”

Kane only asked the question once before she led him back to his bedroom. Madison went to her knees and opened his black jeans. He threw off his old Danzig t-shirt while she wrestled him out of his underwear. Her eyes closed, and her lips parted, and she kissed his cock in that way that had always ruined him.

She licked him from root to tip, never breaking eye contact. She sucked on his balls, and the way his mouth hung open made Madison want to do every filthy thing to him. This was what she needed. She needed to be the dirty version of herself that she wasn't sure her husband could accept. She knew Kane loved her for it.

“Please, Damien. I need this,” she whispered, his cock against her lips, the words sending vibrations up through his shaft.

“Fuck, Maddy...”

Kane laced his fingers in her titian hair and pulled her mouth onto him. He didn't force her because the deeper he pushed, the harder she sucked, but he pushed into her throat and steadily fucked Madison's mouth in the way she craved it. He grunted and fed her his cock, determined to get every ounce of satisfaction from her hunger. He knew this was their last time together. He fully expected Madison to swallow his load and walk out of his life.

But she pulled off him with a wet pop, licking her messy, swollen lips. She pushed on his thighs and told him to get onto the bed. Madison was not going to be satisfied with just sucking him. She wanted it all.

Kane lay back and never took his eyes from her. God, watching Madison strip and reveal that body never got old. She did something to him on a chemical level that no other woman ever had. Her black bra followed her shirt onto the floor. The way her tits swayed and jiggled when she wiggled out of her jeans was hypnotic. Kane didn't want to believe this was the last time he'd ever see it.

Madison sank onto him with a long, low, satisfied moan. She would miss the way Kane stretched and filled her. She couldn't believe she'd allowed the memory of how perfectly they fit together to blur over time. It felt cruel that she'd had a taste of it again and had to give it up again. She rolled her hips, enjoying the way he moved inside her, and making his eyes roll back. But then she braced her hands on his stomach and started to move.

"Ohhh fuck...Maddy...fuck...that's incredible, baby...just like...ohhh...that..."

"Love how you feel...mmm...inside me...sooo good...sooo right..."

"Yeah...fucking perfect, Maddy... Harder...fuck me harder, baby..."

The demand was what she wanted. Time had not diminished the sizzling heat she'd always felt with Kane. She rocked harder on him. Faster. And then he grabbed her hips and forced her to go even harder, taking over.

"Ohhh god...yesss...ohhh fuck...yesss...Damien...please...fuck...fuck me..."

Kane's hips were coming off the bed. He drove his cock into her with every ounce of urgency he felt.

"Yesss...yesss... Fuck! Damien... Fuck...I'm..."

Madison threw her head back and wailed at the ceiling fan. She held her bouncing breasts and rolled her nipples, making her come that much harder. She clenched around him, her pussy demanding he finish with her, but Kane fucked her through it. He was not done with her. She didn't want him to be. Madison wanted him to last as long as he possibly could.

Kane put Madison on her back, and she wrapped her legs around him, pulling him inside her. They kissed fiercely, every powerful thrust punctuated with a grunt.

"Yesss...fuck me...Damien...please...ohmygod...fuck me..."

"So fucking hot...so needy...always need it..."

"Yesss...need it...need you...please...give it to me...Damien..."

Kane tried to hold out, but her heat melted his resolve. No mortal man could hold out with a woman like Madison. He'd assumed Zaydan had been taking blue pills to last all night. She out-fucked everyone she was with. He'd seen it many times. When he finally filled her—for the last time—she screamed that she was coming, too. Kane kept pumping for as long as he stayed hard, but then he collapsed into her arms, and she held him tightly. It felt like she'd never let go, and he wished it were true.

Madison showed afterward. She couldn't go back to Charles smelling like sex. She didn't fool herself about what she'd done. It wasn't for work or her country. It was for her because in that moment, she needed something only Kane could give her.

Kane never got out of bed. He wanted to live in the moment because it would be over too soon. Madison dressed, brushed her hair, and then she bent over to kiss him. He was grateful that she didn't wait until he was asleep to sneak out this time.

“Goodbye, Damien,” she said.

“Goodbye, Maddy. Go fight for your family.”

Madison walked out of his life for the last time.

seventeen

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Six Months Later

“SIR, there is a storm coming in. I have to get you inside. You know what the cold does to you.”

Reznikov sneered at his attendant. The young woman was always fussing over him like he was an invalid—like he was not a real man. But she didn’t know the man he’d been, the one who’d have bent her over the wall bordering his patio, not the man who needed to be wheeled inside before he caught a sniffle. The American whore had killed that man. His echo was all that remained.

He still kept pretty young women around, even though his ability to enjoy them had been greatly diminished. He still touched and kissed them, but he was unable to use them as a man should. Sometimes, when he needed a reminder of the old days, he’d call in one of the guards to fuck them. This one was particularly fond of Dmitry, his driver and bodyguard.

“It is almost sunset. Leave me be!” he grumbled. She reached for the handles on the back of his wheelchair, and he smacked at her hands. “I will decide when I go inside. Do you know who I am?”

“Sir, respectfully, it is not safe to spend too much time outside. Those Kharabati dogs still want their pound of flesh. And you have many other enemies. Why make it easy for them?”

That was Dmitry, standing by the ornate patio doors with his hands clasped in front of him. *Of course, he takes her side. She looks like an incredible fuck*, Reznikov thought.

“I am fine. I am safe. I am watched over now.” He chuckled.

His safety was the one thing he didn’t worry about. Reznikov had lost his health and his son. He didn’t much care if someone took him out, but not until he paid the American whore back for her treachery. His people had not yet located her, but the CIA was sloppy. They would reveal her location eventually.

If only he still had Null:Echo. Reznikov could have located her in five minutes. But the programmer who built it had OD’d shortly after they’d sold it to the Kharabatis, and no one else in Glacier Flame had been able to recreate it.

Reznikov would find the American whore. Milica. Madison Sinclair. Whatever name she was using now. He’d wait as long as he had to. His hate was a powerful force. It would sustain him. She’d be dragged in front of him with her family, and he’d make her watch him take everything from her as she had from him. And then he’d start taking her apart piece by piece.

“Sir, I must insist,” the girl said as the first sleet began to fall.

“Fine.”

She began to turn his wheelchair, but his phone rang, and he made her pause. Only a handful of people in the world had his personal cell number. He had to take those calls.

“*Da?*”

“I wonder if you’ll shit yourself like Sergei when I take you out.” The voice was American, speaking in English.

“Who is this? How dare you...” He replied in the same language.

“I feel like you’re the Tootsie Pop of assholes. How many bullets to the head will it take to finally get to your gooey center and end you?”

“How did you get this number? I will skin you...”

Reznikov was abruptly cut off when his head snapped back, and his brains sprayed all over the woman behind him. The report of a rifle followed a beat later. Dmitry pushed off the wall and drew his weapon, but he had no idea where the shot came from. The attendant was screaming and wiping at the blood and brains on her uniform. Dmitry checked Reznikov’s pulse, even though he knew it was pointless. He heard a tinny voice from the mobile phone, which had tumbled to the flagstones.

“Two. A-one, A-two. Sixteen years apart, but two shots to get to the gooey center of an asshole.”

KANE WAS WALKING DOWN OUT of the hills, with his rifle slung over his shoulder, when the voice stopped him.

“Hands where I can see them, motherfucker. Don’t make any sudden moves, unless you want to be as dead as Reznikov.”

Kane slowly raised his hands and grinned. He’d come a long way and completed his mission. What happened next didn’t matter much, but he had a feeling he was safe. He recognized that voice.

“Are you going to shoot me in the back, Tay? I always thought you’re the type who wants someone to see it coming.”

“Kane? What the fuck?”

The older man slowly turned and lowered his balaclava. He grinned at Dentiger, who’d just stepped out of the brush in a ghillie suit. The man kept his weapon trained on Kane as he walked closer.

“Y’know, when I heard you left the Agency, somehow I knew you’d turn up here.”

“Everybody’s got to be somewhere, and I had a job to finish. Can I put my arms down?”

“Yeah. I don’t think you’ll shoot me.”

“Even though you deserve it. How can you hide in the bushes to keep that asshole alive? Good job, by the way.”

“Fuck you. I’m lucky I still have a job after the shitshow that Scarlet Phantom turned into. They tell me to go sit in a bush in Russia, I go. Hold on.” Dentiger pushed a button on his radio and said, “Sector Three. I don’t have anything. It was a false alarm. The shooter must be somewhere else.”

“I guess that means you’re not turning me in,” Kane said.

“I should. What the fuck, man? Do you know how many networks we’ve shut down with his intel? We’ve cut human trafficking from Eastern Europe by almost 20%.”

“At what cost, Tay? Did you know that Maddy and her family are still living in that safe house?”

“I was told Reznikov promised to leave her alone as part of the deal.”

Kane laughed. “Luckily, Bristow is smarter than you and kept her protected. I hear that Cass personally took charge of Maddy’s protection detail.”

“She’s good people. She feels responsible for how everything went down—Maddy’s family, Manny running off with Null:Echo.”

“Manny didn’t run off with Null:Echo. That’s not him. It’s just gone.”

Dentiger eyed him suspiciously. “Why do you sound so sure about that?”

“I’m just saying I don’t think he stole it.”

“Then why did he run?”

“Would you have waited around for them to pin everything on you?”

“They’ll find him eventually.”

Kane shook his head and laughed. “I don’t think so. He knows what he’s doing. Now, are you going to shoot me, take me in, or let me go? It’s

fucking cold out here, and I need a drink.”

Dentiger gestured with his weapon. “Get the fuck out of here before I change my mind. And don’t let me see you again, motherfucker.”

“Listen, if this Reznikov thing is the final nail in the coffin for your career with the Agency, look me up. I can hook you up with some private sector work. I owe you.”

“Yeah, you do. Now get on out of here.”

Kane tossed off a salute and turned to keep moving down the road. With the final loose end tied up, he really could start to figure out what his future was. He thought about what Madison had said that last night in his condo and laughed.

“I fucking hate fishing.”

THREE MONTHS Later

MADISON STOOD on the beach and let the South Florida sun bake into her pale skin. She was slathered in sunblock, but she still loved to feel the heat. The two-piece she wore was of the more modest variety, not the skimpy string bikini she’d worn in the Hamptons to entice Zaydan. That felt like a lifetime ago.

“Mom, I think I left my earbuds in the car,” Penny called from their blanket.

“Then get the keys and go back and get them.”

Madison only hesitated for a moment before telling her daughter to go off on her own. Her family was finally safe, and she had to learn how to accept that. They were finally free, and they still had their names. She didn’t know the details, and she never would, but she trusted they were safe.

The Agency had kept them in custody while they tried to pressure the Sinclairs to enter permanent witness protection. Bristow claimed that Reznikov had slipped the noose and was in the wind. She suggested that Manny had tipped him off, since he'd disappeared, too. Madison, of course, knew that was bullshit. He suspected that Kane had been right all along. The CIA was protecting Anatoly Reznikov, and her family was a necessary sacrifice. Cassandra, on the other hand, had been great. She told Madison there was no rush to make a decision. She would keep the family safe.

About a month ago, Cassandra had come to the safehouse to tell Madison they were free. She couldn't offer much of an explanation. She just said the threat had been lifted. The Sinclairs gathered their things and cleared out as quickly as they could.

Madison didn't need an explanation. She knew what happened. Kane happened. She knew it in her bones.

Her resignation was on Bristow's desk in forty-eight hours. The Agency had kept Madison on paid leave while she was in protection. They didn't fight her on her resignation.

"If you keep stretching out that body like that, I'm going to need to take you back to the car."

Charles slipped an arm around her waist and kissed her cheek. He was still slow and weak, but his recovery was coming along nicely. He was determined to get back everything he'd lost.

She turned and kissed him on the lips. The kiss lingered. It felt good. They'd needed a long time to get back to kissing like that. There was still a lot of work to do. She'd only moved back into his bedroom two weeks ago, but she was hopeful. They would work through everything.

"Yeah, do you think you're flexible enough to fuck me in the backseat of that SUV?" she asked.

He kissed her again. "If you get on top."

Madison laughed. “Don’t get too used to me doing all the work. A girl likes to get fucked, too, y’know.”

“Oh, I am well aware. I’ll prove it when we get back to the house.”

“Is that a promise, Mr. Sinclair?”

“Of course, Mrs. Sinclair.”

The house was their new house. They both wanted a fresh start, and Madison wanted sunshine. They’d vacationed down in Florida and decided to make it home. Charles could work from anywhere when he was healthy enough to go back, and there were plenty of corporate security or executive protection gigs for Madison down there. She liked the peace of mind of living in a gated community like Peregrine’s Nest. And their new house on Milford Court was perfect. The neighbors were very friendly.

Madison was out of the CIA, but she was sure she would always find a way to keep life interesting. Until then, she was content to enjoy normal for a change. Maybe the life of an ordinary suburban mom was more exciting than she thought.

the vanlife swingers



The open road promised freedom. It delivered danger.

Tom and Megan Henderson walked away from everything—the careers, the mortgage, the grind—and never looked back. Now they're living on their own terms, chasing sunsets and racking up online followers from Coast to Coast. Life is good. Life is free.

Then they met the Lupinos.

One campfire. One reckless night. What felt like a once-in-a-lifetime adventure becomes an obsession. Somehow, Bobby and Alicia keep showing up. Same campgrounds. Same rest stops. Always smiling. Always waiting. Tom wants out. Megan loves the danger. And the Lupinos? They aren't letting go without a fight.

What began as a thrilling escape is closing in fast. There's nowhere to run when someone knows every road you travel. No one to call when the threat is a campfire away. And no way to know how far two strangers will go to keep what they've decided belongs to them.

The Hendersons are about to find out that the most dangerous place in America isn't always a dark alley or a bad neighborhood.

Sometimes, it's a peaceful campground after dark.

They thought that night was a detour. It became a dead end.

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undercover wife



She walked away from the life. Now the life needs her back.

Madison Sinclair was one of the CIA's best. Then she chose love over the field, traded covert ops for carpool lanes, and spent sixteen years behind a desk in Langley. She told herself she didn't miss it.

She was wrong.

When Deputy Director Bristow summons her, Madison is pulled back into a world she thought she'd left behind. A Russian hacker collective called Glacier Flame has built **Null:Echo**, a quantum cipher key capable of cracking any system on earth, instantly and without a trace. The buyer? Kharabat, one of the world's most dangerous state sponsors of terror. The CIA has one shot to stop the deal, and it needs Madison to take it. The target, Prince Zaydan, has a very specific weakness: older, married women. Madison fits the profile perfectly. Operation **Scarlet Phantom** is born.

So she's handed a new identity, a new "husband," and a mission that will push every limit she has.

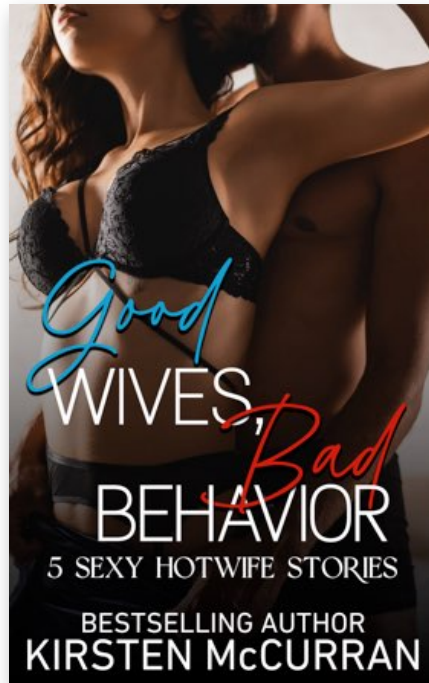
Her husband? Damien Kane — her former partner, former lover, and the man she walked away from sixteen years ago when she chose Charles. Their last mission together nearly killed them both. This one might finish the job.

As David and Michelle Richardson, Madison and Kane infiltrate **Nox Venari**, an elite, international sex club where the Null:Echo deal is set to go down. Madison must seduce the prince, neutralize the threat, and keep her marriage—and her sanity—intact.

Undercover Wife is the bestselling erotic thriller series from Kirsten McCurran, The Queen of Sexy Suburban Secrets.

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good wives, bad behavior



From the mind of one of hotwife erotica's most loved writers comes this bestselling collection of 5 sultry stories featuring sexy suburban couples exploring their sexuality with their friends and neighbors. These very good wives behaving very badly could be the woman you see at the grocery store or the president of your local PTA. Kirsten McCurran specializes in pulling back the curtain on everyday couples' most forbidden desires.

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claire unwrapped



Once, she was everyone’s fantasy. This Christmas, she’s about to become her own.

At forty-eight, **Claire Weston** is a small-town celebrity. Every December she takes the stage as the leading lady in Merry Hollow’s annual Christmas play—a beloved local tradition that lets her dust off the spotlight she once knew so well. Decades ago, she played the sultry Raven Chandler on the hit soap *The Edge of Desire*. Now she teaches elementary school, tends to her marriage, and saves her acting for the holidays.

But this year’s production feels different. Her new co-star, **Ethan Blake**, is twenty years younger, dangerously charming, and very aware of who she used to be. Their chemistry is instant—and impossible to ignore. Every rehearsal runs a little hotter, every “stage kiss” lingers a little too long, until the line between acting and wanting begins to blur.

Her husband **Daniel** has always loved watching her shine, but seeing other men drawn to her stirs something unexpected—something thrilling, possessive, and just a little forbidden. And as the snow

falls and the curtain rises, Claire finds herself at the center of a passion she never expected to feel again.

Claire Unwrapped is a steamy, emotional holiday romance about marriage, trust, and the intoxicating power of being desired—on stage, and off.

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the new wife on milford court



When Jeremy Sampson lands his dream job, it seems like a golden opportunity for his family. His wife, April, reluctantly gives up a life she loves for the shiny promise of a new adventure.

The Sampsons' luxurious new house on Milford Court is a dream home, but as they settle in, April can't shake the feeling that something is off about their glamorous new neighbors.

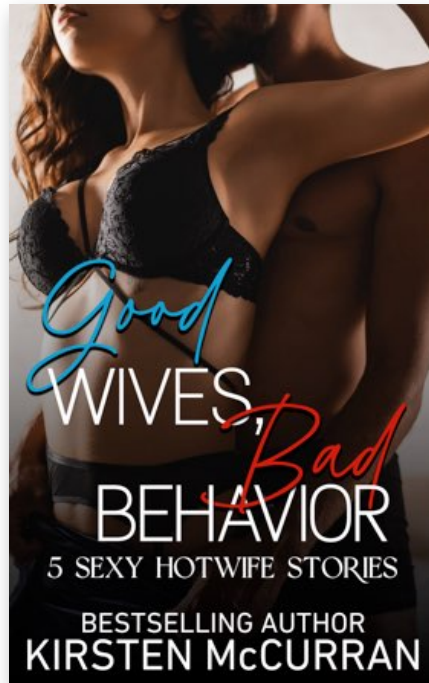
Sultry secrets lurk everywhere. April discovers the wives of Milford Court share a very special bond, one they're eager to share with her. As she delves deeper into the secrets of the gated community, April uncovers a world of forbidden temptations and dark desires.

Can April and Jeremy resist forbidden games played by the couples of Milford Court? Will Jeremy's dream job become a nightmare when he learns the real reason behind his good fortune? Get ready for a thrilling journey into the exclusive world of Milford Court, where nothing is as it seems.

The New Wife on Milford Court is the latest adventure from bestselling author Kirsten McCurran, The Queen of Suburban Secrets!

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good wives, bad behavior



From the mind of one of hotwife erotica's most loved writers comes this bestselling collection of 5 sultry stories featuring sexy suburban couples exploring their sexuality with their friends and neighbors. These very good wives behaving very badly could be the woman you see at the grocery store or the president of your local PTA. Kirsten McCurran specializes in pulling back the curtain on everyday couples' most forbidden desires.

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picking forbidden fruit



Lauren Curry is a skilled massage therapist who finds joy in relieving her clients' pains. If anything, she's too giving, putting her clients first whenever she can. When a longtime family friend, Dylan, injures himself working for his father during college summer break, Lauren offers to treat him without hesitation.

Lauren is always the consummate professional, even when an attractive man is on her table—not that she sees Dylan as attractive. He's just a family friend. She's known the young man for ages. But once she gets her hands on the college athlete's body, Lauren discovers just how sculpted it is. Lauren admires his physique with professional detachment until Dylan turns over, and she discovers that he's enjoying her treatment *a little too much*.

Can Lauren do the right thing and keep it professional? Or will a hot college baseball player help this suburban wife find her inner cougar? Dylan is a family friend. He's forbidden fruit. Can she resist picking it?

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tara's homecoming



Tara usually passes on her husband's bro weekend with all his buddies at the Lockley University homecoming game, even though she knows all of them from their college days. She was a staple in their apartment when she started dating Mark. But it's their 20th year of tailgating, and she decides to see if the boys are as wild as they used to be.

The boys, Austin, Danny, and Shaun, were always like family to her, but Tara learns they see her very differently when their old drinking game, Heads or Tails, gets going. It doesn't matter that they're in the middle of a parking lot filled with tailgaters. The challenges keep getting wilder and more daring. Next thing she knows, Tara is crossing lines she never imagined and experiencing things she didn't think possible for a 44-year-old married woman from the suburbs.

A weekend away can change everything. Tara and Mark will be tested like never before. Can their marriage ever be the same after all their limits are shattered? **Tara's Homecoming** is another pulse-pounding shared wife adventure from celebrated author Kirsten McCurran!

ORDER NOW!

about the author

“Kirsten McCurran” is the pen name of a wife and husband team exploring the sexy secrets of middle-class, suburban couples. This couple has their own dirty little secret: they have lots of fantasies about what all their friends and neighbors are up to behind closed doors, and they turn those sexy fantasies into the stories they love to share with the world. The Mrs. could be the sweet mom you see in the stands at the soccer game or the pretty woman at the supermarket you wonder about as she's squeezing the melons. The Mr. could be your kid's little league coach.

Most of their stories are about married women looking to bust out and explore their wild side, often with the encouragement of their husbands—and sometimes without it. The strength of the couple behind Kirsten McCurran is that husband and wife writing together can uniquely capture the feelings of both partners in their couples as they explore their most forbidden desires. The Mrs. is all about exploring stories of daring women of a certain age exploring their sexuality, and the Mr. captures the feelings of the men who love them.

Kirsten McCurran has written over 60 books, which can be found at major booksellers. You can reach Ms. McCurran by email at kmccurran@gmail.com.

If you'd like other ways to support Kirsten McCurran's writing, visit her website for links, books.kirstenmccurran.com.

